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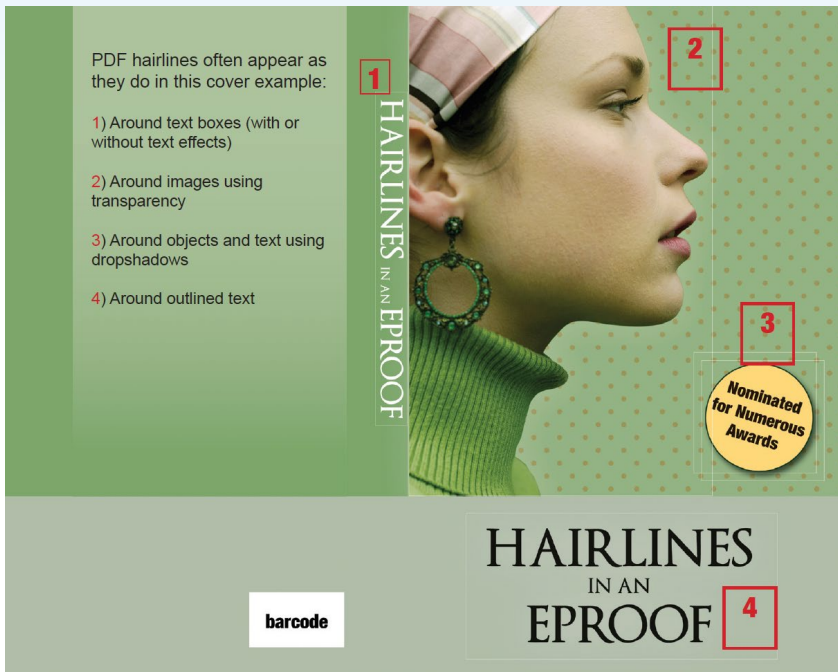
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Nobody told you this was coming.

You are standing at the beginning of your adult life in a world that offers everything except the truth you actually need.

This book is built on the Bible — not on opinions, not on trends, not on what sounds good at graduation.

It is a straight-talk guide through the questions that will define your life: who you are, who God is, how you treat people, and how you build something that lasts.

Thirteen chapters. One Foundation.

*“Choose for yourselves today
whom you will serve . . .
but as for me and my house,
we will serve the Lord.”*

JOSHUA 24:15

PAUL & PAM HAINLINE



YOUR NAME MEANS EVERYTHING: A GOOD NAME

+

YOUR
NAME
MEANS
EVERYTHING



A Good Name

*A Straight-Talk Guide for Young Men
Who Want to Matter*

*“The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom,
and the knowledge of the Holy One is understanding.”*

PROVERBS 9:10

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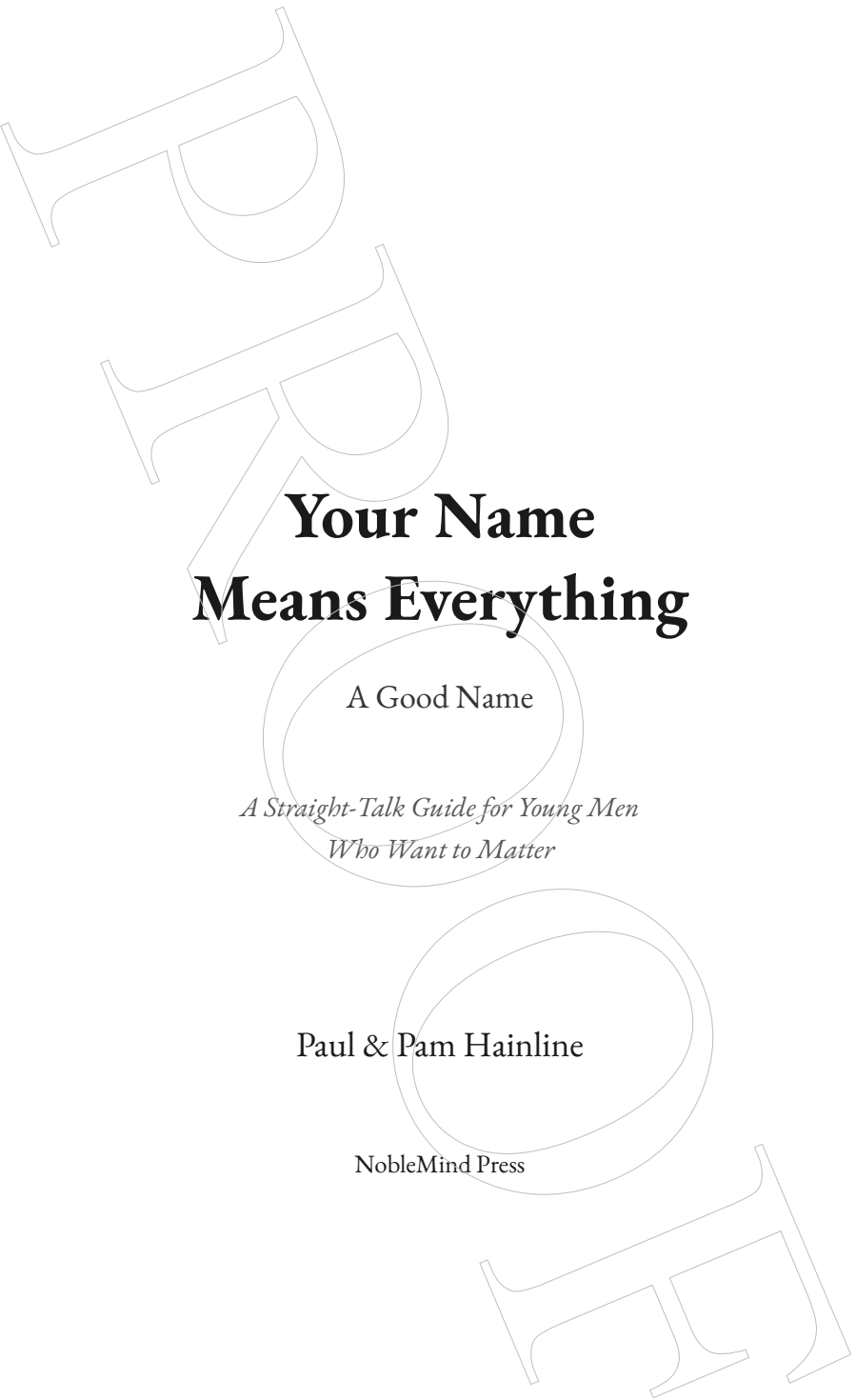
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— ◆ —
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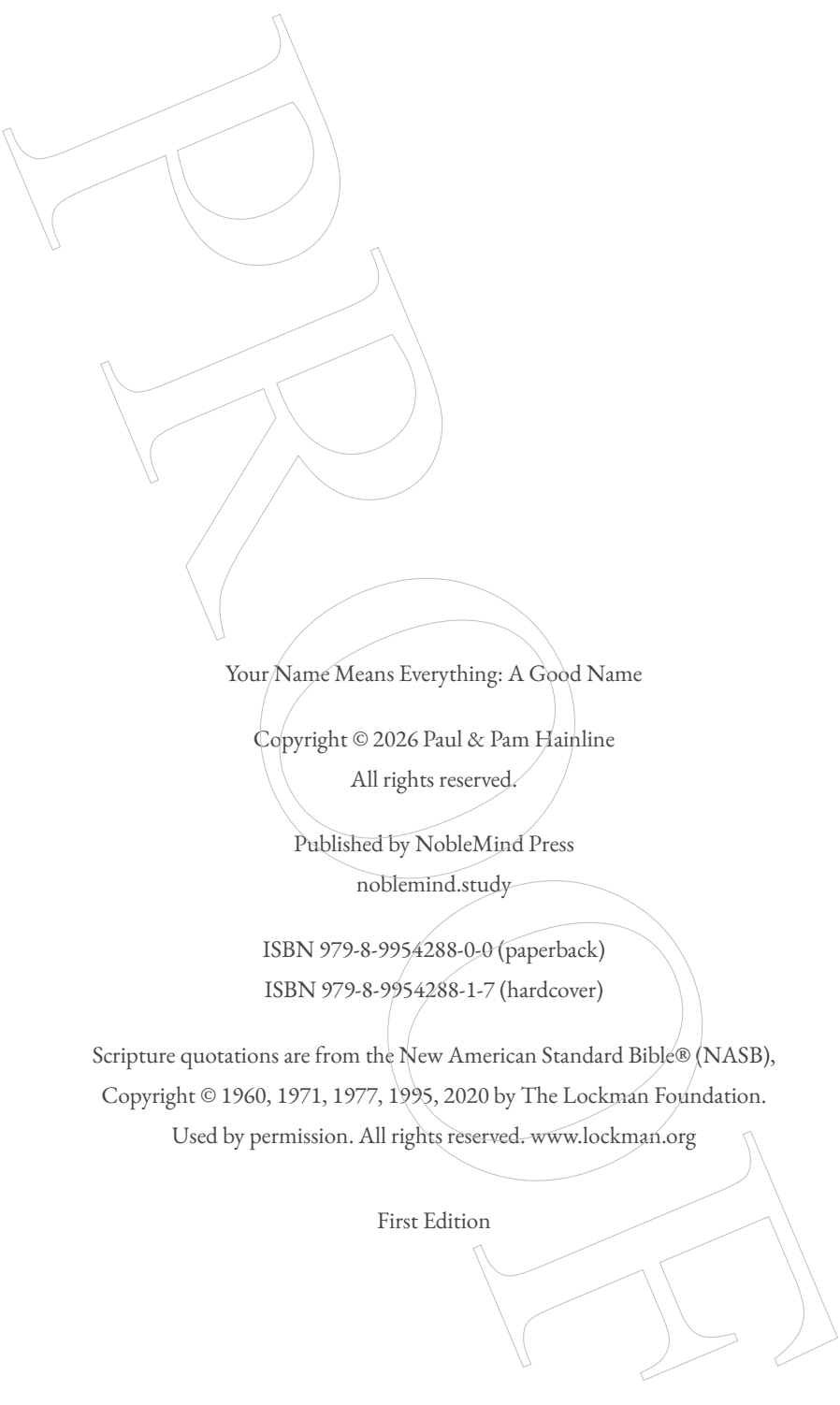
Your Name Means Everything

A Good Name

*A Straight-Talk Guide for Young Men
Who Want to Matter*

Paul & Pam Hainline

NobleMind Press



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First Edition

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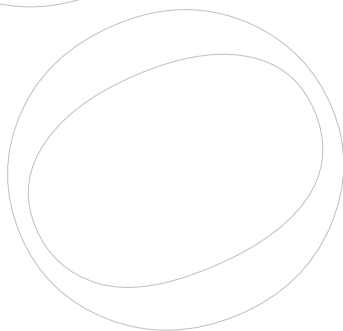
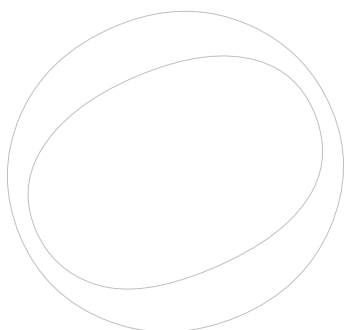
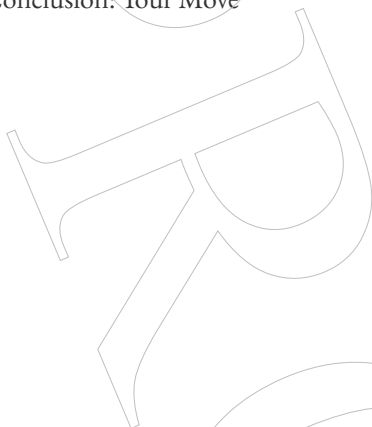
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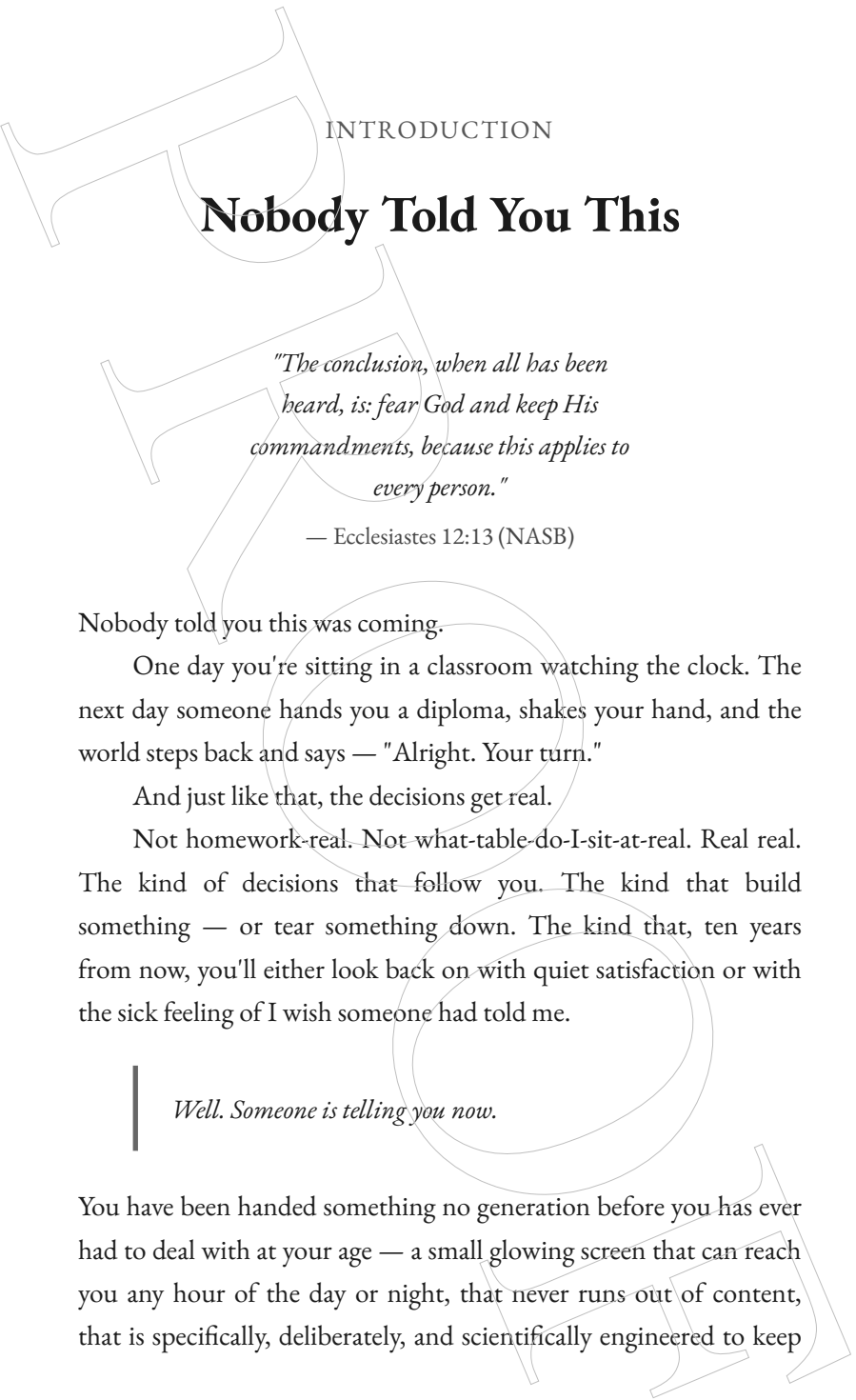
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INTRODUCTION

Nobody Told You This

"The conclusion, when all has been heard, is: fear God and keep His commandments, because this applies to every person."

— Ecclesiastes 12:13 (NASB)

Nobody told you this was coming.

One day you're sitting in a classroom watching the clock. The next day someone hands you a diploma, shakes your hand, and the world steps back and says — "Alright. Your turn."

And just like that, the decisions get real.

Not homework-real. Not what-table-do-I-sit-at-real. Real real. The kind of decisions that follow you. The kind that build something — or tear something down. The kind that, ten years from now, you'll either look back on with quiet satisfaction or with the sick feeling of I wish someone had told me.

| *Well. Someone is telling you now.*

You have been handed something no generation before you has ever had to deal with at your age — a small glowing screen that can reach you any hour of the day or night, that never runs out of content, that is specifically, deliberately, and scientifically engineered to keep

you looking at it. The people who built it are brilliant. Their entire business model depends on your attention. And they are very, very good at what they do.

Here is what that screen has cost you, and this isn't said to make you feel bad — it's said because it's true and you deserve to know it: it has shortened your ability to sit still with something difficult. It has trained you to expect the next thing before you've finished the current thing. It has fed you a thousand opinions and very little truth. And it has been doing this since you were old enough to hold it.

That is not your fault. But what you do about it from here — that part is on you.

This book is going to ask something of you that might feel harder than it sounds.

It is going to ask you to slow down.

Not forever. Not dramatically. But long enough to actually think. Long enough to read a passage of Scripture and sit with it instead of scrolling past it. Long enough to ask yourself hard questions and wait for honest answers.

If you can do that — and you can — what you'll find on the other side of that discipline is something the screen has never once been able to give you:

* * *

Wisdom.

Not information. Not opinions. Not highlights and hot takes.

Wisdom. The kind that tells you who to trust, how to treat people, what your life is actually for, and how to build something that lasts beyond you.

The only source of that wisdom is God. And He did not leave us without a Word.

This book is built on the Bible. Not on one denomination's interpretation of it. Not on what's popular or comfortable or easy to sell. On the text itself — what it actually says, to whom it was said, and what it means for a young man standing at the beginning of his life in the twenty-first century.

Some of what you read here will confirm what you already sense is true.

Some of it will challenge what you've been told — or what you've told yourself.

All of it is offered with one purpose: to help you become the man God designed you to be. Not a perfect man. Not a man who never fails. But a man of character. A man of his word. A man who knows his God, treats people with genuine respect, and understands that the decisions he makes at eighteen, nineteen, and twenty are laying a foundation — for better or worse — that the rest of his life will be built upon.

There is one verse that could serve as the compass for everything that follows. It was written by a man named Solomon —

the wisest man who ever lived — and he wrote it near the end of his life, after having tried nearly everything the world had to offer:

"The conclusion, when all has been heard, is: fear God and keep His commandments, because this applies to every person."

— Ecclesiastes 12:13 (NASB)

Every person. That includes you.

Not when you're older. Not when life settles down. Not after you've had your fun. **Now.** At the exact moment you're reading these words.

You don't have to have it all figured out. Nobody does at your age, and anyone who tells you otherwise is either lying or hasn't been tested yet.

But you do have to start.

- Start paying attention to the kind of man you're becoming.
- Start taking your name seriously.
- Start treating the people around you — especially the young women in your life — the way God says they deserve to be treated.
- Start spending more time with the Book that has the answers and less time with the screen that's selling you distractions.

This book will walk with you through all of it, one chapter at a time. No rush. No shame. Just straight talk from God's Word to a young man who matters more than he probably knows.

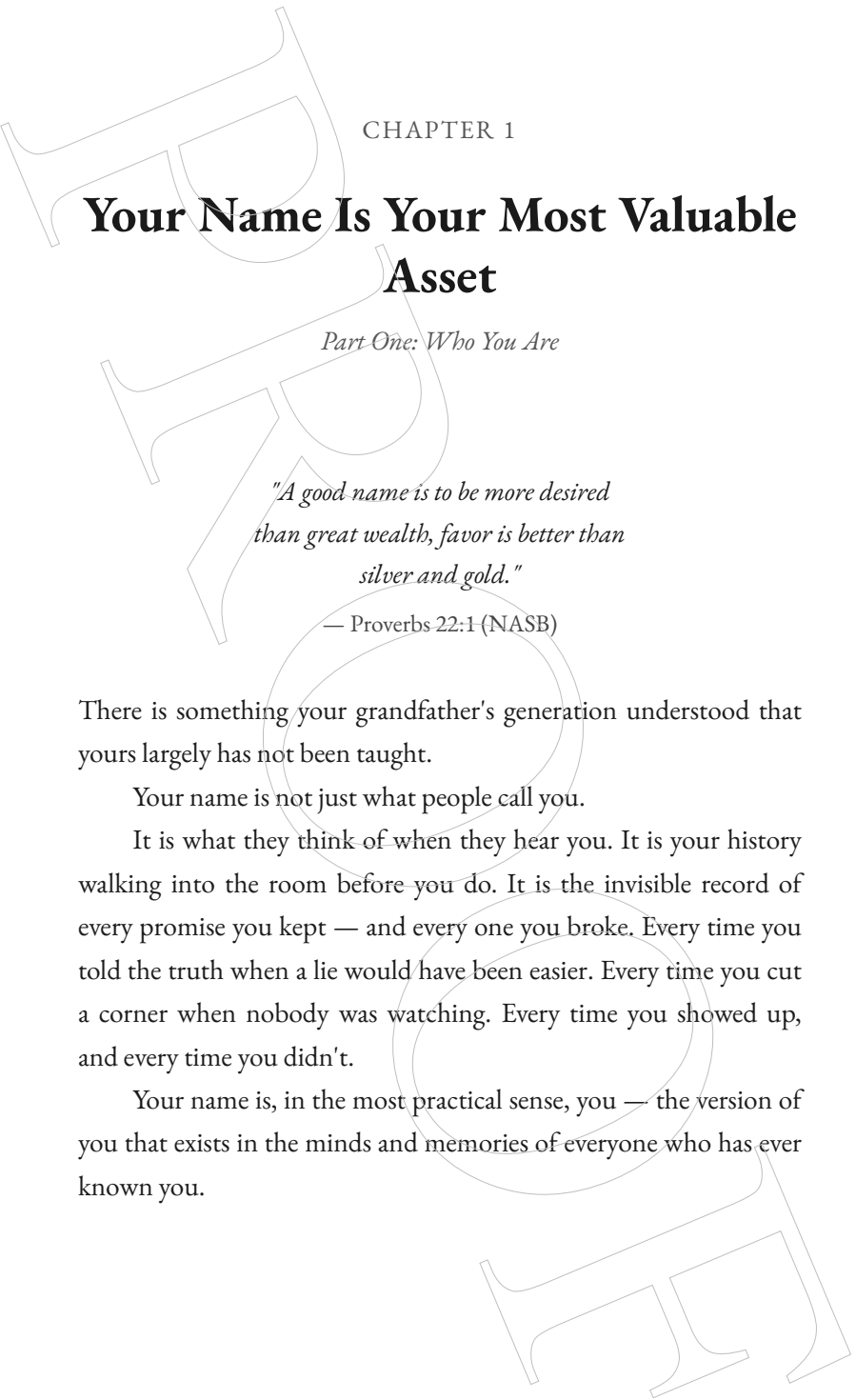
That young man is you.

Let's get started.

"The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is understanding."

— Proverbs 9:10 (NASB)

ROSE



CHAPTER 1

Your Name Is Your Most Valuable Asset

Part One: Who You Are

*"A good name is to be more desired
than great wealth, favor is better than
silver and gold."*

— Proverbs 22:1 (NASB)

There is something your grandfather's generation understood that yours largely has not been taught.

Your name is not just what people call you.

It is what they think of when they hear you. It is your history walking into the room before you do. It is the invisible record of every promise you kept — and every one you broke. Every time you told the truth when a lie would have been easier. Every time you cut a corner when nobody was watching. Every time you showed up, and every time you didn't.

Your name is, in the most practical sense, you — the version of you that exists in the minds and memories of everyone who has ever known you.

And right now, at the beginning of your adult life, you are writing the first chapters of what that name will mean.

* * *

What God Says About a Name

The wisest man who ever lived — a king named Solomon, who had wealth, power, pleasure, and achievement beyond anything most people can imagine — sat down late in his life and made a simple statement that cuts right through all of it:

"A good name is to be more desired than great wealth, favor is better than silver and gold."

— Proverbs 22:1 (NASB)

Read that again. He didn't say a good name is nice to have. He said it is more to be desired than great wealth. The man who had more wealth than almost anyone in history is telling you that your reputation is worth more than money.

Elsewhere, in the book of Ecclesiastes, he says it even more bluntly:

"A good name is better than a good ointment."

— Ecclesiastes 7:1 (NASB)

In Solomon's day, fragrant ointment was expensive. It was a luxury. A status symbol. He is saying your name — your character, your reputation — is worth more than the most valuable thing money can buy.

This is not a minor observation from a minor person. This is the concentrated wisdom of a man who tested everything life has to offer and reported back. When Solomon tells you something matters, you would be wise to listen.

* * *

Names Meant Something

Here is something that may surprise you about the Bible: in the ancient world, a name was not simply a label. It was a statement of identity. A declaration of character. A prophecy of destiny.

When a child was named in the Old Testament, that name was chosen with intention. It described who that person was, or who they were meant to become. And when God changed a person's name — which He did on some of the most significant occasions in all of Scripture — it wasn't a formality. It was a transformation.

Consider a few:

Abram — whose name meant "exalted father" — was a man who had no children and was nearly a hundred years old. God changed his name to **Abraham**, meaning "father of a multitude." Before a single descendant was born, God renamed him according to what He was about to do. The new name was a covenant. A promise spoken into his identity.

"No longer shall your name be called Abram, but your name shall be Abraham; for I have made you the father of a multitude of nations."

— Genesis 17:5 (NASB)

Jacob — whose name meant "supplanter" or "one who grabs the heel" — was a man who spent the first half of his life scheming and deceiving. He tricked his brother. He deceived his father. His name fit him like a glove. But after a long night of wrestling with God, everything changed. God looked at this broken, struggling man and gave him a new name:

Israel — meaning "one who strives with God" or "God prevails."

"Your name shall no longer be Jacob, but Israel; for you have striven with God and with men and have prevailed."

— Genesis 32:28 (NASB)

From that moment on, an entire nation would carry that name. Twelve tribes. Thousands of years of history. All flowing from the moment one man's name — and character — was changed by an encounter with the living God.

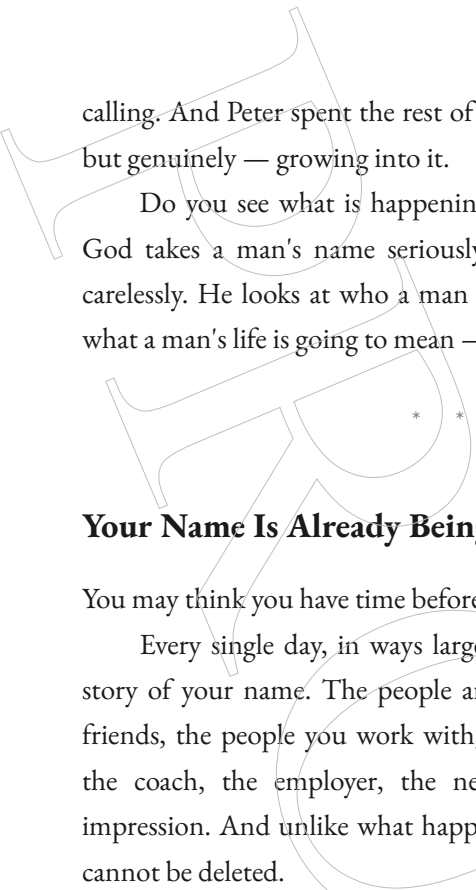
Simon — an ordinary fisherman, impulsive, rough around the edges, the kind of young man who would say the wrong thing at exactly the wrong moment — was looked at by Jesus Christ and immediately given a new name:

Peter. Which means "the rock."

"You are Simon the son of John; you shall be called Cephas" (which is translated Peter).

— John 1:42 (NASB)

At the time, nobody looking at Simon would have called him a rock. He was anything but. But Jesus was not describing who Simon was. He was declaring who Simon would become. The name was a



calling. And Peter spent the rest of his life — imperfectly, painfully, but genuinely — growing into it.

Do you see what is happening in all three of these accounts? God takes a man's name seriously. He does not hand them out carelessly. He looks at who a man is, who a man is becoming, and what a man's life is going to mean — and He names accordingly.

Your Name Is Already Being Written

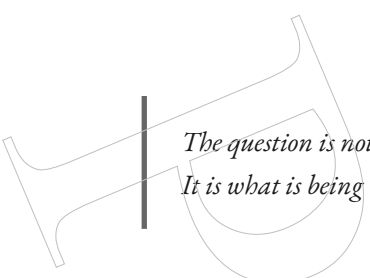
You may think you have time before any of this matters. You don't.

Every single day, in ways large and small, you are writing the story of your name. The people around you — your family, your friends, the people you work with, the young woman you talk to, the coach, the employer, the neighbor — are all forming an impression. And unlike what happens on a screen, that impression cannot be deleted.

Think about the people you already know. There are names you hear and immediately feel a sense of trust. And there are names you hear that make you instinctively a little more careful. You didn't sit down and analyze those people. You didn't study their resume. You accumulated experiences with them — or heard the experiences of people who know them — and your mind made a record.

Your name is being recorded in exactly the same way, right now, in the minds of everyone around you.





*The question is not whether your name is being written.
It is what is being written.*

* * *

What Actually Builds a Name

A good name is not built with big dramatic gestures. It is built in the small, ordinary, unspectacular moments that nobody photographs and nobody applauds.

It is built when you:

- Tell the truth when a lie would cost you nothing and the truth costs you something.
- Do the work even when no one is checking whether you did it.
- Keep your word to someone who couldn't do anything to you if you broke it.
- Show up on time, every time, because you said you would.
- Treat people the same way whether they can do something for you or not.
- Take responsibility for your mistakes instead of manufacturing reasons why it wasn't your fault.

None of these things will trend. None of them will get you followers. But every single one of them deposits something into the account of your name — and over time, that account either grows into something of real value, or it quietly empties out.

* * *

The Danger No One Is Warning You About

Here is something your grandfather's generation never had to worry about, but you do — and it needs to be said plainly:

Your digital life is part of your name now.

What you post. What you share. What you think is funny at seventeen. What you say in anger or in foolishness or just because everyone else is saying it. The photos, the comments, the groups you're part of, the things you laugh at publicly — all of it is being recorded. Permanently. And the world you are about to step into — employers, graduate schools, future relationships — has access to it.

The young man who spent years building a reputation for honesty and integrity in his community can undo years of that work with a single careless post. The digital world has no mercy and no short memory.

Solomon had no internet. But he understood the principle perfectly:

"Like a city that is broken into and without walls is a man who has no control over his spirit."

— Proverbs 25:28 (NASB)

A man without self-control has no protection. Not in Solomon's day, and not in yours. The platform changes. The principle does not.

Guard your name online with the same seriousness you would guard it in person. Because to the world you are about to walk into, there is no difference.

Growing Into Your Name

Here is the most hopeful thing in this entire chapter:

Your name is not finished yet.

Peter wasn't a rock when Jesus named him. Abraham didn't have a single child when God called him the father of nations. Jacob was a schemer and a deceiver before he became Israel.

If your name carries some weight it shouldn't, it is not too late to change what you're writing. The same God who looked at a rough fisherman and said "you shall be called the rock" is the same God who looks at you — exactly as you are — and sees what you could become.

But it starts with a decision. A daily decision. The decision to take your name seriously. To act like it matters. To understand that who you are when no one is watching is who you actually are — and that eventually, who you actually are becomes what everyone knows.

For Further Study

Look these passages up yourself. Open a Bible — not a phone app, a Bible — and read the surrounding context:

- **Proverbs 22:1**
- **Ecclesiastes 7:1**
- **Genesis 17:1-8** — God's covenant with Abraham
- **Genesis 32:22-32** — Jacob wrestles with God and is renamed
- **John 1:40-42** — Jesus names Peter

One Question to Sit With

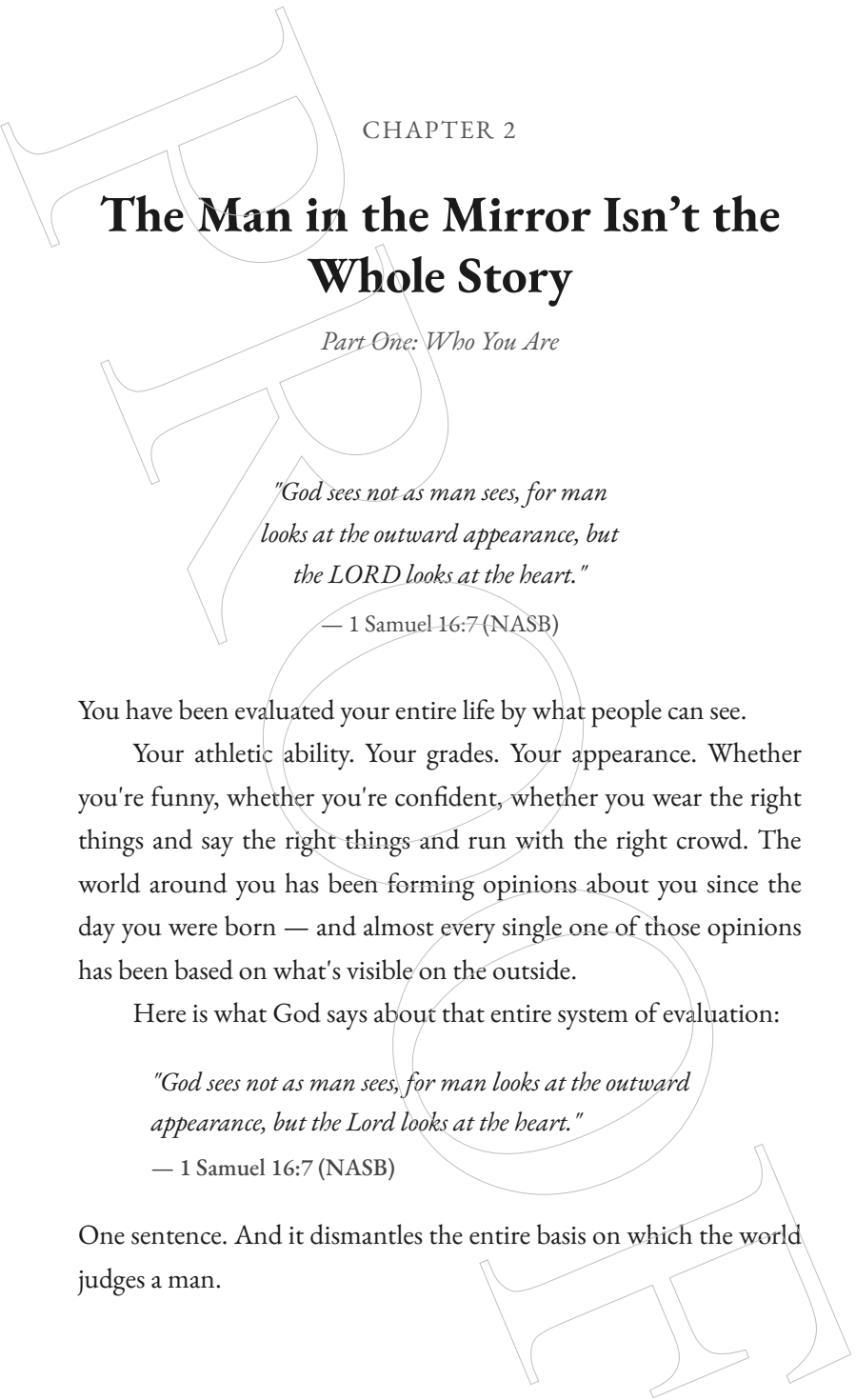
If everyone who knows you were asked to describe your name in three words — what would they say? And is that who you want to be?

One Thing to Do

Choose one area where your actions haven't matched the man you want to be known as. It doesn't have to be a big thing. Fix it quietly, without announcing it. That's where character gets built.

"A good name is to be more desired than great wealth; favor is better than silver and gold."

— Proverbs 22:1 (NASB)



CHAPTER 2

The Man in the Mirror Isn't the Whole Story

Part One: Who You Are

"God sees not as man sees, for man looks at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart."

— 1 Samuel 16:7 (NASB)

You have been evaluated your entire life by what people can see.

Your athletic ability. Your grades. Your appearance. Whether you're funny, whether you're confident, whether you wear the right things and say the right things and run with the right crowd. The world around you has been forming opinions about you since the day you were born — and almost every single one of those opinions has been based on what's visible on the outside.

Here is what God says about that entire system of evaluation:

"God sees not as man sees, for man looks at the outward appearance, but the Lord looks at the heart."

— 1 Samuel 16:7 (NASB)

One sentence. And it dismantles the entire basis on which the world judges a man.

God is not impressed by what you can perform. He is not moved by what you look like, how many people follow you, what your stats are, or how well you present yourself when the audience is watching. He looks straight past all of it — past the image you've carefully constructed, past the version of yourself you put forward for other people — and He looks directly at your heart.

That should be both sobering and freeing. Sobering, because you cannot fool Him. Freeing, because the things that impress Him are available to every man — regardless of talent, appearance, or circumstances.

* * *

The Story Behind the Verse

That verse in 1 Samuel 16 comes from one of the most instructive moments in all of Scripture, and it's worth understanding the full picture.

God had told the prophet Samuel to go to the house of a man named Jesse, because one of Jesse's sons was going to be the next king of Israel. Samuel arrived and Jesse began presenting his sons. The first one to walk in was a young man named Eliab — and the text tells us that Samuel looked at him and thought, surely this is the one God has chosen. Eliab was tall. He was impressive. He looked exactly like what a king should look like.

God immediately corrected Samuel. "Do not look at his appearance or at the height of his stature, because I have rejected him." And then God said the words that have echoed through every

generation since: "For God sees not as man sees, for man looks at the outward appearance, but the Lord looks at the heart."

Son after son walked past Samuel. Seven of Jesse's sons. Not one of them was chosen.

Finally Samuel asked — is this all of them? And Jesse said, well, there's the youngest. He's out in the field watching the sheep. Nobody had even thought to call him in. He wasn't in the room because nobody considered him a serious candidate.

That youngest son's name was David.

"Arise, anoint him; for this is he."

The man after God's own heart — the greatest king in Israel's history, the ancestor of Jesus Christ — was the one nobody thought to invite to the meeting. He was outside doing his job faithfully, with no audience, no applause, and no idea that everything was about to change.

That is not a coincidence. That is a pattern. God consistently chooses and uses men based on what is happening on the inside, not what is being performed on the outside.

* * *

What Is the Heart?

When the Bible talks about the heart, it is not talking about the organ in your chest. In both Hebrew and Greek, the heart refers to the inner man — the seat of your will, your thoughts, your desires,

your motives. It is the deepest, most private part of who you are.

The part that no one else can see.

It is who you are when you are completely alone.

It is the thought behind the action. The motive behind the gesture. The reason you actually did the thing you did — not the reason you told other people.

And God sees it with perfect clarity.

"For the word of God is living and active, and sharper than any two-edged sword, and piercing as far as the division of soul and spirit, of both joints and marrow, and able to judge the thoughts and intentions of the heart."

— Hebrews 4:12 (NASB)

That verse is describing what God's Word does when it works on a man. It goes beneath the surface. It gets past the performance. It exposes what is actually there — the thoughts, yes, but also the intentions. Not just what you did, but why you did it.

This is why two men can do the exact same thing and it can mean something completely different to God. One man gives generously because he genuinely loves people and wants to honor God. Another man gives generously because he wants to be seen giving generously. The action looks identical. The heart behind it is entirely different.

God knows which is which. Every time.

* * *

The Word Nobody Talks About Anymore

There is a word that used to be common in the vocabulary of men and has nearly disappeared from the modern world.

* * *

Integrity.

Integrity comes from the same root as the word integer — a whole number. A number that is not a fraction. Not divided. Complete.

A man of integrity is not divided. He is the same man in public that he is in private. He is the same man when the stakes are high as when no one is paying attention. He does not have a performance version of himself and a real version of himself. What you see is what you get, every time, in every room, under every kind of pressure.

The book of Proverbs describes this kind of man:

"A righteous man who walks in his integrity — how blessed are his sons after him."

— Proverbs 20:7 (NASB)

Notice something remarkable in that verse. It doesn't just say the man himself is blessed. It says his sons after him are blessed. Your integrity — or the lack of it — does not stay contained to your own life. It flows forward. Into the people who come after you. Into the family you will one day have. Into the young men who will watch you and learn from you what a man is supposed to look like.

You are already influencing someone younger than you. You may not be aware of it. But somewhere there is a boy who is

watching the way you carry yourself — and forming his idea of manhood based on what he sees.

What is he learning?

* * *

Who You Are When No One Is Watching

Here is a simple test for the condition of your heart. Ask yourself honestly:

How do I act when there is absolutely nothing to gain and no one to impress?

Do you work hard when the boss isn't looking — or just when he is? Do you treat people with respect when they can do nothing for you — or only when it benefits you? Do you keep your word when breaking it would have no consequences — or only when someone is holding you accountable?

These are not hypothetical questions. These are questions about the real you. The you that God sees at all times.

King David — the same young man God chose from a field, who nobody thought to invite into the room — wrote this:

"Search me, O God, and know my heart; try me and know my anxious thoughts; and see if there be any hurtful way in me, and lead me in the everlasting way."

— Psalm 139:23-24 (NASB)

That is a dangerous prayer. It is the prayer of a man who is willing to be examined. Who is not hiding behind a performance. Who understands that the condition of his heart matters more than the condition of his reputation.

Most men never pray that prayer because they're not sure they want the honest answer. But the men who can pray it — and mean it — are the men God can do something with.

The Slow Work of Building a Heart

Here is the truth that culture will never tell you: becoming a man of genuine character is slow work. It does not happen all at once. It does not happen in a weekend retreat or after a powerful sermon or because you felt something deeply in the moment.

It happens the way a muscle is built — through repeated effort, day after day, in the ordinary moments where nobody is watching and nothing dramatic is happening.

- Every time you choose honesty over convenience, your heart gets a little stronger in that direction.
- Every time you choose to serve someone with no expectation of anything in return, something grows in you.
- Every time you take responsibility for a failure instead of deflecting it, you are building something that will hold weight later.

And every time you do the opposite — every shortcut, every half-truth, every time you treat people differently based on what they can

do for you — something erodes. Quietly. Without fanfare. But it erodes.

The writer of Proverbs said it this way:

"Watch over your heart with all diligence, for from it flow the springs of life."

— Proverbs 4:23 (NASB)

Watch over it with all diligence. Not occasionally. Not when it's convenient. With all diligence — which means it requires active, intentional, ongoing attention.

Your heart is not something that takes care of itself. It requires tending. And the primary tool for tending it is the Word of God — which is why this book will keep returning to Scripture, and why the challenge at the end of every chapter asks you to open a Bible and spend time in it.

You cannot build a healthy heart on a diet of social media, entertainment, and peer pressure. It simply cannot be done. The inputs shape the heart, and the heart shapes the man.

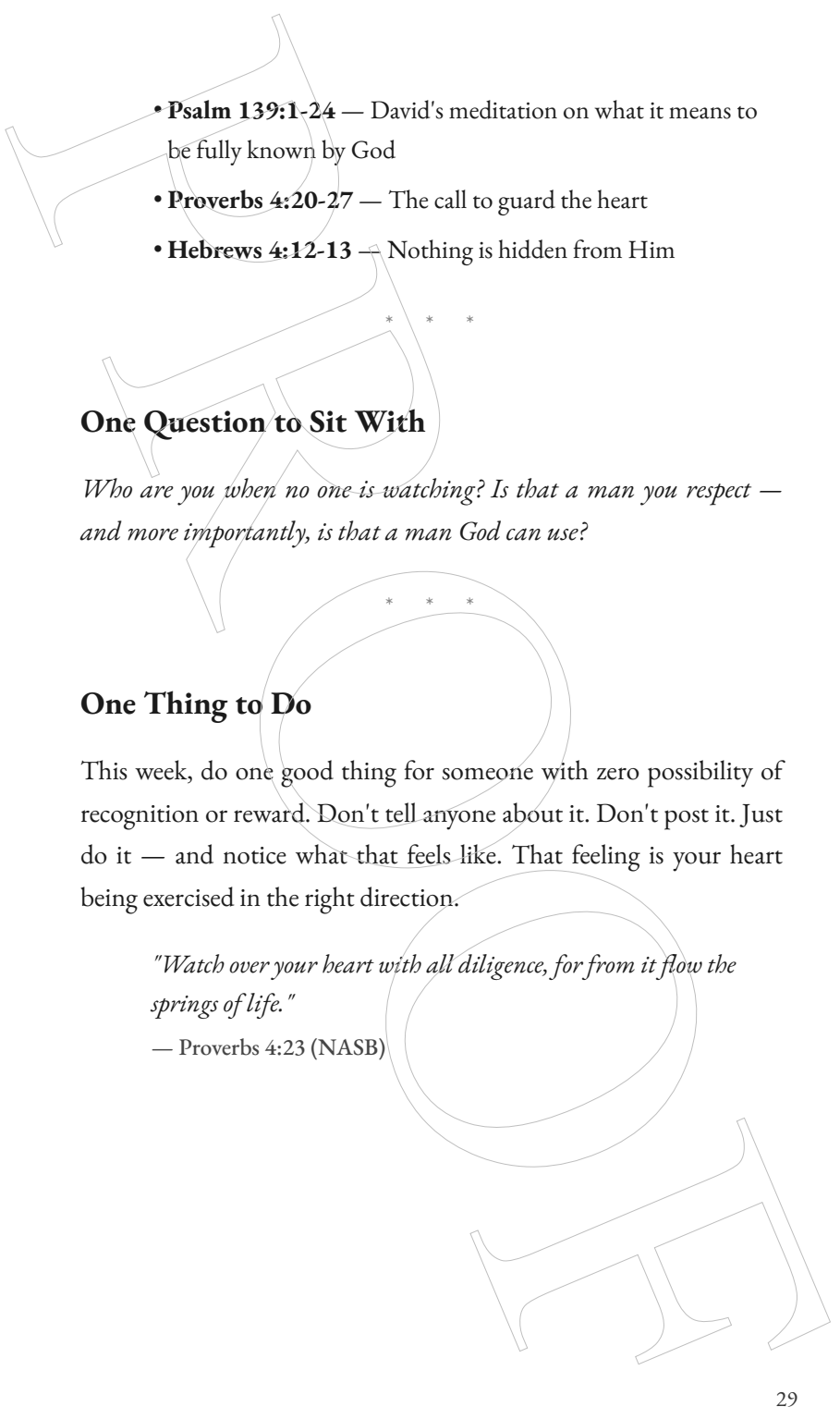
Choose your inputs carefully.

* * *

For Further Study

Read the whole account — not just the famous verse. Let the full story land.

• **1 Samuel 16:1-13** — The choosing of David

- 
- **Psalm 139:1-24** — David's meditation on what it means to be fully known by God
 - **Proverbs 4:20-27** — The call to guard the heart
 - **Hebrews 4:12-13** — Nothing is hidden from Him

* * *

One Question to Sit With

Who are you when no one is watching? Is that a man you respect — and more importantly, is that a man God can use?

* * *

One Thing to Do

This week, do one good thing for someone with zero possibility of recognition or reward. Don't tell anyone about it. Don't post it. Just do it — and notice what that feels like. That feeling is your heart being exercised in the right direction.

"Watch over your heart with all diligence, for from it flow the springs of life."

— Proverbs 4:23 (NASB)

CHAPTER 3

When Nobody's Watching Becomes When Everybody's Watching

Part One: Who You Are

*"But Daniel made up his mind that he
would not defile himself"*

— Daniel 1:8 (NASB)

There is a question that every young man will eventually have to answer. Not once, but repeatedly, throughout his entire life. And the way he answers it — especially early on, especially when the cost is real — will determine more about the shape of his character than almost anything else.

The question is this:

*Will you stand for what is right when standing costs
you something?*

Not when it's easy. Not when everyone around you agrees. Not when the crowd is on your side and the wind is at your back. But when the most powerful people in the room are telling you to sit down — and sitting down would be so much simpler.

There were four young men in the Bible who answered that question, and answered it well. Their story begins in the rubble of a conquered city and ends with kings bowing before the God of Israel. And it starts the same way most great stories of character start — not in a palace, not in a moment of high drama, but in an ordinary daily decision that nobody was paying much attention to.

Their names were Daniel, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah. You probably know the last three by the Babylonian names given to them by their captors: Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego.

* * *

Taken

To understand what these young men faced, you have to understand what had just happened to them.

Jerusalem had fallen. The Babylonian king Nebuchadnezzar — one of the most powerful rulers the ancient world had ever seen — had conquered Judah, destroyed the city, and taken its people captive. Among those taken were young men from the best families. Intelligent, capable, well-built young men who could be trained and used in service to the Babylonian court.

Daniel and his three friends were among them. Teenagers. Ripped from their homes, their families, their land, and everything familiar. Transported hundreds of miles to a foreign empire that worshipped foreign gods. And immediately enrolled in a three-year program designed — deliberately — to remake them. New names. New language. New education. New food. The Babylonians understood something that still holds true today: if you want to

reshape a man's identity, start with what he consumes and what he answers to.

These young men had every excuse in the world to go along with it. Nobody back home would ever know. They were far from their families, in the middle of a hostile empire, with no power and no protection. The path of least resistance was simply to blend in — absorb the new culture, eat the food, take the new name, and survive.

That is what most young men would have done.

It is not what Daniel did.

The First Test — The Quiet One

"But Daniel made up his mind that he would not defile himself with the king's choice food or with the wine which he drank; so he sought permission from the commander of the officials that he might not defile himself."

— Daniel 1:8 (NASB)

Notice what the text says. Daniel made up his mind. Before the food was ever placed in front of him. Before the pressure arrived. He had already decided, in the quiet of his own conviction, that there was a line he would not cross.

This is the part of the Daniel story that doesn't make it into most sermons. Everyone knows about the lion's den. Everyone knows about the fiery furnace. But both of those moments were

made possible by this one — this quiet, private, unglamorous decision about food.

Daniel didn't storm in and make a scene. He didn't lecture anyone. He went to the commander respectfully and asked for an alternative. He proposed a test — ten days of vegetables and water, and then compare the results. The commander agreed.

At the end of ten days, Daniel and his three friends looked healthier and better nourished than all the young men who had eaten the king's food.

"God gave them knowledge and intelligence in every branch of literature and wisdom; Daniel even understood all kinds of visions and dreams."

— Daniel 1:17 (NASB)

God honored the quiet faithfulness. He didn't honor it with a thunderclap or a vision or an angelic visitation. He honored it with wisdom. With favor. With the slow, steady fruit of a life that was keeping its convictions intact even when nobody was watching.

Here is what this means for you: the faithfulness that nobody sees is the foundation for the courage that everybody will eventually see. Daniel didn't become the man who survived the lion's den on the night he was thrown in. He became that man in the years of quiet daily faithfulness that preceded it.

Character is always built in private before it is tested in public.

* * *

The Second Test — The Furnace

Years passed. Daniel and his three friends served faithfully in the Babylonian court. They had risen in position, earned respect, and demonstrated the kind of wisdom and character that God had been building in them since those early days.

And then Nebuchadnezzar built a gold statue ninety feet tall and commanded everyone in the empire to bow down and worship it. The penalty for refusal was immediate and explicit:

"Whoever does not fall down and worship shall immediately be cast into the midst of a furnace of blazing fire."

— Daniel 3:6 (NASB)

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego refused.

They were brought before the king — furious, powerful, surrounded by all the authority of the greatest empire on earth — and they were given one more chance. Bow, or burn.

Their answer is one of the most remarkable statements of faith in all of Scripture:

"Our God whom we serve is able to deliver us from the furnace of blazing fire; and He will deliver us out of your hand, O king. But even if He does not, let it be known to you, O king, that we are not going to serve your gods or worship the golden image that you have set up."

— Daniel 3:17-18 (NASB)

Read those words carefully. They did not say God would deliver them. They said He was able to — and then they added four words that should stop every reader cold:

"But even if He does not."

They were not bargaining with God. They were not standing firm because they had a guarantee of rescue. They were standing firm because it was right — regardless of the outcome. Their obedience was not conditional on God's deliverance. Their faithfulness was not a transaction.

That is a level of conviction that cannot be manufactured in a moment of crisis. It can only come from years of smaller, quieter, private faithfulness — exactly the kind that started with a decision about food in a foreign palace when nobody important was watching.

They were thrown into the furnace. The fire was so hot it killed the soldiers who threw them in. And then Nebuchadnezzar leaped to his feet in astonishment:

"Look! I see four men loosed and walking about in the midst of the fire without harm, and the appearance of the fourth is like a son of the gods!"

— Daniel 3:25 (NASB)

They were not alone in the fire. They were never alone in the fire.

* * *

The Third Test — The Lions

Daniel continued to serve faithfully through multiple kingdoms — long after Nebuchadnezzar was gone, into the reign of the Medes

and Persians. He had become so trusted, so clearly exceptional, that the king was planning to set him over the entire empire.

Which is exactly why his enemies came after him.

They watched him. They looked for corruption, for misconduct, for any crack in his integrity. And they found nothing.

"...they could find no ground of accusation or evidence of corruption, inasmuch as he was faithful, and no negligence or corruption was to be found in him."

— Daniel 6:4 (NASB)

Think about what that means. These men were specifically, deliberately trying to find something wrong with Daniel — and they found nothing. His public life matched his private life. There was no gap between who he was in the palace and who he was when the doors were closed.

So they went after the one thing they knew they could trap him on: his faithfulness to God. They convinced the king to sign a law forbidding prayer to anyone except the king for thirty days. And then they waited.

"Now when Daniel knew that the document was signed, he entered his house (now in his roof chamber he had windows open toward Jerusalem); and he continued kneeling on his knees three times a day, praying and giving thanks before his God, as he had been doing previously."

— Daniel 6:10 (NASB)

As he had been doing previously. Daniel didn't heroically decide in that moment to be faithful. He simply continued doing what he had always done. The crisis didn't create his character. It revealed it.

He was thrown to the lions. And the next morning, when the king rushed to the den and called out — Daniel answered from inside:

"My God sent His angel and shut the lions' mouths and they have not harmed me, inasmuch as I was found innocent before Him."

— Daniel 6:22 (NASB)

* * *

What These Four Men Have to Say to You

You are not in Babylon. But you are living in a culture that is doing exactly what Babylon did — it is systematically trying to reshape your identity. New names, new values, new definitions of what a man is supposed to be, constant pressure to consume what everyone else is consuming and bow to what everyone else is bowing to.

And you will face your own versions of these tests. They won't come with a ninety-foot golden statue or a den of lions. They'll come in smaller, quieter, more ordinary packaging.

They'll come when your friends are looking at things online you know you shouldn't look at, and saying nothing would be so much easier than saying something. They'll come when telling the truth about something you did wrong will cost you, and a half-truth would slide right by. They'll come when everyone in the room bows — to the crowd, to the culture, to whatever the current pressure is — and you have to decide whether you're going to bow too.

What Daniel and his three friends show you is this: the man who stands in the big moment is the man who practiced standing in the small moments first. Nobody stumbles into that kind of

courage. It is built, day by day, decision by decision, in the ordinary faithfulness of a life lived before an audience of One.

Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego did not know there would be a fourth man in the fire with them. They only knew that they would not bow.

That was enough.

* * *

For Further Study

Read these accounts in full. They are gripping stories, and the details matter:

Daniel 1:1-21 — The first test; the decision about food

Daniel 3:1-30 — The furnace; "But even if He does not"

Daniel 6:1-28 — The lion's den; the life that had no gap in it



CHAPTER 4

You Were Made On Purpose, For a Purpose

Part One: Who You Are

*"Before I formed you in the womb I
knew you, and before you were born I
consecrated you"*

— Jeremiah 1:5 (NASB)

Somewhere along the way, the culture handed you a story about yourself.

It goes something like this: you are the product of random biological processes that nobody planned and nobody intended. You are here by accident. Your personality, your tendencies, your struggles — these are the result of genetics and environment and a long chain of events that had nothing to do with design. There is no blueprint. There is no designer. There is no purpose built into you that you didn't put there yourself.

And if that story is true, then nothing you do ultimately matters very much. You can construct your own meaning, chase your own goals, define yourself however you choose — but at the end of the day, you are a temporary arrangement of molecules on a small planet in an indifferent universe, and when you are gone, you are simply gone.

That is the story the modern world tells young men.

Here is what God says.

* * *

Before You Were Born

The prophet Jeremiah was a young man — probably a teenager — when God spoke to him. And the first thing God said to him was this:

"Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, and before you were born I consecrated you; I have appointed you a prophet to the nations."

— Jeremiah 1:5 (NASB)

Read that slowly. Three things happened before Jeremiah drew his first breath.

God formed him. Not passively, not accidentally — formed. The same word used in Genesis 2 when God formed Adam from the dust of the ground. Deliberate. Intentional. Hands-on.

God knew him. Not knew of him. Not knew about him. Knew him — personally, intimately, completely. Before a single cell had divided. Before his mother knew she was pregnant. God knew Jeremiah.

God consecrated him. Set him apart. Designated him for a specific purpose. Appointed him to a specific task.

Before Jeremiah had done a single thing — before he had succeeded or failed, impressed anyone or disappointed anyone,

developed a single talent or revealed a single flaw — God had already designed him, known him, and set him apart.

That is not the story of an accident. That is the story of a plan.

The Psalm That Should Change How You See Yourself

King David — the same young man we met in Chapter 2, chosen from a field because God saw his heart — wrote one of the most extraordinary descriptions of human life ever put into words. It is Psalm 139, and if you have never read it in full, that is your assignment this week.

But for now, consider these verses:

"For You formed my inward parts; You wove me in my mother's womb. I will give thanks to You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made; wonderful are Your works, and my soul knows it very well. My frame was not hidden from You, when I was made in secret, and skillfully wrought in the depths of the earth; Your eyes have seen my unformed substance; and in Your book were all written the days that were ordained for me, when as yet there was not one of them."

— Psalm 139:13-16 (NASB)

There is almost too much in those four verses to unpack fully, but stay with it.

"You formed my inward parts." The word translated "formed" here is the Hebrew word for a weaver — someone who works with threads, interlacing them with intention and skill. God did not assemble you carelessly. He wove you.

"I am fearfully and wonderfully made." The word "fearfully" here does not mean frightening. It means awe-inspiring. It means the work that went into making you is the kind of work that produces reverence in those who truly understand it. David is not being sentimental. He is making a theological statement: the complexity and intentionality of a human being, seen clearly, should produce awe.

"In Your book were all written the days that were ordained for me." Before you lived a single one of your days — God had already written them. Not in the sense that you have no choices or that nothing you do matters. But in the sense that you are not wandering through an empty universe with no map and no destination. You are a person with ordained days — days that God saw before you lived them.

That is not the biography of an accident. That is the biography of someone who was expected.

* * *

What This Means When Life Doesn't Feel That Way

Here is where honesty is required, because some young men reading this are carrying things that make all of this hard to believe.

Maybe your father wasn't around — and it is difficult to hear about a God who designed you when the man who helped create you couldn't stay.

Maybe you have been told, in ways spoken or unspoken, that you are not particularly valuable. That you are a burden, a problem, a disappointment. That you don't measure up.

Maybe you have made choices you are not proud of — and the idea that God designed you for a purpose feels like it belongs to someone else. Someone who has his act together. Someone who hasn't done what you have done.

Jeremiah himself struggled with this. When God told him he was consecrated as a prophet to the nations, Jeremiah's response was immediate and honest:

"Alas, Lord God! Behold, I do not know how to speak, because I am a youth."

— Jeremiah 1:6 (NASB)

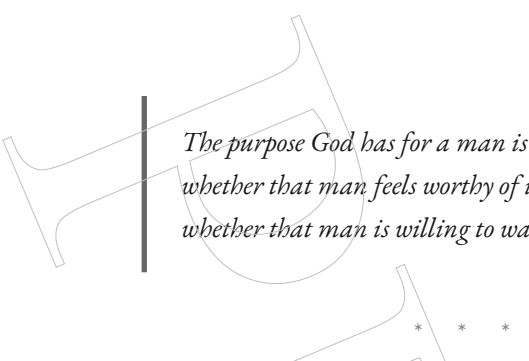
He didn't feel qualified. He didn't feel ready. He looked at himself and saw limitations where God saw a calling.

God's answer was not a pep talk. It was a correction:

"Do not say, 'I am a youth,' because everywhere I send you, you shall go, and all that I command you, you shall speak. Do not be afraid of them, for I am with you to deliver you."

— Jeremiah 1:7-8 (NASB)

God did not say — you are actually more talented than you think. He said — the issue of your adequacy is not the point. I am sending you. I am with you. Go.



The purpose God has for a man is not dependent on whether that man feels worthy of it. It is dependent on whether that man is willing to walk in it.

The Designer Left a Manual

Here is a simple truth that gets lost in a world full of noise:

When something is designed, the designer understands it better than anyone else. Better than the people who use it. Better than the critics who evaluate it. Better than the person who owns it.

If you want to understand what something is for — what it was built to do, how it works best, what will damage it, what will make it thrive — you go to the designer.

God designed you. And He did not leave you without a Word.

The Bible is not a collection of ancient rules invented by religious people trying to control other people. It is the instruction manual written by the One who made you — who knows exactly how you are wired, exactly what you need, exactly what will build you up and exactly what will tear you apart.

When the Bible says don't do a certain thing, it is not arbitrary restriction. It is the Designer telling you — that will damage what I built. When it says pursue a certain thing, it is the Designer telling you — that is what you were made for. That is where you will find what you are actually looking for.

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

— Psalm 119:105 (NASB)

A lamp doesn't illuminate everything at once. It illuminates the next step. And then the step after that. You don't have to see the end of the road to walk faithfully on it. You just have to stay close enough to the light to see where to put your foot next.

That is what this book is trying to help you do — stay close enough to God's Word that the next step is always lit.

Purpose Is Not a Feeling

One more thing before this chapter closes, and it is important.

A lot of young men are waiting to feel their purpose before they pursue it. They are waiting for clarity, for passion, for the unmistakable sense that this is what I am meant to do. And in the meantime, they drift. They fill the waiting with screens and distractions and the slow erosion of days that could have been building something.

Purpose, in the biblical sense, is not primarily a feeling. It is a direction.

The direction is this: know God, reflect His character, serve the people around you, and do your work with everything you have. That is true for every man, in every season, regardless of whether he has figured out his career path or his life plan or his unique calling.

Ecclesiastes 9:10 says it plainly:

"Whatever your hand finds to do, do it with all your might."

— Ecclesiastes 9:10 (NASB)

Not whatever your hand finds to do that excites you. Not whatever your hand finds to do that feels meaningful at the moment. Whatever your hand finds to do — do it fully. Completely. As unto God.

The young man who is faithful in the small, unglamorous, unexciting work in front of him right now is the young man who will be trusted with more. That is not just wisdom. That is the direct teaching of Jesus in the parable of the talents — Matthew 25:14-30 — which is worth reading this week.

You were made on purpose.

You were made for a purpose.

The first step toward that purpose is not finding it. It is being faithful right where you are.

* * *

For Further Study

Take your time with each of these. They reward slow reading.

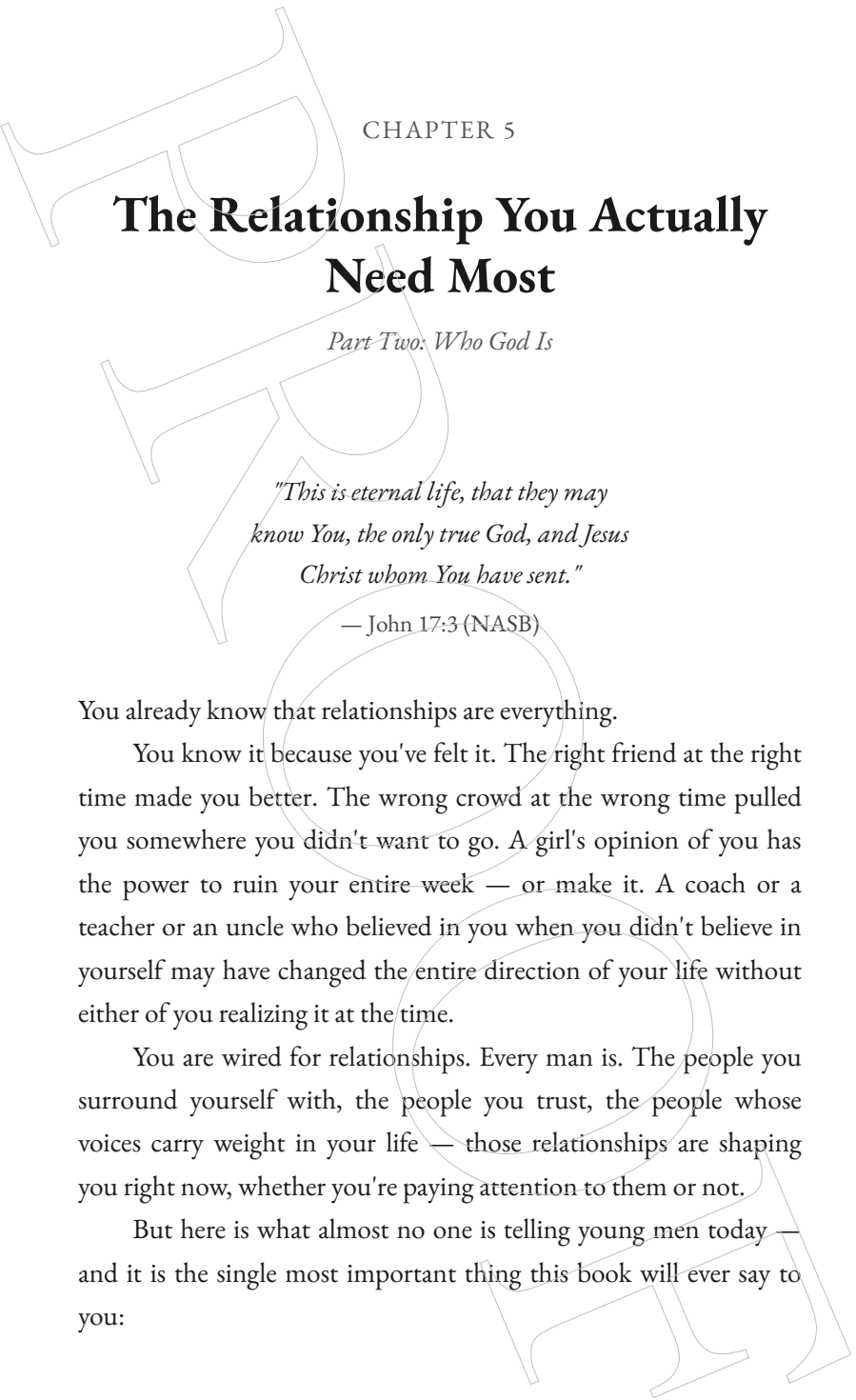
Jeremiah 1:4-10 — The full account of Jeremiah's calling

Psalms 139:1-24 — Read the whole psalm; let it land

Psalms 119:105 — The lamp and the path

Matthew 25:14-30 — The parable of the talents; faithfulness with what you are given

Ecclesiastes 9:10 — Whatever your hand finds to do



CHAPTER 5

The Relationship You Actually Need Most

Part Two: Who God Is

*"This is eternal life, that they may
know You, the only true God, and Jesus
Christ whom You have sent."*

— John 17:3 (NASB)

You already know that relationships are everything.

You know it because you've felt it. The right friend at the right time made you better. The wrong crowd at the wrong time pulled you somewhere you didn't want to go. A girl's opinion of you has the power to ruin your entire week — or make it. A coach or a teacher or an uncle who believed in you when you didn't believe in yourself may have changed the entire direction of your life without either of you realizing it at the time.

You are wired for relationships. Every man is. The people you surround yourself with, the people you trust, the people whose voices carry weight in your life — those relationships are shaping you right now, whether you're paying attention to them or not.

But here is what almost no one is telling young men today — and it is the single most important thing this book will ever say to you:

The most important relationship you will ever have is with God.

It is not with a woman. It is not with your best friend. It is not with a mentor, a father figure, or anyone else you can see with your eyes or reach with your phone.

And most young men your age are not even close to taking that seriously.

* * *

Why Most Young Men Walk Right Past God

Let's be honest about this, because you deserve honesty and not a sales pitch.

Most young men don't reject God because they've carefully examined the evidence and concluded He isn't real. Most young men ignore God for much simpler reasons:

They're busy. Life just got interesting. There are things to chase — freedom, girls, money, experiences, the feeling of finally being in charge of your own life. God feels like something that can wait. Something for later, when life slows down, when things get serious, when you're older and it starts to matter.

Or they associate God with religion — and religion, in their experience, has meant boring services, rules that seemed arbitrary, people who said one thing and lived another, or a version of church that felt more like performance than anything real. And they walked away not from God, but from a Christ-less caricature of Him that nobody explained to them honestly.

Or — and this is more common than most people will admit — they know, somewhere deep down, that if they actually took God seriously, they would have to change. And they're not ready to change. Not yet. Maybe not ever, if they can help it.

None of those reasons are stupid. They're human. But every single one of them carries a cost — and the cost is this:

A man who does not know God is building his entire life on his own understanding. His own strength. His own judgment. And if you've been alive long enough to be reading this book, you already know that your own understanding has limits. Your own strength runs out. Your own judgment gets it wrong — sometimes badly wrong — and there's no one above you to catch what you missed.

Solomon — the same man who told you in Chapter 1 that your name is worth more than wealth — also said this:

"Trust in the Lord with all your heart and do not lean on your own understanding. In all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."

— Proverbs 3:5-6 (NASB)

That is not a suggestion for weak men who can't handle life on their own. That is the wisest man in history telling you that your own understanding — no matter how smart you are — is not enough. It was never designed to be enough. You were never meant to navigate this life alone.

* * *

What God Is Actually Offering You

Here is where it gets important to clear away what you think you know and look at what the text actually says.

Most people — if they think about God at all — think of Him as a distant authority figure. A rule-maker. A cosmic judge who is mostly disappointed in you and keeping a detailed record of everything you've done wrong. Or they think of Him as a vague, feel-good idea — "the universe" or "a higher power" or "something out there" — with no real definition and no real demands.

The Bible presents neither of those pictures.

What the Bible actually presents is a God who created you, who knows you completely, who is not surprised by anything you've ever done, and who is offering you something that most young men never stop long enough to understand:

A relationship. A real one.

Not religion. Not ritual. Not a list of rules to follow so He won't be angry with you. A relationship — the kind where you actually know Him and He knows you, where you speak to Him and He speaks to you through His Word, where your life is built on a foundation that does not shift when everything around you does.

Jesus Himself defined what that relationship means, and He did it in the most startling terms:

"This is eternal life, that they may know You, the only true God, and Jesus Christ whom You have sent."

— John 17:3 (NASB)

Read that again. Jesus is not saying eternal life is something you receive after you die. He is saying eternal life *is* knowing God. The relationship itself is the life. It is not a ticket to somewhere. It is not a transaction — do enough good things and you get a reward. It is a living, ongoing, transformative connection between you and the Creator of everything that exists.

That is what is on the table. That is what most young men walk right past without ever realizing what they turned down.

* * *

Seek First

If the relationship with God is the most important one a man can have, then it raises an obvious question: where does it go in the priority list?

Jesus answered that directly:

"But seek first His kingdom and His righteousness, and all these things will be added to you."

— Matthew 6:33 (NASB)

The context of that verse matters. Jesus was speaking to people who were anxious — worried about food, clothing, the basic necessities of life. Real concerns. Legitimate concerns. And His answer was not "stop caring about those things." His answer was: get the order right.

Seek *first*. Not second. Not when you've got everything else figured out. Not after you've secured the career, the relationship, the financial stability, and the lifestyle. First. Before all of it.

That word — *first* — is doing all the work in the sentence. Jesus is not saying that God should be *part* of your life. He is saying God should be the foundation of it. Everything else — the job, the money, the relationships, the plans — gets built on top of that foundation. And when you get the order right, Jesus says, the other things find their proper place.

When you get the order wrong — when you put career first, or a relationship first, or money first, or yourself first — every single one of those things becomes an unstable foundation. They shift. They disappoint. They break under weight they were never designed to carry. Not because they're bad things, but because they were never meant to be the first thing.

A young man who seeks God first is not a man who ignores everything else. He is a man who has his priorities in the right order — and that changes everything about how he handles what comes next.

Prayer Is Not What You Think It Is

If God is offering a relationship, then prayer is simply communication within that relationship. That's it. That's what it is.

But most young men — if they're honest — think of prayer as one of two things: either a religious ritual that involves folding your hands and reciting words that don't feel real, or a last resort when everything has fallen apart and there's nowhere else to turn. The "foxhole prayer." The desperate, bargaining kind.

Neither of those is what Scripture describes.

Prayer, in the Bible, is a man talking to God. Honestly. Directly. About everything — the big things and the small things, the fears and the gratitude, the failures and the requests, the questions that don't have easy answers and the moments where you simply need to say thank You.

David — the same man you met in Chapter 2, the man after God's own heart — prayed constantly. And if you read his prayers in the Psalms, they are nothing like what most people imagine prayer to be. He was angry sometimes. Confused sometimes. Afraid. Honest to the point of being raw. He asked God hard questions. He told God exactly how he felt — even when how he felt wasn't particularly spiritual.

And God never once rebuked him for honesty. Not once. Consider what Paul wrote to the church at Philippi:

"Be anxious for nothing, but in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God. And the peace of God, which surpasses all comprehension, will guard your hearts and your minds in Christ Jesus."

— Philippians 4:6-7 (NASB)

In *everything*. Not just the emergencies. Not just the spiritual-sounding requests. Everything. That includes the job you're worried about, the decision you can't figure out, the relationship that's confusing you, and the fear you haven't told anyone else about.

And notice what Paul says the result is: peace. Not necessarily the answer you wanted. Not necessarily the removal of the problem. But a peace that surpasses comprehension — the kind that guards your heart and your mind when circumstances say you should be falling apart.

That is not weakness. A man who can bring his concerns to the God of the universe and walk away with a settled mind is not a weak man. He is a man who knows where his strength actually comes from.

Daniel — the man you read about in Chapter 3 — prayed three times a day. Every day. When it was easy and when it could have gotten him killed. His enemies knew that prayer was so central to who Daniel was that the only way to trap him was to make prayer illegal. And when they did, Daniel walked upstairs, opened his windows toward Jerusalem, and prayed anyway.

As he had been doing previously.

That is a man who understood that his relationship with God was not optional. It was the source of everything — his wisdom, his courage, his integrity, his ability to stand when everyone else bowed. Take that away, and the whole structure collapses.

* * *

What This Relationship Costs — and What It's Worth

Let's not pretend this is free. It isn't.

A real relationship with God will cost you something. It will cost you your illusion of total independence. It will cost you the comfort of doing whatever you want without answering to anyone. It will cost you some friendships that can't survive a man who starts

taking his faith seriously. It may cost you the approval of people whose approval you've been chasing your whole life.

But here is what the man who walks past God never realizes until it's too late:

Everything else costs more.

The man who builds his life on his own strength pays for it with anxiety — because deep down, he knows he's not strong enough. The man who chases money and status and approval pays for it with an emptiness that nothing he acquires ever quite fills. The man who avoids God because he doesn't want to change pays for it with a nagging sense that the life he's living is smaller than the one he was made for.

Jesus said it as plainly as it can be said:

"For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world, and forfeit his soul?"

— Mark 8:36 (NASB)

You can have everything the world says matters and still lose the thing that matters most. Men do it every day. Successful men. Wealthy men. Men who look like they have it all together from the outside and who are quietly hollow on the inside.

You don't have to be one of them.

The relationship is there. It has been there since before you were born. The God who made you has not lost interest in you. He is not waiting for you to clean yourself up before He'll talk to you.

He is not sitting at a distance with His arms crossed, waiting for you to earn His attention.

He is near. He has spoken — and His Word is sitting within reach of you right now.

The only question is whether you'll seek Him. And whether you'll seek Him first.

* * *

For Further Study

These passages will take you deeper into what this chapter only introduced. Read them slowly, and read the verses around them:

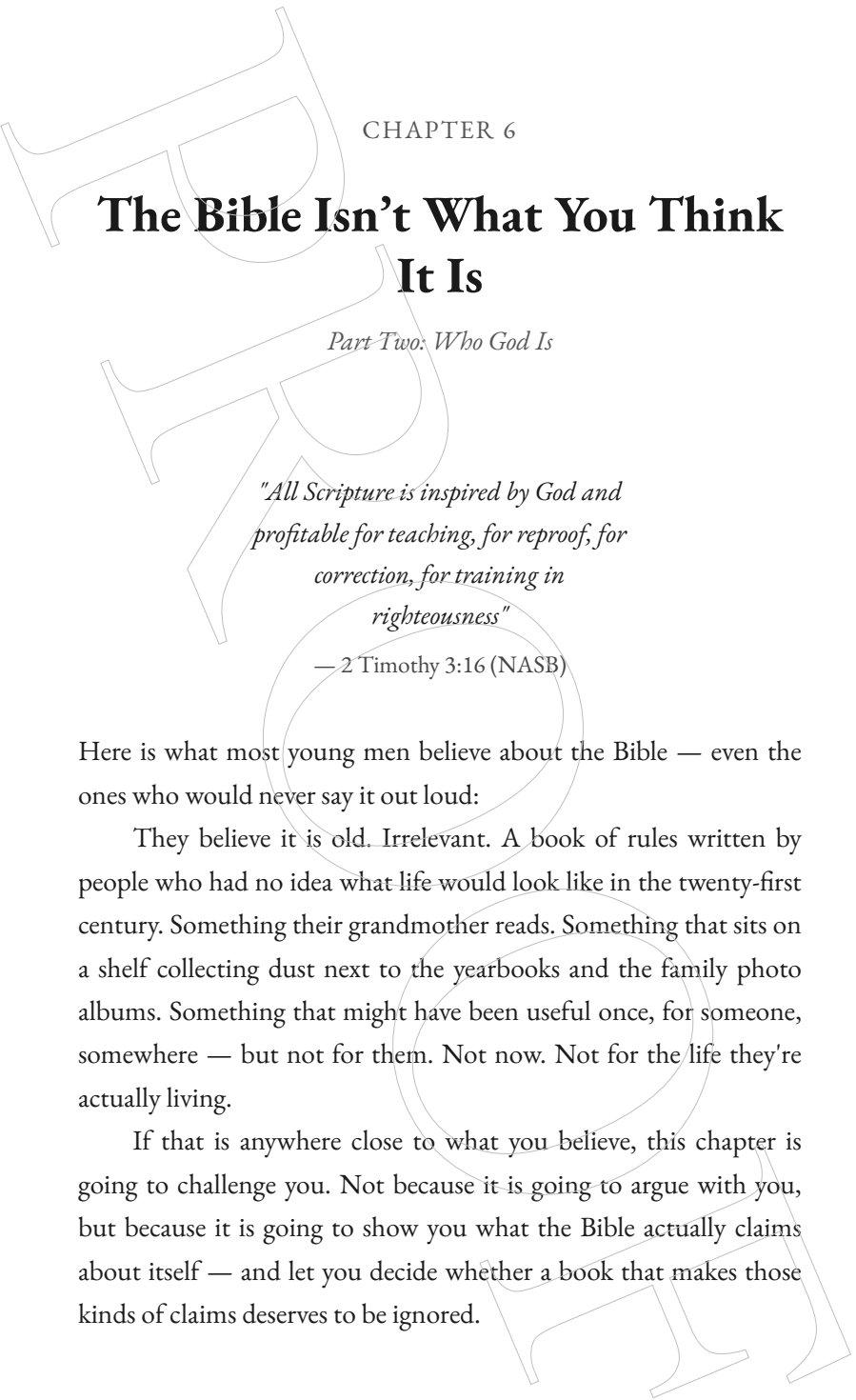
Proverbs 3:5-6 — Trust in the Lord, not your own understanding

John 17:1-5 — Jesus' prayer to the Father; what eternal life actually means

Matthew 6:25-34 — The full context of "seek first"; Jesus on anxiety and priorities

Philippians 4:4-9 — Prayer, peace, and what to fill your mind with

James 4:8 — "Draw near to God and He will draw near to you"



CHAPTER 6

The Bible Isn't What You Think It Is

Part Two: Who God Is

*"All Scripture is inspired by God and
profitable for teaching, for reproof, for
correction, for training in
righteousness"*

— 2 Timothy 3:16 (NASB)

Here is what most young men believe about the Bible — even the ones who would never say it out loud:

They believe it is old. Irrelevant. A book of rules written by people who had no idea what life would look like in the twenty-first century. Something their grandmother reads. Something that sits on a shelf collecting dust next to the yearbooks and the family photo albums. Something that might have been useful once, for someone, somewhere — but not for them. Not now. Not for the life they're actually living.

If that is anywhere close to what you believe, this chapter is going to challenge you. Not because it is going to argue with you, but because it is going to show you what the Bible actually claims about itself — and let you decide whether a book that makes those kinds of claims deserves to be ignored.

Because here is the truth: most people who dismiss the Bible have never seriously read it. They have an opinion about it. They have heard things about it. They may have sat through readings of it in a church service they didn't want to be at. But they have never actually opened it, studied it, and let it speak for itself.

You are not going to make that mistake.

* * *

It Is Not a Rule Book

Let's start by clearing away the most common misunderstanding, because it is the one that keeps more young men away from the Bible than almost anything else.

The Bible is not primarily a rule book.

Yes, it contains commands. Yes, God tells His people how to live. But if you think the Bible is just a list of things you can't do — a collection of ancient restrictions designed to take the fun out of life — you have been handed a Christ-less caricature of something far bigger and far more powerful than a set of regulations.

The Bible is a story. One story. A story that begins with the creation of everything that exists, moves through the fall of mankind, follows God's relentless pursuit of a people who kept turning away from Him, and arrives at a moment in history where God Himself entered the world in human flesh to do for man what man could never do for himself.

It is a story about rescue. About a God who refuses to give up on the people He made — even when those people give up on Him.

And the reason it contains commands is not because God is controlling. It is because He knows how life works. He designed it. The instructions aren't restrictions — they are the Creator telling you how the thing He built is supposed to function. Ignore them and the gears grind. Follow them and something works the way it was always meant to.

You would not buy a truck and then refuse to read the manual because you resented being told what kind of oil to put in the engine. That would not be freedom. That would be foolishness — and an expensive repair bill.

The Bible is not trying to take something from you. It is trying to give you something — the knowledge of how to live a life that actually holds together.

* * *

What the Bible Claims About Itself

Here is where it gets serious. Because the Bible does not present itself as a collection of helpful suggestions from well-meaning religious people. It makes a claim that is either the most important truth in the world or the most audacious lie ever told.

It claims to be the Word of God.

Paul, writing to a young man named Timothy — a man not much older than you — put it this way:

"All Scripture is inspired by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in righteousness; so that the man of God may be adequate, equipped for every good work."

— 2 Timothy 3:16–17 (NASB)

That phrase — "inspired by God" — translates a Greek word, *theopneustos*, that literally means "God-breathed." Paul is not saying that the men who wrote Scripture were inspired the way a poet is inspired by a sunset. He is saying that the words of Scripture originated with God. They carry His authority. They are His communication to mankind, delivered through human authors but sourced in the mind of God Himself.

Peter said the same thing in different words:

"But know this first of all, that no prophecy of Scripture is a matter of one's own interpretation, for no prophecy was ever made by an act of human will, but men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God."

— 2 Peter 1:20–21 (NASB)

Men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God. Not from their own opinions. Not from their own cultural assumptions. Not from their own agenda. From God.

Now — you have to decide what to do with that claim. You can accept it or reject it. But what you cannot honestly do is pretend the claim was never made. The Bible does not ask to be treated as one voice among many. It does not present itself as a helpful resource you can take or leave. It presents itself as the authoritative

Word of the Creator of the universe — and it asks to be received on those terms.

* * *

A Book Like No Other

If someone told you there was a book written over a span of roughly fifteen hundred years, by approximately forty different authors — kings, shepherds, fishermen, doctors, tax collectors, prophets, and prisoners — on three different continents, in three different languages, and the entire thing told one unified, coherent story from beginning to end without contradiction — you would say that was impossible.

And you would be right. It is impossible — unless something beyond human effort was holding it together.

That is exactly what the Bible is.

Moses wrote the first five books roughly fourteen hundred years before Christ. John wrote the last book — Revelation — near the end of the first century. Between those two points, dozens of authors from radically different backgrounds, cultures, and centuries each contributed a piece to a single, unfolding story that none of them could have coordinated on their own.

And the story holds together. The promises made in Genesis are fulfilled in the Gospels. The patterns established in Exodus are echoed in Revelation. The prophecies spoken by Isaiah hundreds of

years before Jesus was born describe His life, His death, and His purpose with a specificity that cannot be explained by coincidence.

This is not a book that was assembled by a committee. It is a book that was orchestrated by a mind far larger than any human mind — and the unity of it is one of the strongest pieces of evidence that the claim it makes about itself is true.

* * *

Living and Active

In Chapter 2, you read a verse from the book of Hebrews. It is worth returning to here, because it says something about the Bible that no other book in history can honestly claim:

"For the word of God is living and active, and sharper than any two-edged sword, and piercing as far as the division of soul and spirit, of both joints and marrow, and able to judge the thoughts and intentions of the heart."

— Hebrews 4:12 (NASB)

Living and active. Not "was living" — *is* living. The writer of Hebrews is claiming that this book is not dead text. It is not a historical artifact. It is alive — and it does something to the person who reads it. It pierces. It divides. It gets underneath the surface of who you are and exposes what is actually there.

You have read thousands of things in your life. Textbooks, articles, social media posts, messages from friends. Some of them informed you. Some of them entertained you. None of them — not

one — claimed to be able to look inside you and judge the thoughts and intentions of your heart.

The Bible makes that claim. And the millions of men and women across two thousand years who have opened it honestly will tell you the same thing: it delivers on it.

There is a reason this book has survived every empire that tried to destroy it, every movement that tried to discredit it, and every generation that tried to ignore it. It is still here. It is still being read. It is still changing lives. And the explanation for that staying power is found in one of the oldest promises in all of Scripture:

"The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God stands forever."

— Isaiah 40:8 (NASB)

Jesus Himself said it even more directly:

"Heaven and earth will pass away, but My words will not pass away."

— Matthew 24:35 (NASB)

Every other book you own will eventually be forgotten. This one will not. The question is not whether the Bible will endure. It has already answered that. The question is whether you will take it seriously while you still have time to let it shape who you become.

* * *

How to Actually Read It

Here is where most young men — even the ones who decide the Bible might be worth their time — go wrong. They don't know how to read it.

They open it at random, read a verse, try to figure out what it means to them personally, and walk away confused or unimpressed. Or they start at Genesis, make it through creation and the flood, and stall somewhere in Leviticus when it starts talking about sacrificial laws they don't understand. Or they read a passage someone posted on social media, stripped of all its context, and form an opinion about the Bible based on a fragment torn from its surroundings.

None of that is Bible study. That is the equivalent of opening a novel to page 247, reading one paragraph, and concluding the story doesn't make sense.

Here is how to actually read it:

Start with context. Every passage in the Bible was written by a specific person, to a specific audience, under specific circumstances. Before you ask what a passage means, ask what it says — and to whom it was said. A command given to Moses under the Law of the Old Testament is not the same as an instruction given by Paul to the church under the New Testament. Both are Scripture. Both are valuable. But they function differently in God's unfolding plan, and reading them without that distinction will lead to confusion.

Read what comes before and after. A single verse pulled out of its surrounding text can be made to say almost anything. Entire false teachings have been built on verses ripped from context. When you read a verse, read the chapter, understand where it sits in the

book. Let the Bible interpret the Bible — because Scripture never contradicts itself when you let the full picture come into focus.

Let clear passages explain difficult ones. There are passages in the Bible that are genuinely difficult. Faithful, honest students of Scripture have wrestled with them for centuries. When you encounter one, don't panic — and don't twist it to fit what you already believe. Instead, look for what the rest of Scripture says on the same subject. The clear passages will illuminate the difficult ones if you are patient enough to let them.

And read it with a Bible in your hands. Not a phone app with notifications buzzing every thirty seconds. Not a screen that is three swipes away from everything designed to pull you away from focused thought. A physical Bible, open on a table, with nothing between you and the text. That one change — the simple act of removing the digital noise — will do more for your ability to hear what God is saying than almost any other single decision you can make.

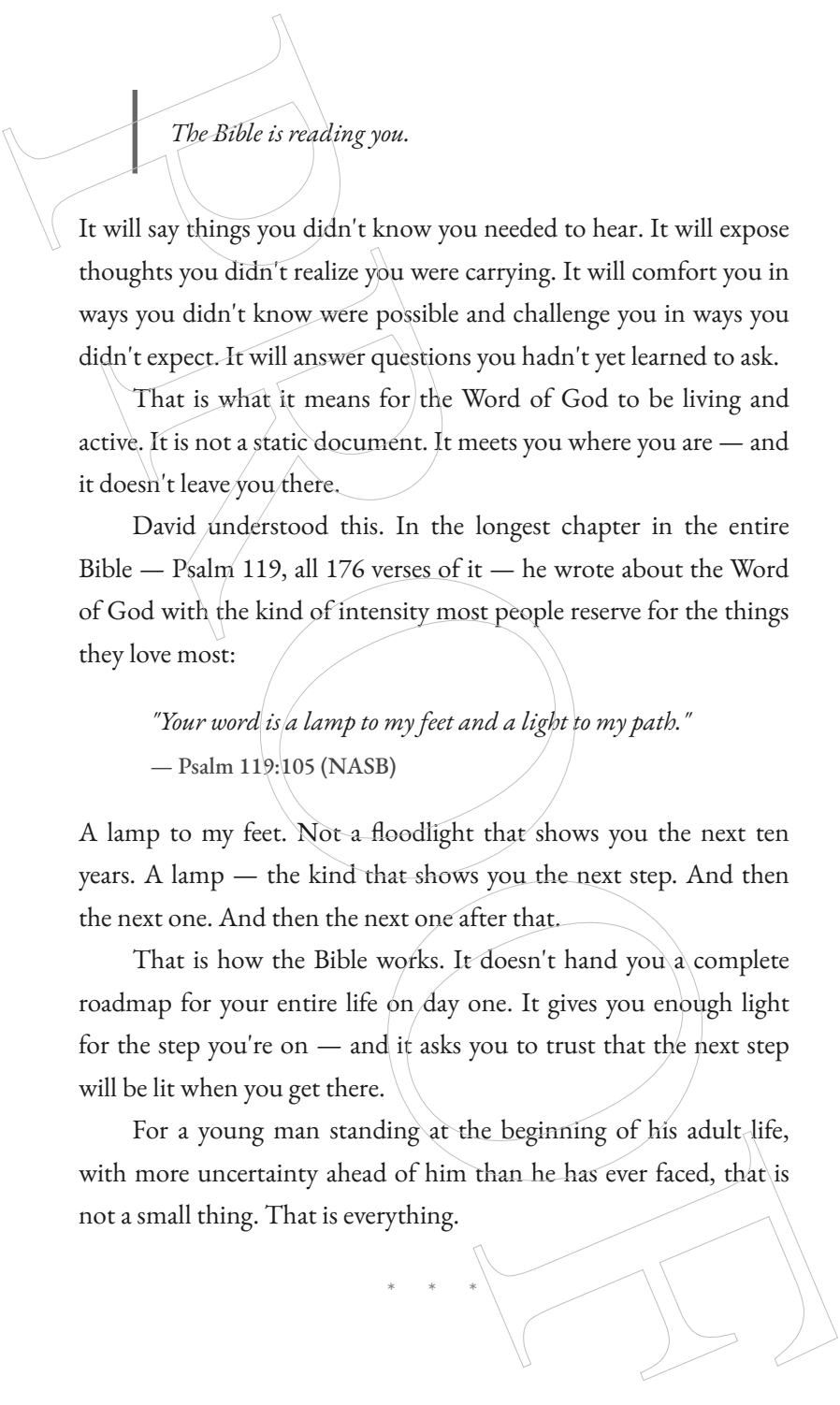
* * *

The Book That Reads You

Here is the part that will surprise you — and it is the part that keeps people coming back to this book for their entire lives.

You will sit down to read the Bible. You will bring your questions, your doubts, your circumstances, your struggles. You will open it looking for answers.

And somewhere in the process, something will shift. You will realize that you are not just reading the Bible.



The Bible is reading you.

It will say things you didn't know you needed to hear. It will expose thoughts you didn't realize you were carrying. It will comfort you in ways you didn't know were possible and challenge you in ways you didn't expect. It will answer questions you hadn't yet learned to ask.

That is what it means for the Word of God to be living and active. It is not a static document. It meets you where you are — and it doesn't leave you there.

David understood this. In the longest chapter in the entire Bible — Psalm 119, all 176 verses of it — he wrote about the Word of God with the kind of intensity most people reserve for the things they love most:

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

— Psalm 119:105 (NASB)

A lamp to my feet. Not a floodlight that shows you the next ten years. A lamp — the kind that shows you the next step. And then the next one. And then the next one after that.

That is how the Bible works. It doesn't hand you a complete roadmap for your entire life on day one. It gives you enough light for the step you're on — and it asks you to trust that the next step will be lit when you get there.

For a young man standing at the beginning of his adult life, with more uncertainty ahead of him than he has ever faced, that is not a small thing. That is everything.

* * *

For Further Study

These passages say what the Bible claims about itself. Read them — and let the text make its own case:

- 2 Timothy 3:14–17 — All Scripture is God-breathed
- 2 Peter 1:19–21 — Men spoke from God, moved by the Holy Spirit
- Psalm 119:97–112 — What it looks like to love the Word of God
- Hebrews 4:12–13 — The Word that sees into the heart
- Isaiah 40:6–8 — Everything else fades; God's Word stands

One Thing to Do

Get a Bible this week. A physical one. If you don't own one, find one — a church will give you one, or someone in your life has one they'll hand you without making a scene about it. Open the Gospel of John — the fourth book of the New Testament — and read the first chapter. Just one chapter. No phone nearby. See what happens.

"Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path."

— Psalm 119:105 (NASB)

CHAPTER 7

Putting Down the Phone Long Enough to Hear Something True

Part Two: Who God Is

"Be still, and know that I am God"

— Psalm 46:10 (NASB)

You are holding something in your pocket right now — or within arm's reach — that is more powerful than anything any previous generation of young men has ever had to deal with.

It connects you to every person you know. It gives you access to more information than entire civilizations possessed. It entertains you, informs you, tracks you, listens to you, and learns what keeps you looking at it so it can keep you looking at it longer.

And it is costing you more than you realize.

This is not a chapter about how technology is evil. It is not a lecture from someone who doesn't understand your world. Technology is a tool, and tools are not moral in themselves — a hammer can build a house or break a window. The question is never whether the tool exists. The question is what it is doing to the man who uses it.

And if you are honest — genuinely, painfully honest — you already know the answer.

* * *

What the Screen Has Taken

The introduction to this book said something to you that is worth repeating here, because you are further into these pages now and perhaps more willing to hear it:

That phone has shortened your ability to sit still with something difficult. It has trained you to expect the next thing before you've finished the current thing. It has given you the illusion of connection while slowly starving you of the real thing.

Those are not opinions. Those are observable realities, and you can test them yourself.

Try to sit in a room with no screen, no music, no noise — just silence — for thirty minutes. Not meditating. Not sleeping. Just sitting with your own thoughts, in quiet, with nothing to reach for.

If that sounds easy, try it. If it sounds unbearable — that reaction itself is the evidence.

Something has been taken from your generation that previous generations had by default: the ability to be still. The ability to sit with a single thought long enough for it to take root. The ability to hear a quiet voice — your own conscience, the voice of wisdom, the voice of God Himself — over the constant roar of content, notification, distraction, and noise.

And here is what makes that loss so dangerous: almost everything God does in a man's life requires the very thing the screen is destroying.

* * *

God Speaks in the Quiet

There is a moment in the life of the prophet Elijah that every young man needs to understand.

Elijah was running. He had just experienced one of the most dramatic victories in all of Scripture — a confrontation with 450 prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel, where God answered with fire from heaven. It was the kind of moment that should have settled his faith for the rest of his life.

And yet, within days, he was exhausted, afraid, and alone in the wilderness. He had run from a death threat by Queen Jezebel, and he was so low that he asked God to let him die. One of the greatest prophets who ever lived, sitting under a tree, asking for it to be over.

God did not scold him. He fed him. He let him rest. And then He brought him to a mountain and said something that changed everything:

"So He said, 'Go forth and stand on the mountain before the Lord.' And behold, the Lord was passing by! And a great and strong wind was rending the mountains and breaking in pieces the rocks before the Lord; but the Lord was not in the wind. And after the wind an earthquake, but the Lord was not in the earthquake. After the earthquake a fire, but the Lord was not in the fire; and after the fire a sound of a gentle blowing."

— 1 Kings 19:11–12 (NASB)

A great wind. An earthquake. A fire. Three massive, overwhelming, impossible-to-ignore displays of power. And God was not in any of them.

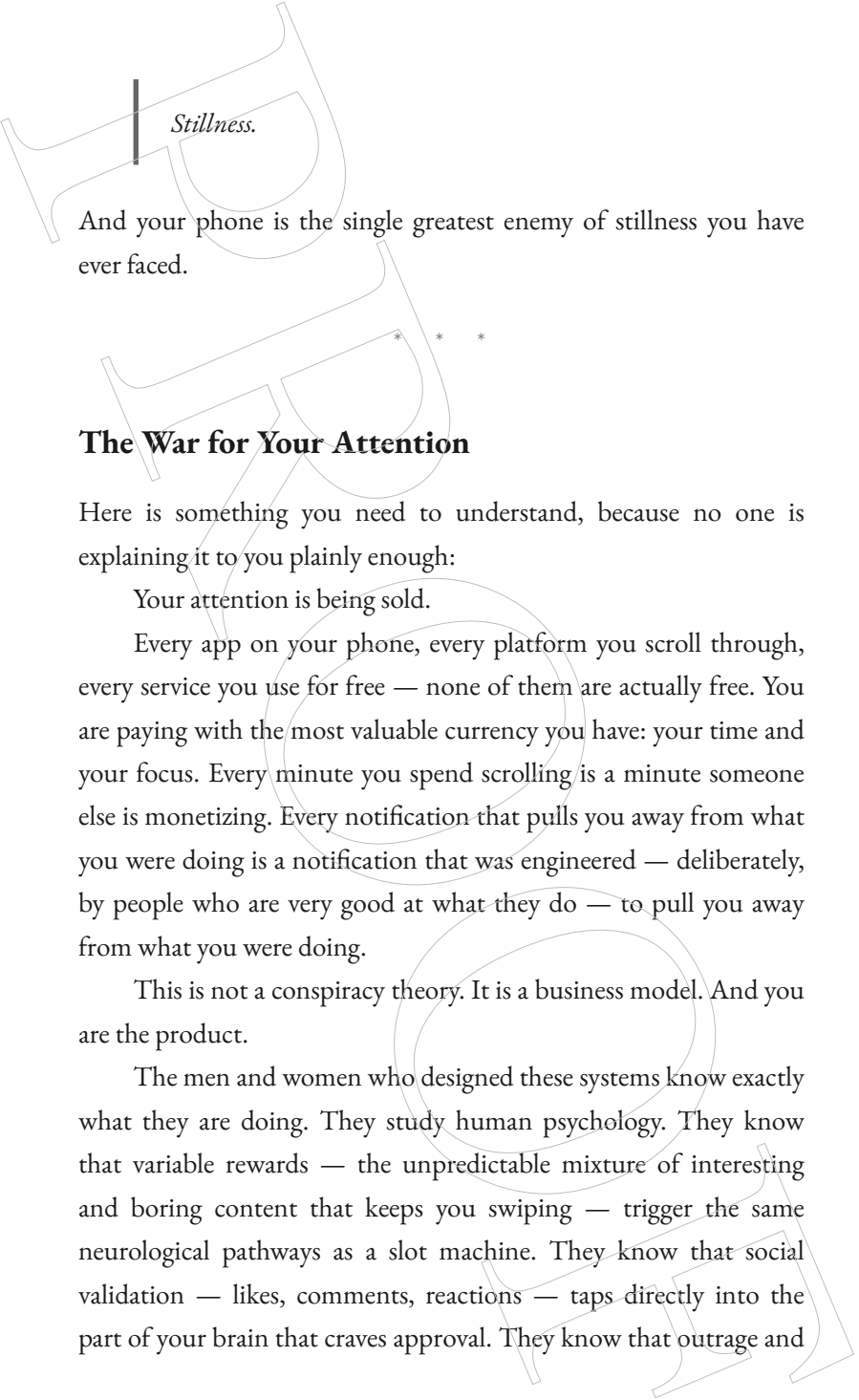
He was in the sound of a gentle blowing. A still, small voice. A whisper.

That is how God often works. Not always — He is God, and He can do anything He chooses. But the pattern throughout Scripture is consistent: God speaks to men who are quiet enough to hear Him. He reveals Himself to men who have slowed down enough to pay attention. He does His deepest work in men who have learned to be still.

"Cease striving and know that I am God."

— Psalm 46:10 (NASB)

Cease striving. Stop. Be still. *Know* that I am God. That word — *know* — is not intellectual agreement. It is the deep, settled, experiential knowledge that comes from being in the presence of someone long enough to actually know them. It requires time. It requires attention. It requires the one thing that is hardest for your generation to give:



Stillness.

And your phone is the single greatest enemy of stillness you have ever faced.

The War for Your Attention

Here is something you need to understand, because no one is explaining it to you plainly enough:

Your attention is being sold.

Every app on your phone, every platform you scroll through, every service you use for free — none of them are actually free. You are paying with the most valuable currency you have: your time and your focus. Every minute you spend scrolling is a minute someone else is monetizing. Every notification that pulls you away from what you were doing is a notification that was engineered — deliberately, by people who are very good at what they do — to pull you away from what you were doing.

This is not a conspiracy theory. It is a business model. And you are the product.

The men and women who designed these systems know exactly what they are doing. They study human psychology. They know that variable rewards — the unpredictable mixture of interesting and boring content that keeps you swiping — trigger the same neurological pathways as a slot machine. They know that social validation — likes, comments, reactions — taps directly into the part of your brain that craves approval. They know that outrage and

controversy generate more engagement than calm, thoughtful content — so the algorithm feeds you more of it.

And they are not losing sleep over what it is doing to your ability to think clearly, pray honestly, read deeply, or sit still long enough to hear the God who made you.

That is not their concern. It is yours.

Paul wrote something to the church in Rome that sounds like it was written yesterday:

"And do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your mind, so that you may prove what the will of God is, that which is good and acceptable and perfect."

— Romans 12:2 (NASB)

Do not be conformed to this world. The word Paul uses for "conformed" carries the idea of being pressed into a mold — squeezed into a shape that someone else designed. That is *exactly* what the screen is doing. It is pressing you, hour by hour, swipe by swipe, into its mold. Its values. Its definition of what matters. Its version of who you should be.

The alternative Paul offers is transformation — but notice where it happens: *the renewing of your mind*. Your mind has to be renewed. Which means it has to receive something different from what the world is constantly pouring into it. And that renewal cannot happen if your mind never gets a moment of quiet.

* * *

What You Feed Grows

In Chapter 2, you read the verse from Proverbs that says to watch over your heart with all diligence, because from it flow the springs of life. Here is the practical application of that truth:

What you feed grows. What you starve dies.

If you feed your mind a steady diet of social media, entertainment, outrage, and distraction — that is what will grow in you. Your thoughts will become scattered. Your attention span will shrink. Your ability to focus on anything that doesn't provide instant stimulation will erode. And the quiet things — the things that actually build a life, like prayer, Scripture, honest reflection, and deep conversation — will slowly starve.

If you feed your mind the Word of God, honest prayer, and time in quiet reflection — something entirely different grows. Your thinking clarifies. Your priorities sharpen. Your ability to hear God's voice through His Word gets stronger, not because God is speaking louder, but because you have finally turned down the noise enough to hear what He has been saying all along.

This is not mystical. It is practical. It is the same principle that governs every area of your life. The man who eats well and exercises builds a strong body. The man who reads broadly and thinks carefully builds a sharp mind. And the man who spends time in God's Word and in honest prayer builds a soul that can bear weight when life gets heavy.

The man who hands his attention over to the screen for four, six, eight hours a day is building nothing. He is consuming. And

consumption without creation, without reflection, without stillness — that is not living. That is just being entertained while time passes.

Jesus made this principle vivid in one of His most well-known parables:

"And the one on whom seed was sown among the thorns, this is the man who hears the word, and the worry of the world and the deceitfulness of wealth choke the word, and it becomes unfruitful."

— Matthew 13:22 (NASB)

The seed is the Word of God. The thorns are the things that choke it — the worry of the world and the deceitfulness of wealth. In your generation, the thorns have a new name. They are the endless stream of content, comparison, anxiety, and noise that pours through your screen every waking hour.

The Word can land in your life. It can take root. But if the thorns are never dealt with — if the noise is never turned down — it gets choked out. Not because the Word is weak, but because the soil was never cleared.

You are the one who clears the soil.

* * *

What Stillness Actually Looks Like

This is not a chapter that is going to tell you to throw your phone in a river. That is not realistic, and it is not the point.

The point is this: you need to become a man who controls his phone instead of a man whose phone controls him. And you need

to build into your life regular, deliberate spaces of quiet where God's Word has room to breathe and your mind has room to think.

That looks different for different men. But here are some starting points that are not dramatic — they are just honest:

Start your day before you start your screen. Before you check a single notification, a single message, a single feed — open your Bible. Read one chapter. Pray for two minutes. Let the first voice you hear in the morning be God's, not the world's. That one decision will change the shape of your entire day.

Build a time with no screen. It does not have to be long. Fifteen minutes. Thirty minutes. A window in your day where the phone is in another room and you are alone with your thoughts, with a Bible, or with another human being who matters to you. Do this daily, and within a week you will notice something has shifted.

Pay attention to what you feel when you can't reach your phone. If you feel anxious, restless, like something is missing — that is not a sign that you need your phone. That is a sign that your phone has trained you to need it. Recognize the difference. The discomfort is not danger. It is withdrawal. And it passes.

Guard your evenings. The last thing you take in before you sleep shapes your mind more than most people realize. If the last thing you see every night is a screen full of content that was designed to agitate, arouse, or distract you — do not be surprised when your mind is restless and your sleep is shallow. Close the screen. Open the Book. Let the last voice you hear at night be the same one you heard first in the morning.

None of this requires perfection. It requires intention. It requires the same kind of quiet, daily decision that Daniel made about food in a Babylonian palace — a decision that nobody

applauded, that nobody even noticed, but that built the foundation for everything that came after.

* * *

The Discipline Nobody Talks About — Meditation

There is a spiritual discipline that has been practiced by men of God for thousands of years, and it has nearly vanished from the modern world. It is not prayer, although it is related to prayer. It is not Bible study, although it makes Bible study immeasurably richer.

It is meditation.

Not the emptying-your-mind kind you may have heard about. Biblical meditation is the opposite of that. It is the deliberate, sustained filling of your mind with the Word of God. It is taking a passage of Scripture and sitting with it. Turning it over. Reading it again. Thinking about what it says, what it means, how it applies, and what God is revealing through it. It is slow. It is quiet. And it is powerful.

God told Joshua — the man who was about to lead an entire nation into the most challenging season of their existence — exactly one thing about how to succeed:

"This book of the law shall not depart from your mouth, but you shall meditate on it day and night, so that you may be careful to do according to all that is written in it; for then you will make your way prosperous, and then you will have success."

— Joshua 1:8 (NASB)

Meditate on it day and night. Not glance at it. Not skim it between notifications. *Meditate* — which means to dwell on it, to chew on it, to let it soak into the fabric of your thinking until it becomes part of how you see the world.

The very first Psalm opens with the same idea:

"How blessed is the man who does not walk in the counsel of the wicked, nor stand in the path of sinners, nor sit in the seat of scoffers! But his delight is in the law of the Lord, and in His law he meditates day and night. He will be like a tree firmly planted by streams of water, which yields its fruit in its season and its leaf does not wither; and in whatever he does, he prospers."

— Psalm 1:1–3 (NASB)

A tree firmly planted by streams of water. That is the picture of a man who has built his inner life on the Word of God — a man who is rooted, stable, fruitful, and unshaken when the wind blows. That image is the opposite of what the screen produces, which is a man who is scattered, reactive, anxious, and blown in whatever direction the latest content pushes him.

You get to choose which man you become. But you do not get to choose both. The tree and the tumbling feed cannot occupy the same life. One will win. And the one that wins is the one you feed.

* * *

A Quiet Challenge

This chapter is closing Part Two of this book. You have spent three chapters looking at who God is, what He is offering you, what His

Word actually claims about itself, and what it will take to hear Him clearly.

Here is the honest truth about everything you have just read: none of it will matter if you go back to the screen and forget it by tomorrow.

The young men who will be changed by this book are not the ones who simply read it. They are the ones who do something about what they read. They are the ones who make the quiet, daily, unglamorous decisions that no one will notice and no one will applaud — but that God will see, and that will build something in them that cannot be taken away.

Daniel made a decision about food. It changed the trajectory of his entire life.

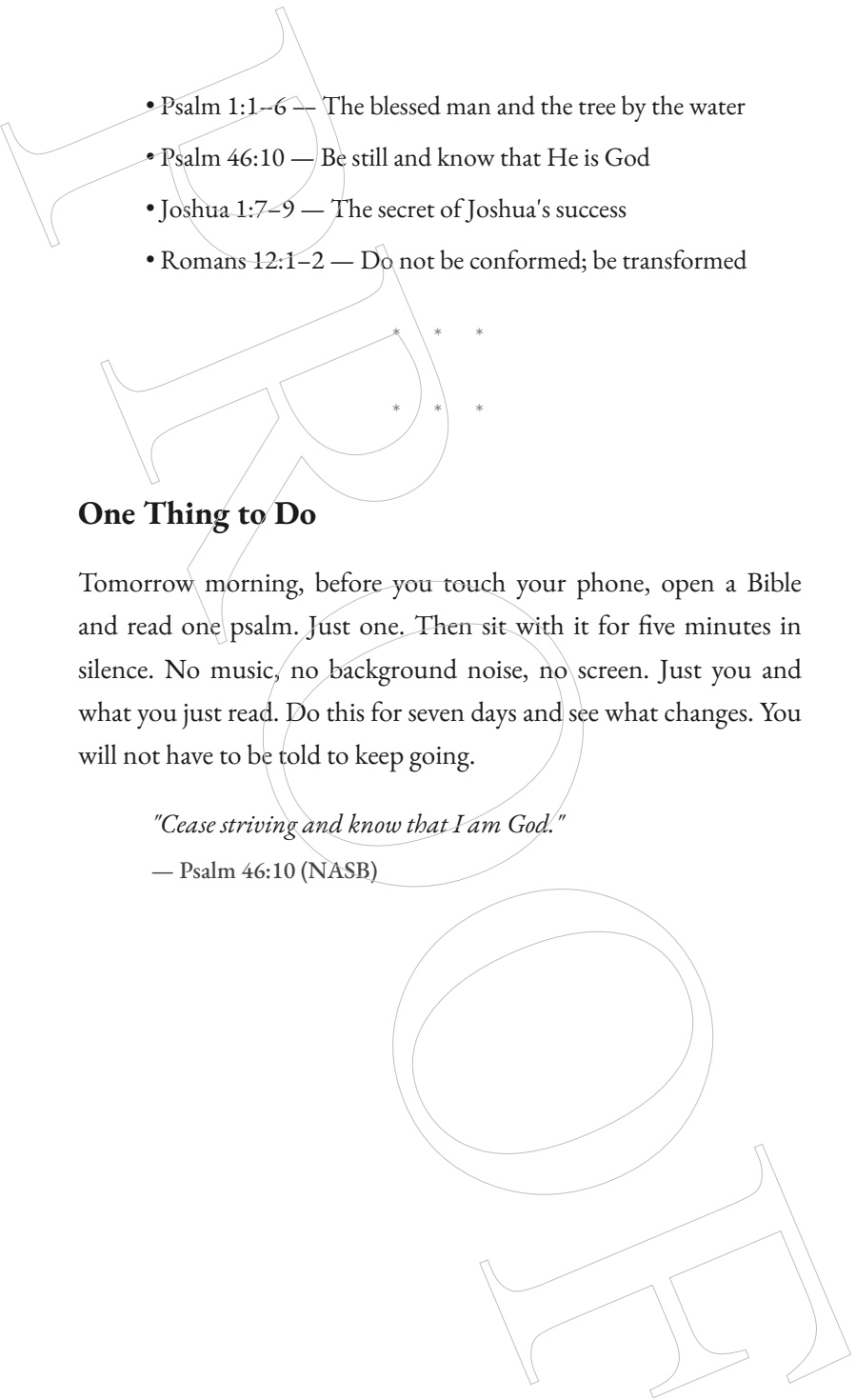
You are being asked to make a decision about your attention. It is the same kind of decision. Quiet. Private. Unremarkable to everyone else. But it is the decision that determines whether the seed of God's Word lands on clear ground or gets choked by thorns.

Clear the ground.

For Further Study

These passages connect stillness, meditation, and the Word of God. Sit with them slowly — practice what they teach while you read them:

- 1 Kings 19:1–18 — Elijah and the still, small voice

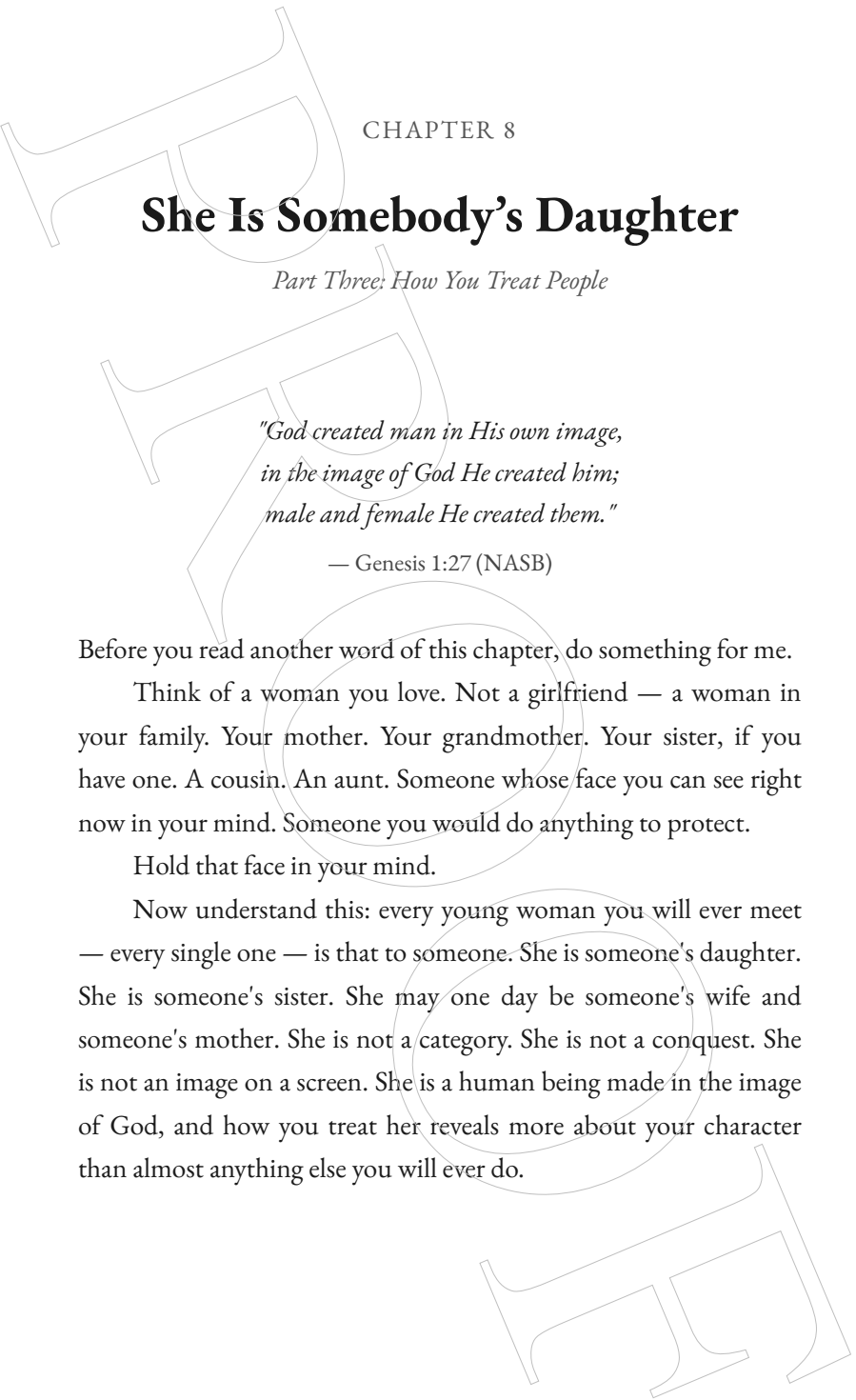
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- Psalm 1:1–6 — The blessed man and the tree by the water
 - Psalm 46:10 — Be still and know that He is God
 - Joshua 1:7–9 — The secret of Joshua's success
 - Romans 12:1–2 — Do not be conformed; be transformed

One Thing to Do

Tomorrow morning, before you touch your phone, open a Bible and read one psalm. Just one. Then sit with it for five minutes in silence. No music, no background noise, no screen. Just you and what you just read. Do this for seven days and see what changes. You will not have to be told to keep going.

"Cease striving and know that I am God."

— Psalm 46:10 (NASB)



CHAPTER 8

She Is Somebody's Daughter

Part Three: How You Treat People

*"God created man in His own image,
in the image of God He created him;
male and female He created them."*

— Genesis 1:27 (NASB)

Before you read another word of this chapter, do something for me.

Think of a woman you love. Not a girlfriend — a woman in your family. Your mother. Your grandmother. Your sister, if you have one. A cousin. An aunt. Someone whose face you can see right now in your mind. Someone you would do anything to protect.

Hold that face in your mind.

Now understand this: every young woman you will ever meet — every single one — is that to someone. She is someone's daughter. She is someone's sister. She may one day be someone's wife and someone's mother. She is not a category. She is not a conquest. She is not an image on a screen. She is a human being made in the image of God, and how you treat her reveals more about your character than almost anything else you will ever do.

This is the chapter that separates the boys from the men.

* * *

Made in His Image

The very first chapter of the very first book of the Bible makes a statement about women that the ancient world had never heard before — and that much of the modern world still has not taken seriously:

"God created man in His own image, in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them."

— Genesis 1:27 (NASB)

Male and female He created them. Both made in the image of God. Not one above the other in worth. Not one more human than the other. Both bearing the *imago Dei* — the image of the Creator Himself.

In the ancient world, that was a revolutionary statement. Women in most ancient cultures were treated as property. They had no legal standing, no voice, no inherent dignity in the eyes of the society around them. And then Genesis opens with God declaring that the woman, like the man, carries His image.

That is not a cultural opinion. That is not a modern idea someone read back into the text. That is the foundation of everything the Bible says about how men and women relate to one another. And it means that every time you look at a young woman, you are looking at someone who bears the image of God — whether

she knows it or not, whether she acts like it or not, whether the world around you treats her that way or not.

How you treat an image-bearer of God is between you and God. It does not depend on what she is wearing. It does not depend on what she says or does. It does not depend on what your friends think is acceptable. It depends on what is true — and what is true is that she carries the same divine image you do.

What the Screen Has Done to Your Eyes

Here is the hardest conversation in this entire book, and it needs to be had honestly.

You are growing up in a world that has done something to young men that no previous generation has experienced at this scale: it has made women into content.

Images. Videos. Feeds. Algorithms that have learned exactly what catches your eye and serves you more of it. A relentless, bottomless stream of female bodies, reduced to pixels, stripped of personhood, and delivered to your screen with the specific purpose of keeping you engaged — which in this context means keeping you looking.

And what that does to a man's mind — slowly, quietly, and without any visible damage on the outside — is devastating.

It trains you to see women as objects before you see them as people. It rewires the way your brain responds to a real human being, because no real human being can compete with an image that was manufactured to trigger a reaction. It builds expectations that

have nothing to do with reality and everything to do with a fantasy that was designed to exploit you, not to help you.

And it erodes something in your character that you will desperately need later: the ability to see a woman clearly. To see her as a whole person — her mind, her heart, her dignity, her worth — without your vision being clouded by what the screen has trained you to look for first.

Jesus addressed this with a directness that should stop every man cold:

"But I say to you that everyone who looks at a woman with lust for her has already committed adultery with her in his heart."

— Matthew 5:28 (NASB)

Notice what Jesus is saying. He is not just talking about actions. He is talking about how you look at her. The sin begins in the gaze. It begins in what you allow your eyes to do and what you allow your mind to dwell on. Long before a man ever crosses a physical line, he has crossed it a thousand times in his heart — and Jesus says that matters. It matters to God, and it should matter to you.

This is not about shame. This is about understanding what is at stake. The man who trains his eyes on a screen full of images that reduce women to objects is not just committing a private sin that hurts nobody. He is slowly destroying his ability to love a real woman well when the time comes. He is poisoning the well before he ever gets thirsty.

* * *

How Scripture Says to Treat Her

Paul, writing to a young man named Timothy who was leading a church and navigating the complexities of how men and women interact, gave him one instruction that is as clear and as direct as anything in the New Testament:

"Treat older women as mothers, and younger women as sisters, in all purity."

— 1 Timothy 5:2 (NASB)

In all purity. Those three words carry the entire weight of the verse. Paul does not say "treat younger women as sisters unless you find them attractive." He does not say "treat younger women as sisters unless you're dating." He says in *all* purity. No exceptions. No qualifiers. No loopholes.

Think about what it means to treat a young woman as a sister. You protect a sister. You do not exploit a sister. You do not pressure a sister. You do not use a sister for your own gratification and then walk away. You care about her well-being, her reputation, her future — not just what she can do for you or how she makes you feel.

That is the standard. And it applies whether you are in a relationship with her or not. Whether she is someone you are dating, someone you are interested in, or someone you will never speak to again — the standard is the same. She is an image-bearer of God, and you treat her with the purity and respect that demands.

Paul wrote to the church in Thessalonica with even more specificity:

"For this is the will of God, your sanctification; that is, that you abstain from sexual immorality; that each of you know how to possess his own vessel in sanctification and honor, not in lustful passion, like the Gentiles who do not know God; and that no man transgress and defraud his brother in this matter because the Lord is the avenger in all these things, just as we also told you before and solemnly warned you."

— 1 Thessalonians 4:3–6 (NASB)

That word — *defraud* — deserves your attention. To defraud someone is to take something from them by deception. To promise something you never intend to deliver. To create an expectation and then rob them of it. Paul is saying that when a man uses a woman for physical gratification outside the boundaries God established, he is defrauding her. He is taking something that does not belong to him. He is stealing from her and from the man she will one day marry.

That is strong language. It is meant to be. Because the stakes are not small. What happens between a man and a woman — physically, emotionally, and spiritually — carries consequences that reach far beyond the moment. And a man of character understands that before the moment arrives, not after.

* * *

The Kind of Man She Actually Needs

The world has handed you two models of manhood when it comes to women, and both of them are failures.

The first is the predator — the man who sees women as targets. He measures his worth by his conquests. He brags about what he's done and who he's done it with. He treats relationships like a game where the goal is to get as much as you can while giving as little as possible. Culture celebrates him. The screen rewards him. And he leaves a trail of damaged people behind him that he never thinks about again.

The second is the passive man — the man who has no spine. He tells a woman whatever she wants to hear because he is afraid of conflict. He has no convictions, no direction, no strength. He is not safe because he is gentle. He is harmless because he is empty. And a woman cannot respect a man she knows she can push in any direction.

Neither of those is what Scripture produces.

What Scripture produces is a third kind of man — and he is rarer than either of the first two:

A man who is strong enough to lead and gentle enough to be trusted.

That is the model Paul describes when he writes to husbands:

"Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself up for her."

— Ephesians 5:25 (NASB)

Just as Christ loved the church. And how did Christ love the church? He *gave Himself up* for her. He sacrificed. He put her needs above His own comfort. He led not by dominating but by serving.

He was the strongest man who ever lived, and He used that strength to protect and to give — never to take.

That is the kind of man a woman actually needs. Not a man who takes from her. Not a man who has no backbone. A man who has the strength to lead and the character to use that strength for her good, not his own.

You are not married yet. You may not be for years. But the kind of husband you will be is being formed right now — in how you treat the young women around you today. Every interaction is practice. Every choice is a deposit into the man you are becoming.

And if you build the habit of treating women with honor now — when nobody is requiring it of you and the culture is telling you the opposite — it will be the most natural thing in the world when it matters most.

* * *

A Word About Waiting

The world is going to tell you that the biblical standard for sexual purity is outdated, unrealistic, and unnecessary. It is going to tell you that everybody does it, that waiting is repressive, that your desires are natural and should be acted on whenever and however you choose.

And every bit of that is a lie.

Not because your desires are wrong — they are not. God created them. The desire for physical intimacy with a woman is built into how He designed you, and there is nothing shameful about it. The Bible is not embarrassed by sex. The Song of Solomon is an

entire book of Scripture that celebrates the beauty of physical love between a husband and wife.

But God placed that gift inside a boundary. And the boundary is not there to restrict you. It is there to protect you, to protect her, and to protect the relationship itself.

Think about it this way: fire inside a fireplace heats the house. Fire outside the fireplace burns it down. The fire is the same. The difference is the boundary. And God, who designed the fire, also designed the fireplace. When you step outside it, you are not being free. You are being reckless with something powerful enough to cause damage that lasts for years.

The man who waits is not weak. He is strong enough to control himself. He is honoring the woman in front of him by refusing to take what doesn't belong to him yet. And he is trusting that the God who designed the gift knows the right context for it.

That takes more strength than giving in. And it builds something in you that the man who gives in never develops: self-mastery. The ability to say no to yourself. Solomon knew the value of that:

"Like a city that is broken into and without walls is a man who has no control over his spirit."

— Proverbs 25:28 (NASB)

You saw that verse in Chapter 1. It is worth seeing again here, because the principle is the same. A man without self-control has no walls. He is defenseless — not against enemies, but against himself.

And in this area of life more than perhaps any other, the absence of self-control will cost you things you cannot get back.

* * *

What You Build or What You Break

Here is the simplest way to think about everything in this chapter:

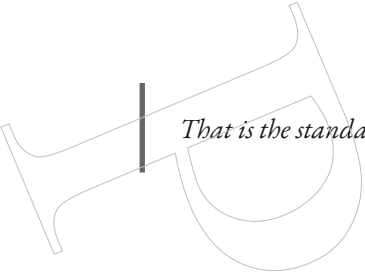
Every interaction you have with a young woman either builds something or breaks something. There is no neutral. You are either building her up — treating her with dignity, protecting her honor, making her feel safe and respected in your presence — or you are breaking something. Taking something. Diminishing her in ways that may not show on the surface but that register in her heart.

You will not be able to undo that damage easily. A young woman who has been used by a man carries that wound. A young woman who has been disrespected, pressured, lied to, or treated as less than she is — that does not simply disappear. It shapes how she sees herself and how she trusts the next man who comes along.

You can be the man who builds. Or you can be the man who breaks. But you cannot be both, and you cannot pretend the choice doesn't matter.

Years from now, when you are older and you look back on how you treated the young women in your life during these years — will you be able to look at your reflection without flinching?

Better yet — will the women you knew during these years be able to say that you treated them the way God required?



That is the standard. Nothing less.

* * *

For Further Study

These passages are the foundation. Read them slowly and let the weight of them settle:

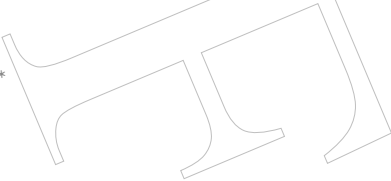
- Genesis 1:26–28 — Male and female, both made in the image of God
- Matthew 5:27–30 — Jesus on lust and the heart
- 1 Timothy 5:1–2 — Treat younger women as sisters, in all purity
- 1 Thessalonians 4:1–8 — Sanctification and sexual purity
- Ephesians 5:25–28 — How Christ loved the church; the model for husbands
- Proverbs 25:28 — The value of a man with self-control

* * *

One Question to Sit With

How have you been looking at women — and does the way you look at them reflect the fact that every one of them was made in God's image and is somebody's daughter?

* * *



One Thing to Do

For the next seven days, every time you see a woman — in person or on a screen — silently say: *She is made in God's image. She is somebody's daughter.* And let that reshape what you allow your eyes and your mind to do.

"Husbands, love your wives, just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself up for her"

— Ephesians 5:25 (NASB)

CHAPTER 9

The Friends You Choose Will Choose Your Future

Part Three: How You Treat People

*"He who walks with wise men will be
wise, but the companion of fools will
suffer harm."*

— Proverbs 13:20 (NASB)

Think about the five people you spend the most time with.

Not just the names. Think about who they are. Think about what they talk about when no one important is listening. Think about what they do when the weekend opens up and there's no plan and no accountability. Think about what they laugh at, what they chase, what they dismiss, and what they admire.

Now ask yourself one honest question: Am I becoming more like them, or are they becoming more like me?

Because one of those two things is happening. It is always happening. There is no version of friendship where two people spend significant time together and neither one is changed by it. You are being shaped by the people around you right now — in your habits, in your language, in your ambitions, in your standards, and in your character. The only question is whether that shaping is making you better or making you worse.

Solomon, the wisest man who ever lived, put it as plainly as it can be put:

"He who walks with wise men will be wise, but the companion of fools will suffer harm."

— Proverbs 13:20 (NASB)

Two outcomes. Two paths. And the determining factor is not your intelligence, your talent, or your intentions. It is who you walk with.

* * *

The People Around You Are Shaping You

This is not a new observation. This is not modern psychology or self-help advice dressed up in Bible language. This is a principle that runs through the entirety of Scripture because God understands something about human nature that most young men do not take seriously enough: you will become like the people you choose to be around.

Not might. Will.

The apostle Paul, writing to the church at Corinth — a city that made modern culture look conservative — quoted a well-known saying to drive the point home:

"Do not be deceived: 'Bad company corrupts good morals.'"

— 1 Corinthians 15:33 (NASB)

Notice the first three words. Do not be deceived. Paul knew that the young men reading this letter would think they were the exception. They would think they could run with the wrong crowd and stay

clean. They would tell themselves what every generation of young men has told itself: I'm strong enough. It won't affect me. I know who I am.

Paul said: you are deceiving yourself.

Bad company does not corrupt bad morals. It corrupts good morals. The danger is not that a weak man will be pulled down by bad friends. The danger is that a good man will be. Slowly. Quietly. One compromise at a time. One lowered standard at a time. One evening at a time where the things that used to bother you stop bothering you because everyone around you treats them as normal.

That is how it works. Not with a dramatic fall, but with a slow drift. And by the time you notice the drift, the current has already carried you a long way from where you started.

* * *

Iron Sharpens Iron

But here is the other side of the same truth — and it is just as powerful: the right friends will make you sharper, stronger, and better than you could ever become on your own.

"Iron sharpens iron, so one man sharpens another."

— Proverbs 27:17 (NASB)

Most people quote this verse casually, as if it means friendship is nice. It means something far more specific than that. Iron does not sharpen iron gently. It sharpens through friction. Through contact.

Through the hard, scraping, sometimes uncomfortable process of one surface grinding against another until both are sharper than they were before.

A real friend is not the man who tells you what you want to hear. A real friend is the man who tells you what you need to hear — and who respects you enough to say the hard thing rather than the easy thing.

A real friend will call you out when your behavior does not match the man you say you want to be. He will not let you get comfortable with a half-truth, a shortcut, or a slow compromise. He will challenge you — not to tear you down, but because he believes you are capable of more.

That kind of friendship is rare. It is also irreplaceable.

If you have even one friend like that in your life, you have something most men never find. Guard that friendship. Invest in it. Be that kind of friend in return. Because the men who sharpen each other are the men who build lives that last.

* * *

The Friends Who Will Cost You Everything

Solomon did not just talk about friendship in general terms. He gave specific warnings about the kinds of people a young man should avoid — and he did it because he understood how much was at stake.

"Do not associate with a man given to anger, or go with a hot-tempered man, or you will learn his ways and find a snare for yourself."

— Proverbs 22:24–25 (NASB)

Notice the word *learn*. You will learn his ways. Not because you intend to. Not because you admire his anger. But because proximity is a teacher. Spend enough time with a man who has no control over his temper, and your own threshold for anger will drop. Spend enough time with a man who cuts corners, and cutting corners will start to feel like efficiency. Spend enough time with a man who treats women carelessly, and the standard you set in your own mind — the standard we talked about in the last chapter — will quietly erode.

Solomon also said something that should make every young man stop and evaluate his circle:

"The righteous is a guide to his neighbor, but the way of the wicked leads them astray."

— Proverbs 12:26 (NASB)

There are two kinds of friends: those who guide you toward something better, and those who lead you somewhere you never intended to go. And the most dangerous version of the second kind is the one who doesn't look dangerous at all. He is fun. He is likable. He is the guy everybody wants at the party. But his life has no foundation, no direction, and no standard — and if you follow his lead, neither will yours.

* * *

What Real Friendship Looks Like — David and Jonathan

If you want to see what friendship is supposed to be — what it looks like when two men sharpen each other and make each other better — there is no better example in all of Scripture than David and Jonathan.

The circumstances of their friendship were, by any reasonable measure, impossible. Jonathan was the son of King Saul — the sitting king of Israel. By every custom and expectation of the ancient world, Jonathan was next in line for the throne. David was the shepherd boy God had chosen to replace Saul. In other words, David was the man who would take what should have been Jonathan's.

In any normal friendship, that would have destroyed everything. Jealousy, rivalry, resentment — the natural human response would have been for Jonathan to view David as a threat. And Jonathan's father, Saul, certainly did. Saul spent years trying to kill David. He was consumed by it.

Jonathan chose a different path.

"The soul of Jonathan was knit to the soul of David, and Jonathan loved him as himself."

— 1 Samuel 18:1 (NASB)

Jonathan recognized that God's hand was on David. And instead of resenting it, he honored it. He gave David his own robe and armor — the symbols of his royal status. He warned David when Saul was plotting to kill him. He risked his own life, his own standing, his

own relationship with his father, to protect the man God had chosen.

At one of the darkest moments in David's life — when he was running, hiding, exhausted, and hunted — the text tells us something remarkable:

"Jonathan, Saul's son, arose and went to David at Horesh, and encouraged him in God."

— 1 Samuel 23:16 (NASB)

He encouraged him *in God*. Not with empty optimism. Not with "hang in there, buddy." He pointed David back to the One who had called him, the One who was with him, the One whose promises had not changed even though the circumstances were brutal.

That is what a real friend does.

A real friend does not just stand with you when it is easy. He stands with you when it costs him something. Jonathan gave up a throne — not reluctantly, not bitterly, but willingly — because he loved his friend and he loved God's purpose more than his own ambition.

When Jonathan was later killed in battle, David's grief tells you everything about what that friendship meant:

"I am distressed for you, my brother Jonathan; you have been very pleasant to me. Your love to me was more wonderful than the love of women."

— 2 Samuel 1:26 (NASB)

David — the warrior, the king, the man who killed Goliath — wept openly and called Jonathan's friendship the most valuable human relationship he had ever known. That is not weakness. That is a man who understood what it means to have a friend who made him better, who sharpened him, who pointed him back to God when the world was falling apart.

Every young man needs a Jonathan. And every young man needs to be one.

* * *

Daniel Did Not Stand Alone

There is another friendship in Scripture that this book has already spent time with, and it is worth returning to here — because it proves the same point from a completely different angle.

When Daniel made his decision about the king's food in Babylon, he did not make it alone. Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah — Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego — stood with him. When the golden statue went up and the command to bow came down, they stood together. When the furnace was heated and the cost of faithfulness became as real as it could possibly get, none of them was alone.

This is not a coincidence in the text. It is a pattern.

God did not design you to stand alone. He designed you to stand with men who share your convictions, who strengthen your resolve, and who will not bow even when you are tempted to. The reason Daniel could be the man he was in the lions' den is not only

because of his private faithfulness — it is also because he spent his life surrounded by men who were faithful too.

Show me your friends, and I will show you your future.

Daniel's friends did not drag him down. They held him up. And when the fire came, they walked into it together.

Choosing With Intention, Not Just Proximity

Here is the mistake most young men make; they do not choose their friends. They inherit them. They end up with the people who happen to be nearby — the guys in the dorm, the coworkers on the shift, the group that formed in high school and never dissolved. And there is nothing wrong with any of those people individually. But proximity is not the same thing as intention.

Choosing your friends means asking a harder set of questions than "do I enjoy being around this person?" It means asking:

- Does this person make me want to be a better man?
- Does this person take his own character seriously?
- Would I trust this person to tell me the truth even when the truth is hard?
- Does this person's life reflect the kind of life I want to build?
- If I become like this person in five years, will I be proud of who I am?

Those are not comfortable questions. They may mean that some of the people you currently spend the most time with are not the people you should be building your life around. That does not mean you have to cut people off dramatically or make some public announcement. It means you redirect your time and energy toward the men who sharpen you — and you become that kind of man for someone else.

This also applies to the digital world. The voices you listen to online, the accounts you follow, the content creators and commentators who fill your feed — those are companions too. Paul's warning in 1 Corinthians 15:33 does not stop at physical proximity. If bad company corrupts good morals, then bad content consumed daily is bad company. The man who fills his ears with foolishness should not be surprised when foolishness starts coming out of his mouth.

* * *

Be the Friend Worth Having

There is one more side to this that most young men do not consider, and it may be the most important part of all.

You are not only choosing friends. You are being chosen. Somewhere, right now, there is another young man looking at the people around him and deciding who to spend his time with. And you are either the kind of man who makes that decision easy — or you are the kind he needs to walk away from.

"A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity."

— Proverbs 17:17 (NASB)

A friend loves at all times. Not when it is convenient. Not when you are fun to be around. Not when things are going well and the friendship costs nothing. At all times — including the times when it is hard, when it is expensive, when the other man is struggling and has nothing to offer you in return.

Be the man who shows up. Be the man who tells the truth. Be the man who, like Jonathan, encourages his friend in God rather than just in good feelings. Be the man whose name, when it comes up in conversation, makes other men say: "That is someone I trust."

Your name is being written in the lives of the people around you. We talked about that in the first chapter. The friends you choose will shape what your name becomes. But you are also shaping theirs.

Choose well. And be worth choosing.

* * *

For Further Study

Read these passages in their full context. Let the surrounding verses speak:

- Proverbs 13:20 — The two paths: wise companions or foolish ones
- 1 Corinthians 15:33 — Paul's warning about the power of bad company
- Proverbs 27:17 — Iron sharpens iron

- 1 Samuel 18:1–4 — The beginning of David and Jonathan's friendship
- 1 Samuel 23:15–18 — Jonathan encourages David in God
- Proverbs 17:17 — A friend loves at all times
- Proverbs 22:24–25 — The danger of angry companions

* * *

One Question to Sit With

Look at the five people you spend the most time with. Are they making you sharper — or duller? Are they pulling you toward the man God is calling you to be — or away from him?

* * *

One Thing to Do

Reach out to one person this week who makes you better — not just someone who makes you laugh or keeps you comfortable, but someone who challenges you, calls you up, and tells you the truth. Invest in that friendship on purpose.

"A friend loves at all times, and a brother is born for adversity."

— Proverbs 17:17 (NASB)

Honor Your Father and Mother (Even When It's Hard)

Part Three: How You Treat People

*"Honor your father and your mother,
that your days may be prolonged in the
land which the LORD your God gives
you."*

— Exodus 20:12 (NASB)

The First Commandment With a Promise

When God gave Moses the Ten Commandments on Mount Sinai — the foundational moral law for an entire nation, the bedrock of civilization for three thousand years — He included this:

*"Honor your father and your mother, that your days may be
prolonged in the land which the Lord your God gives you."*

— Exodus 20:12 (NASB)

Of the ten commandments, this is the only one that comes with a promise attached. The command to honor your parents is not buried in a list of suggestions. It is not tucked into a minor passage that only theologians care about. It sits in the most important moral code ever given to mankind, right at the hinge point between the

commands about how man relates to God and the commands about how man relates to other people.

Think about that placement. The first four commandments deal with God — no other gods, no idols, do not take His name in vain, remember the Sabbath. The last five deal with others — do not murder, do not commit adultery, do not steal, do not lie, do not covet. And right in the middle, serving as the bridge between the two, is this: honor your father and your mother.

God placed it there because how you treat your parents is connected to both — to your relationship with Him and to your relationship with the world. A man who cannot honor the people who raised him will struggle to honor anyone else. And a man who dismisses the authority God placed in his life first will find it very difficult to submit to the authority of God Himself.

The apostle Paul, writing centuries later to the church at Ephesus, picked up this exact commandment and carried it into the New Testament:

"Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right. Honor your father and mother (which is the first commandment with a promise), so that it may be well with you, and that you may live long on the earth."

— Ephesians 6:1–3 (NASB)

Paul calls it *the first commandment with a promise*. He wants his readers to notice that God did something unusual here. He did not just command obedience. He attached a blessing to it. He said: this is the kind of life that goes well. This is the kind of life that has length and depth and substance. Not because honoring your parents earns you extra years like some kind of transaction — but

because the man who learns to honor his parents is learning something foundational about how life works. He is learning humility. He is learning gratitude. He is learning that the world does not revolve around him and his feelings.

Honor is the soil in which everything else grows.

What Honor Actually Means

The word "honor" in the Hebrew is *kabed*. Its root meaning is "heavy" — to give weight to, to treat as significant. To honor your parents means to treat them as people who carry weight in your life. People who matter. People whose words and sacrifices and presence are not taken lightly.

It does not mean your parents are always right. It does not mean you must agree with every decision they made. It does not mean pretending your childhood was something it was not.

It means you give them weight.

You take them seriously. You speak about them with respect, even when they are not in the room. You do not dismiss their counsel simply because you have decided you know better. You pick up the phone. You show up. You say the words that cost you nothing to say and mean everything to them to hear.

Honor is not a feeling. It is a decision. And like every decision worth making, it is easiest when the circumstances are good and most valuable when the circumstances are hard.

* * *

When Honor Is Easy — and When It Costs Something

Some of you reading this have good parents. Parents who loved you well, sacrificed for you, showed up, stayed married, built a home that felt like a home. Honoring those parents is not difficult to understand — though even in the best families, the transition into adulthood brings friction. The young man who respected his father at fourteen may find himself at eighteen thinking he has outgrown the man who raised him. He hasn't. But it can feel that way.

If you have good parents, do not make the mistake of taking them for granted. You did not earn them. You did not choose them. They were a gift. And the appropriate response to a gift is not indifference — it is gratitude.

Solomon, who received his wisdom as a young man sitting at the feet of his father David, wrote:

"Listen to your father who begot you, and do not despise your mother when she is old."

— Proverbs 23:22 (NASB)

Do not despise your mother when she is old. That word — *despise* — means to treat as insignificant. To make light of. To move past without stopping. Solomon is warning against the drift that

happens naturally as a young man builds his own life: the slow, unintentional shrinking of his parents in his mind from the center of his world to the edges of it. One day you simply stop calling as often. One day their advice feels outdated. One day you realize you haven't been home in months and it didn't bother you.

That is the drift. And Solomon says: fight it.

But some of you reading this did not have good parents. Or did not have both. Or the ones you had carried damage they never dealt with, and some of that damage landed on you. This chapter owes you honesty about that.

The command to honor your parents does not come with an exception clause. God did not say "Honor your father and mother if they deserve it." He did not say "Honor them if they were good at it." He said honor them. Period. And that can feel, to a young man who has been hurt, like God is asking something unfair.

Hear this carefully: honor is not the same as pretending.

You do not honor a parent by lying about what they did. You do not honor them by excusing destructive behavior or by acting as if wounds do not exist. Honoring an imperfect parent — or even a deeply flawed one — means choosing not to let bitterness define you. It means refusing to carry the weight of resentment for the rest of your life, not because they earned your forgiveness, but because unforgiveness will destroy you far more effectively than anything they ever did.

The man who holds on to bitterness against his parents is drinking poison and expecting someone else to get sick. It does not work. It has never worked.

* * *

What Jesus Said About It

If you want to know how seriously God takes this command, watch what Jesus did with it.

In Mark chapter 7, the Pharisees — the religious elite of Israel, the men who prided themselves on their meticulous obedience to the law — had found a loophole. They had invented a practice called Corban, which allowed a man to dedicate his money to God and then use that dedication as an excuse not to support his aging parents. It was religious-sounding selfishness. It looked pious. It was, in reality, a way of getting out of the most basic human obligation.

Jesus confronted them directly:

"You are experts at setting aside the commandment of God in order to keep your tradition. For Moses said, 'Honor your father and your mother'. . . but you say, 'If a man says to his father or his mother, whatever I have that would help you is Corban (that is to say, given to God),' you no longer permit him to do anything for his father or his mother; thus invalidating the word of God by your tradition which you have handed down."

— Mark 7:9–13 (NASB)

Jesus was not gentle about this. He called it what it was: using religion as a cover for dishonoring your parents. And He made it

clear that no tradition, no excuse, no clever reinterpretation of the rules can cancel what God plainly commanded.

But Jesus did not only teach this. He lived it.

In the final moments of His life — hanging on the cross, bearing the weight of the sin of the entire world, in more physical agony than any human being has ever endured — Jesus looked down and saw His mother standing there. And in the middle of everything He was suffering, He made sure she would be taken care of:

"When Jesus then saw His mother, and the disciple whom He loved standing nearby, He said to His mother, 'Woman, behold, your son!' Then He said to the disciple, 'Behold, your mother!' From that hour the disciple took her into his own household."

— John 19:26–27 (NASB)

Even while dying, He honored His mother. He made provision for her. He did not leave her uncared for. If the Son of God, in the most important moment in human history, took time to honor His parent — what excuse could any man possibly have for neglecting his own?

What Honor Builds in a Man

Here is what most young men do not see until much later: honoring your parents is not primarily about your parents. It is about who you are becoming.

The man who learns to honor imperfect people is learning a skill that will serve him in every relationship he ever has. His future wife will be imperfect. His future children will be imperfect. His boss, his friends, his church — all imperfect. And the man who practiced honor at home, even when it was hard, will carry that capacity into every other room he walks into.

The man who never learned it will wonder why every relationship eventually becomes adversarial. Why every authority feels oppressive. Why gratitude does not come naturally and why resentment always does.

We talked in Chapter 2 about integrity — being the same man in every room. We talked in Chapter 9 about the friends who shape your future. But before your friends shaped you, your parents shaped you. And how you respond to that shaping — with honor or with contempt, with gratitude or with grievance — will echo through every relationship that follows.

"Hear, my son, your father's instruction and do not forsake your mother's teaching; indeed, they are a graceful wreath to your head and ornaments about your neck."

— Proverbs 1:8–9 (NASB)

Solomon calls a parent's teaching a wreath and an ornament — something that adorns you. Something that adds to who you are, not subtracts from it. A young man who carries his parents' good teaching with him does not look weak. He looks wise. He looks like a man who had the humility to learn from the people who went before him, and the good sense to keep what was worth keeping.

* * *

Daniel Was Somebody's Son

This book has spent significant time with Daniel and his three friends. You know their courage. You know their faithfulness. You know they stood when the entire Babylonian empire told them to bow.

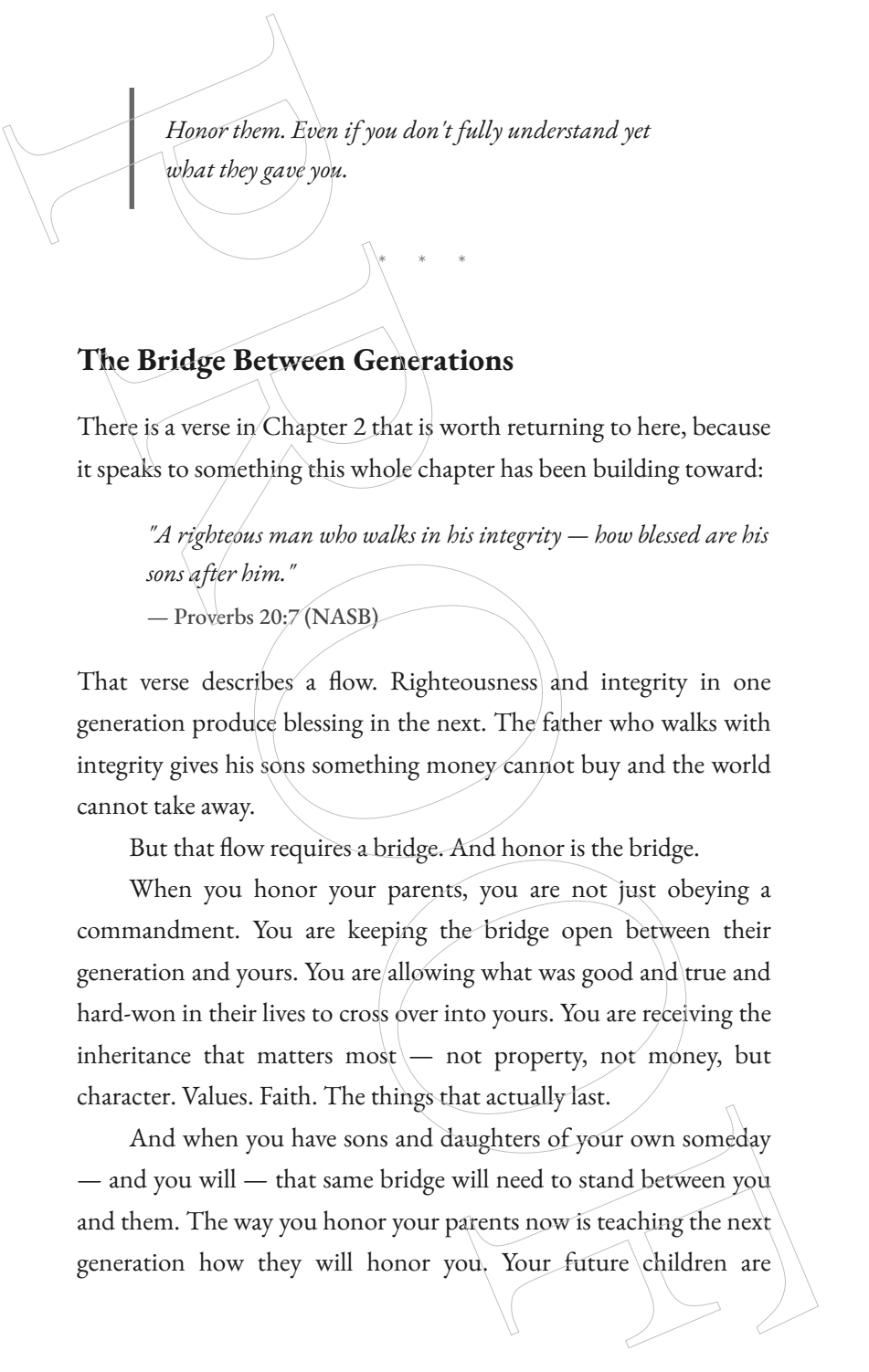
But there is something else worth noticing about Daniel, something the text does not say directly but implies powerfully: someone raised that boy.

Daniel was taken from Jerusalem as a teenager. He was ripped from his home, his land, his people, everything familiar. And when he arrived in Babylon, with every reason to abandon his convictions and blend in with the culture around him, he did not. He had already decided what kind of man he would be.

Where did that come from?

That kind of conviction does not appear out of nowhere. It is planted, long before the test arrives, by a father who teaches and a mother who instructs. Daniel carried something into Babylon that Babylon could not take from him — and the people who put it there were his parents.

You may never know the full impact of what your parents gave you until the day you need it most. The values that feel ordinary now may be the very things that hold you together when everything else is shaking. The lessons you dismissed as repetitive or old-fashioned may turn out to be the only solid ground under your feet when the culture around you offers nothing but sand.



Honor them. Even if you don't fully understand yet
what they gave you.

* * *

The Bridge Between Generations

There is a verse in Chapter 2 that is worth returning to here, because it speaks to something this whole chapter has been building toward:

"A righteous man who walks in his integrity — how blessed are his sons after him."

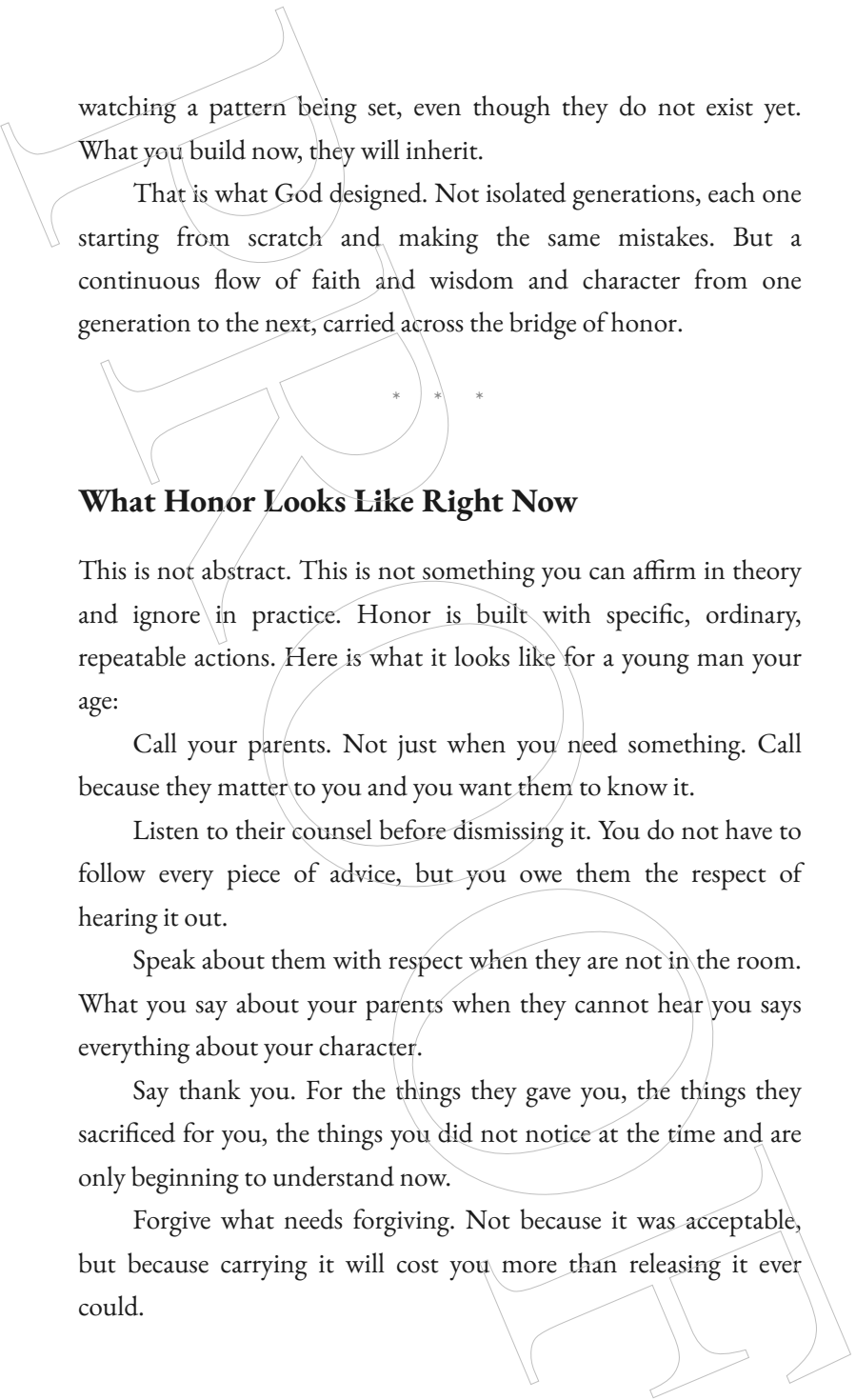
— Proverbs 20:7 (NASB)

That verse describes a flow. Righteousness and integrity in one generation produce blessing in the next. The father who walks with integrity gives his sons something money cannot buy and the world cannot take away.

But that flow requires a bridge. And honor is the bridge.

When you honor your parents, you are not just obeying a commandment. You are keeping the bridge open between their generation and yours. You are allowing what was good and true and hard-won in their lives to cross over into yours. You are receiving the inheritance that matters most — not property, not money, but character. Values. Faith. The things that actually last.

And when you have sons and daughters of your own someday — and you will — that same bridge will need to stand between you and them. The way you honor your parents now is teaching the next generation how they will honor you. Your future children are



watching a pattern being set, even though they do not exist yet. What you build now, they will inherit.

That is what God designed. Not isolated generations, each one starting from scratch and making the same mistakes. But a continuous flow of faith and wisdom and character from one generation to the next, carried across the bridge of honor.

What Honor Looks Like Right Now

This is not abstract. This is not something you can affirm in theory and ignore in practice. Honor is built with specific, ordinary, repeatable actions. Here is what it looks like for a young man your age:

Call your parents. Not just when you need something. Call because they matter to you and you want them to know it.

Listen to their counsel before dismissing it. You do not have to follow every piece of advice, but you owe them the respect of hearing it out.

Speak about them with respect when they are not in the room. What you say about your parents when they cannot hear you says everything about your character.

Say thank you. For the things they gave you, the things they sacrificed for you, the things you did not notice at the time and are only beginning to understand now.

Forgive what needs forgiving. Not because it was acceptable, but because carrying it will cost you more than releasing it ever could.

Show up. Be present. Give them your time, not just your tolerance.

None of these things are dramatic. None of them will trend or earn you recognition from anyone. But every single one of them honors the command of God, strengthens the bridge between generations, and builds something in your character that will hold weight when it matters most.

The Hardest and Best Decision

This chapter sits at the close of Part Three of this book — the section about how you treat people. We have talked about how you treat the young women in your life. We have talked about how you choose your friends. And now we have talked about how you treat the people who were there first — the ones who changed your diapers, sat through your ball games, stayed up when you were sick, worried when you did not call, and loved you in a thousand ways you probably never noticed.

They were not perfect. No parent is. No parent has ever been, with one exception — and even God's own Son was rejected by the people He came to save.

But they are yours. And God said to honor them. Not because they earned it. Not because the relationship is easy. Because honor is the kind of thing a man does when he takes God at His word and trusts that the command is good even when the circumstances are complicated.

This is where Part Three has been leading. How you treat the young woman in your life reveals what you think about the image of God. How you choose your friends reveals what you value. And how you honor your parents reveals whether you trust the God who told you to.

*Honor them. While you can. While they are here.
While your words still have the power to land.*

One day the phone will not be answered. One day the seat at the table will be empty. And the man who honored his parents when it was hard will carry no regret about what he said and what he did. The man who waited too long will carry it forever.

Do not wait.

* * *

For Further Study

Open a Bible and read these passages in full. Let the weight of them settle:

- Exodus 20:12 — The Ten Commandments; notice where the command about parents falls
- Ephesians 6:1–3 — Paul's instruction to children and fathers
- Proverbs 23:22 — Solomon on the value of a parent's heart
- Mark 7:9–13 — Jesus confronts the Pharisees about Corban
- John 19:25–27 — Jesus honors His mother from the cross

- Proverbs 1:8-9 — A parent's teaching as a wreath and ornament
- Proverbs 20:7 — The righteous man and the blessing on his sons

* * *

One Question to Sit With

Is there something your parents have asked of you — or something you know would honor them — that you've been putting off, pushing back on, or quietly ignoring? What would it cost you to do it this week?

* * *

One Thing to Do

Do one thing this week that honors your parents — not because they earned it, not because it's easy, but because God commanded it and your name is being shaped by how you respond. Call. Show up. Apologize. Obey. Whatever it is — do it.

"A righteous man who walks in his integrity — how blessed are his sons after him."

— Proverbs 20:7 (NASB)

Work Like It Matters Because It Does

Part Four: How You Build a Life

*"Whatever you do, do your work
heartily, as for the Lord rather than for
men"*

— Colossians 3:23 (NASB)

Somewhere in the next few weeks or months, the theoretical part of your life ends and the real part begins. You will show up to a job. Someone will hand you something to do. And in that moment — before anyone is evaluating you, before there is any pressure to perform, before anyone is watching closely enough to care — you will make a decision that will quietly define the trajectory of your entire working life.

You will decide whether you are going to do the work well, or just well enough.

It sounds like a small decision. It is not. It is one of the biggest decisions you will ever make, because it sets a pattern. And patterns, once established, are extraordinarily difficult to break. The young man who decides early that he will do excellent work — not for the applause, not for the promotion, not because someone is checking

— is building something into his character that will carry him further than talent, connections, or luck ever could.

The young man who decides that "good enough" is good enough will spend the rest of his life wondering why good things keep going to other people.

* * *

The Verse That Changes Everything About Work

There is one passage of Scripture that, if you understood it and lived it, would make you the most valuable person in any room you ever walk into. It is not complicated. It does not require a theology degree. But it will rearrange your entire understanding of what work is and why it matters.

"Whatever you do, do your work heartily, as for the Lord rather than for men, knowing that from the Lord you will receive the reward of the inheritance. It is the Lord Christ whom you serve."

— Colossians 3:23–24 (NASB)

Read that again. Read it slowly.

Paul is writing to ordinary people in an ordinary city. Not pastors. Not missionaries. Working people. And he tells them something that should fundamentally change the way every man approaches his job: you are not working for your boss. You are not working for a paycheck. You are not working for a promotion or recognition or a performance review. You are working *for the Lord*.

That means the audience for your work is not the man standing over your shoulder. It is not the customer. It is not the

owner of the company. The audience for your work is Jesus Christ. And when you understand that, everything changes.

The task that felt meaningless suddenly has meaning, because the One watching it has given it meaning. The work that nobody notices is noticed by the only One whose notice actually matters. The job that seems beneath you is not beneath Him — and if it is not beneath Him, it is not beneath you.

If you are cleaning a floor, clean it as though Christ will walk on it.

If you are stacking shelves, stack them as though He is the one who will see them. If you are answering a phone, answer it as though He is on the other end. If you are digging a ditch, mowing a yard, running a register, or learning a trade from the ground up — do it heartily, because the word Paul uses there means with your whole soul. Not half-effort. Not distracted. Not watching the clock and counting the minutes until you can leave. With everything you have.

That standard has nothing to do with whether the job is glamorous. It has nothing to do with whether your boss deserves your best effort. It has nothing to do with how much you are being paid. The standard is the Lord. And the Lord does not adjust His expectations based on your circumstances.

* * *

What the World Gets Wrong About Work

The world will hand you two lies about work, and they come from opposite directions.

The first lie says that work is the point of your life. That you are defined by your career, your title, your income, and your professional achievements. This lie produces men who sacrifice their families, their health, their integrity, and their relationship with God on the altar of ambition. They climb and climb and climb, and when they finally get to the top, they discover that the ladder was leaning against the wrong wall. Solomon met these men three thousand years ago:

"I considered all my activities which my hands had done and the labor which I had exerted, and behold, all was vanity and striving after wind and there was no profit under the sun."

— Ecclesiastes 2:11 (NASB)

Solomon had built more, achieved more, and accumulated more than any man alive. And he looked at all of it and called it vapor. Not because work is meaningless — but because work that is done for the wrong reasons and directed toward the wrong goals will always leave a man empty, no matter how much he accomplishes.

The second lie says that work is a necessary evil. Something you endure in order to get to the weekend. Something that exists to fund the life you actually want to live. This lie produces men who do as little as possible, who resent every hour they spend on the job, and who never discover the deep satisfaction that comes from doing difficult work well.

Both lies miss what Scripture says about work. The Bible teaches that work is not the point of your life, but it is part of the point. God worked. Before sin entered the world, before the fall, before anything went wrong, God placed Adam in a garden and gave him work to do:

"Then the Lord God took the man and put him into the garden of Eden to cultivate it and keep it."

— Genesis 2:15 (NASB)

Work was not a punishment. It was part of the original design. It was something God gave to man before there was any curse, any suffering, any brokenness in the world. To work is to participate in something God Himself does and something He built into the fabric of human life from the beginning.

The curse of Genesis 3 did not introduce work. It introduced the pain and frustration that now accompany work — the thorns, the sweat, the difficulty. But the work itself was always meant to be good. And it still can be, when it is done for the right reasons and under the right authority.

* * *

The Men Who Worked as Though It Mattered

Scripture is filled with men whose faithfulness in work became the foundation for everything else God did through them. This is not a coincidence. It is a pattern.

Joseph

Joseph was sold into slavery by his own brothers and taken to Egypt as a teenager. He had every reason to give up, to do the minimum, to let bitterness turn him into a man who simply survived. Instead, the text says something remarkable about his time in the house of Potiphar:

"The Lord was with Joseph, so he became a successful man . . . his master saw that the Lord was with him and how the Lord caused all that he did to prosper in his hand."

— Genesis 39:2–3 (NASB)

Joseph worked so well, with such obvious excellence, that even a pagan master could see that something was different about this young man. Potiphar did not understand the God of Israel. But he could see the fruit of a man who worked as though something greater than a paycheck was at stake.

And when Joseph was falsely accused and thrown into prison — when his circumstances got worse, not better, despite his faithfulness — he did not quit. He did the same thing in prison that he had done in Potiphar's house. He worked with excellence. He served faithfully. And God eventually used that quiet, consistent faithfulness to elevate Joseph to the second highest position in all of Egypt, where he saved an entire nation from starvation.

Joseph did not know, while he was serving in a foreign house and rotting in a prison, what God was building through his work. He simply did the next thing well. And the next thing. And the next thing. That was enough.

Daniel

Daniel — and you know this story by now — served in a foreign government under pagan kings for his entire career. He did not choose that assignment. He did not ask for it. But the text tells us that he served with such integrity and such excellence that his enemies, after searching his entire life for a flaw, could find nothing:

"...he was faithful, and no negligence or corruption was to be found in him."

— Daniel 6:4 (NASB)

No negligence. No corruption. Not in his public duties and not in his private life. Daniel's work ethic was so thorough, so consistent, that it became a weapon his enemies could not overcome. They had to change the law to trap him, because his work gave them nothing to use.

That is what Colossians 3:23 looks like when a man actually lives it.

The First Real Test

For many young men, the first real job comes close to home. Maybe you are working for family. Maybe you are working for someone your family knows. Maybe you are starting at the bottom in a trade or a business where the people around you have been doing this for

years and you are the new man with everything to learn and nothing to prove yet.

Here is what most young men do not understand about that situation: the first year of work is not primarily about the skills you learn. It is about the man you reveal.

Your boss — whether he is a stranger or someone who has known you your whole life — is watching. Not mainly for competence. Competence can be taught. He is watching for something deeper: Does this young man show up on time? Does he do what he says he will do? Does he take ownership of mistakes or does he make excuses? Does he look for the next thing that needs doing, or does he stand around waiting to be told? Does he treat the unglamorous work with the same seriousness as the work that gets attention?

Those are not skill questions. Those are character questions. And they are being answered in the first weeks and months of your working life whether you realize it or not.

Working close to home — for family or people who know your family — adds a dimension that Scripture speaks to directly. Your work now carries your family's name. We talked about the weight of a name in Chapter 1. That weight does not disappear when you clock in. If anything, it gets heavier. The man who works with excellence honors the name he carries. The man who cuts corners, shows up late, or treats the work as something beneath him shames it.

"Poor is he who works with a negligent hand, but the hand of the diligent makes rich."

— Proverbs 10:4 (NASB)

The word *diligent* in Hebrew carries the idea of decisiveness, sharpness, determination. It is the opposite of carelessness. A diligent man does not drift through his work. He attacks it. He gives it his full attention, his full effort, his full presence. And over time — not overnight, but steadily — that diligence produces results that a negligent man will never see.

The Theology of Small Things

One of the most dangerous assumptions a young man can make is that his current work does not matter because it is small. The entry-level task. The repetitive job. The assignment that feels beneath what he is capable of. The temptation is to treat small work carelessly, telling yourself that you will bring your best effort when the work is worthy of it.

Jesus addressed this directly:

"He who is faithful in a very little thing is faithful also in much; and he who is unrighteous in a very little thing is unrighteous also in much."

— Luke 16:10 (NASB)

Faithful in a very little thing. Not "faithful when the stakes are high." Not "faithful when the job matches my ambition." Faithful in the smallest, most ordinary, most forgettable task — because that is where character is revealed. That is where the real man shows up.

The man who sweeps the floor with excellence is the man who can be trusted to manage the project. The man who keeps his word

on a five-dollar commitment will keep his word on a fifty-thousand-dollar one. The man who shows up early when no one is watching will show up early when everyone is.

God does not promote men who despise small beginnings. He promotes men who are faithful in them.

"For who has despised the day of small things?"

— Zechariah 4:10 (NASB)

Your first job is not a holding pattern. It is a proving ground. And the God who watches your heart — the same God who looked past Eliab and chose the shepherd boy in the field — is watching what you do with the small things. Not because the small things are the point. But because the small things reveal whether you can be trusted with the big ones.

* * *

Work and the Man You Are Becoming

There is something that happens to a man who works hard at honest work over a sustained period of time, and it is not something the culture talks about much: he becomes someone. Not someone famous, necessarily. Not someone who makes headlines. But someone solid. Someone dependable. Someone whose word means something and whose presence in a room changes the quality of what gets done.

That transformation does not happen through ambition. It happens through faithfulness. Day after day. Task after task. Showing up and doing the work — heartily, as for the Lord — until

the work has done something to you that nothing else could have done. It has built patience into a man who was impatient. Discipline into a man who was undisciplined. Humility into a man who thought he already knew enough.

Paul understood this. In his letter to the Thessalonians, he gave an instruction that sounds almost too simple for Scripture:

"Make it your ambition to lead a quiet life and attend to your own business and work with your hands, just as we commanded you, so that you will behave properly toward outsiders and not be in any need."

— 1 Thessalonians 4:11–12 (NASB)

Make it your *ambition* to lead a quiet life. That phrase should stop you. In a world that screams at young men to be loud, to be noticed, to build a brand, to chase platform and influence and attention — Paul says make it your *ambition* to be quiet. To attend to your own business. To work with your hands. To build a life that is steady, honest, and self-sufficient.

That is not a life without purpose. That is a life with the deepest kind of purpose — the kind that does not need an audience to be meaningful.

* * *

A Word About Laziness

Scripture does not handle laziness gently. The book of Proverbs in particular is relentless on this subject, and it is worth hearing what Solomon says without softening it:

"How long will you lie down, O sluggard? When will you arise from your sleep? A little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to rest — your poverty will come in like a vagabond and your need like an armed man."

— Proverbs 6:9–11 (NASB)

A little sleep. A little slumber. A little folding of the hands. That is how laziness works. It does not announce itself. It arrives in small increments. A little bit of procrastination. A little bit of distraction. A little bit of "I'll get to it later." And then one day you look up and the work is undone, the opportunity is gone, and the man you could have become is buried under a pile of things you meant to do.

The screen is the single greatest engine of laziness your generation has ever faced. We talked about this in Chapter 7. The device in your pocket is specifically, deliberately engineered to consume your time and attention. And time and attention are the raw materials of work. A man who gives his best hours to his phone will have nothing left to give to his labor. It is a simple equation, and the math does not lie.

Solomon sent his readers to watch the ant — a creature that works without a supervisor, without a deadline, without anyone telling it what to do next:

"Go to the ant, O sluggard, observe her ways and be wise, which, having no chief, officer or ruler, prepares her food in the summer and gathers her provision in the harvest."

— Proverbs 6:6–8 (NASB)

No chief. No officer. No ruler. The ant works because the work needs doing. She does not wait to be told. She does not need to be managed. She sees what needs to be done and she does it.

Be the man who sees what needs to be done. In your job, in your home, in your relationships, in your walk with God. Do not wait for someone to hand you a task. Look around. Find the thing that needs doing. And do it well.

* * *

Rest Is Not Laziness

One more thing needs to be said, because this chapter could be misunderstood without it: God designed work, but He also designed rest. The same God who placed Adam in a garden to work also set apart a day for stopping.

"By the seventh day God completed His work which He had done, and He rested on the seventh day from all His work which He had done."

— Genesis 2:2 (NASB)

God did not rest because He was tired. He rested because rest is part of the rhythm He built into creation. A man who works seven days a week without stopping is not honoring God with his work ethic — he is ignoring the pattern God established at the foundation of the world.

Rest is not laziness. Rest is obedience. It is the acknowledgment that you are not the engine that keeps the world running. God is. And the man who trusts God enough to stop working for a day is demonstrating the same kind of faith that Daniel demonstrated when he kept praying with his windows open — a faith that says my security is not in my effort, but in my God.

Work hard. Work heartily. Work as for the Lord. And then rest, because He told you to and because He knows what you need better than you do.

* * *

The Man Nobody Has to Manage

Here is the man this chapter is asking you to become: the man nobody has to manage.

The man who shows up early. The man who stays until the work is done, not until the clock says he can leave. The man who does not need to be told twice. The man who takes responsibility for his mistakes and gives credit to others for their contributions. The man whose boss — whether it is a stranger or his own father — can hand a task to and walk away, knowing it will be done right, done thoroughly, and done on time.

That man is rare. In every workplace, in every generation, that man is rare. And because he is rare, he is valuable. Doors open for that man. Opportunities find him. Trust is extended to him, not because he demanded it, but because he earned it — quietly, consistently, in the ordinary work that nobody else wanted to do with excellence.

"Do you see a man skilled in his work? He will stand before kings; he will not stand before obscure men."

— Proverbs 22:29 (NASB)

Joseph stood before Pharaoh. Daniel stood before Nebuchadnezzar, Belshazzar, Darius, and Cyrus. Not because they chased power.

Because they worked with such faithfulness, in such obscure and difficult circumstances, that God could not leave them hidden.

You are not building a career. You are building a life. And the foundation of that life is the decision you make in the first days and weeks of your working years — the decision about whether you will do your work heartily, as for the Lord, or whether you will do it for men and settle for whatever men decide to give you.

Work for Him. He sees it. He rewards it. And He has never once overlooked a faithful man.

For Further Study

Read these passages carefully. Let them reshape how you think about Monday morning:

- Colossians 3:23–24 — The full context of Paul's instruction about work
- Genesis 2:15 — God's original design for man and work
- Genesis 39:1–6 — Joseph's faithfulness in Potiphar's house and in prison
- Daniel 6:1–5 — Daniel's work ethic under pagan kings
- Luke 16:10 — Faithful in little, faithful in much
- 1 Thessalonians 4:11–12 — Make it your ambition to lead a quiet life
- Proverbs 6:6–11 — The ant and the sluggard

- Proverbs 22:29 — The skilled man who stands before kings
- Zechariah 4:10 — Do not despise the day of small things

* * *

One Question to Sit With

If your boss, your teacher, your coach, or anyone who oversees your work were to describe your work ethic in three words — what would they say? And would those words reflect a man who works as for the Lord?

* * *

One Thing to Do

Pick one task this week — the one you're most tempted to do halfway — and do it with everything you have. Not for the grade. Not for the paycheck. Not for the recognition. Do it as though God Himself were the one checking your work — because according to Colossians 3:23, He is.

"Do you see a man skilled in his work? He will stand before kings; he will not stand before obscure men."

— Proverbs 22:29 (NASB)

CHAPTER 12

Money Will Test Your Character

Part Four: How You Build a Life

*"For the love of money is a root of all
sorts of evil"*

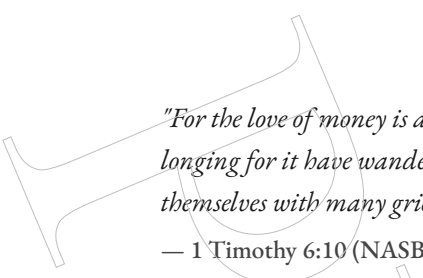
— 1 Timothy 6:10 (NASB)

You are about to start earning money. Real money. Not birthday money from a grandparent, not a few dollars for mowing a neighbor's lawn, but a paycheck with your name on it. Money you earned. Money that is yours. And the moment that money hits your hand, something will begin happening inside you that you need to be prepared for.

Money will start talking to you.

It will tell you what you deserve. It will tell you what you've earned. It will tell you what you need — and the list of things it calls needs will grow every single month. It will whisper that the man with more is the man who matters more, and that the fastest way to feel like somebody is to look like somebody. It will promise you freedom and then slowly, quietly, chain you to the things you bought with it.

Money is not evil. Let's be clear about that from the start. The Bible never says money is evil. What the Bible says is something far more precise — and far more dangerous:



"For the love of money is a root of all sorts of evil, and some by longing for it have wandered away from the faith and pierced themselves with many griefs."

— 1 Timothy 6:10 (NASB)

The *love* of money. Not the possession of it. Not the earning of it. The love of it. The moment money moves from being a tool in your hand to being an affection in your heart, it becomes the most destructive force in your life. And the most dangerous thing about that shift is how quietly it happens. No man wakes up one morning and decides to love money. It happens one purchase at a time. One comparison at a time. One small compromise at a time, until the man who thought he was using money discovers that money has been using him.

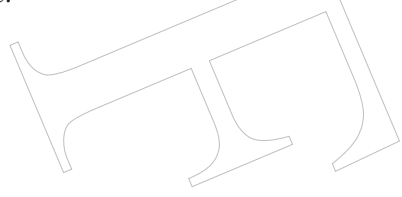
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You Cannot Serve Both

Jesus addressed money more than almost any other subject. More than prayer. More than heaven. More than the end times. He talked about money constantly — because He knew what it does to the human heart. And on this subject, He drew a line that could not be any clearer:

"No one can serve two masters; for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and wealth."

— Matthew 6:24 (NASB)



You cannot. Not you should not. Not it would be better if you did not. You cannot. It is an impossibility. Jesus is saying that money demands the same thing God demands — your whole heart. And since no heart can be given wholly to two masters, every man will eventually have to choose which one sits on the throne of his life.

This does not mean you cannot have money and serve God. Abraham was wealthy. Job was wealthy. David was a king. The issue is never how much you have. The issue is how much it has you.

The man who can hold money with an open hand — who can earn it honestly, give it generously, spend it wisely, and let it go when it needs to go — is a man who has money in the right place. The man who holds money with a closed fist, who panics at the thought of losing it, who measures his worth by the size of his account, who cannot give without calculating what he gets in return — that man is serving money whether he admits it or not.

The test is not whether you have money. The test is what you do with it.

* * *

The Warning From the Richest Man Who Ever Lived

This book has returned to Solomon again and again, and there is a reason for that: Solomon tested every theory about life that a human being could possibly test. He had unlimited resources. He pursued wisdom, pleasure, achievement, and wealth — all of it, in quantities

no one before or since has matched. And his conclusion about money should be carved into the wall of every young man's bedroom:

"He who loves money will not be satisfied with money, nor he who loves abundance with its income. This too is vanity."

— Ecclesiastes 5:10 (NASB)

He who loves money will not be satisfied with money. That is not a theory. That is a report from the field, delivered by the man with the largest data set in human history. Solomon is telling you that the promise money makes — the promise that more will be enough — is a lie. It has always been a lie. The man who makes fifty thousand wants a hundred. The man who makes a hundred wants two hundred. The man who makes a million finds that a million feels like less than he thought it would, and so he chases two.

The hunger never stops. Not because the man does not have enough, but because money has become his god — and that god never says "enough."

Solomon also observed something about wealth that will matter to you very practically in the coming years:

"When good things increase, those who consume them increase. So what is the advantage to their owners except to look on?"

— Ecclesiastes 5:11 (NASB)

The more you make, the more people and things there are to consume it. More income invites more expenses. A bigger paycheck funds a bigger lifestyle, which demands a bigger paycheck, which funds a bigger lifestyle. Solomon saw this cycle three thousand years ago. It has not changed. The man who does not learn to control his

spending when he earns a little will not control it when he earns a lot. He will simply spend more, owe more, and own more things that own him.

* * *

The Young Man Who Walked Away

There is a moment in the Gospels that is one of the most haunting scenes in all of Scripture, because it shows exactly what money can do to a man's heart — even a good man. A man who had done a lot of things right.

A young man came to Jesus. He was wealthy. He was moral. He had kept the commandments from his youth. He came with a sincere question: "What shall I do to inherit eternal life?" This was not a trap. This was a genuine seeker. And the text tells us something remarkable about how Jesus responded:

"Looking at him, Jesus felt a love for him and said to him, 'One thing you lack: go and sell all you possess and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow Me.'"

— Mark 10:21 (NASB)

Jesus *loved* this young man. He was not trying to punish him. He was not making a universal rule that every believer must sell everything. He was doing something far more personal: He was putting His finger on the one thing that stood between this young man and God. For this particular man, that thing was money. Money was the rival. Money sat on the throne. And Jesus, because He loved him, told him the truth.

The young man's response tells you everything:

"But at these words he was saddened, and he went away grieving, for he was one who owned much property."

— Mark 10:22 (NASB)

He walked away. From Jesus. From eternal life. From the invitation that every human being who has ever lived would give anything to receive. He walked away because he could not let go of his money.

He went away grieving. Not angry. Not defiant. Grieving. He knew he was making the wrong choice. He felt the weight of it. But the grip of wealth on his heart was stronger than his desire for God, and he could not break free.

Every man has a throne in his heart. Money will always apply for the seat.

The question this young man forces every reader to ask is simple: Is there anything in my life that I could not let go of if God asked me to? If the answer is your bank account, your lifestyle, your plans for what you want to own and earn and accumulate — then you know where the battle is. And the time to fight it is now, while the amounts are small and the habits are still forming.

* * *

What Faithful Stewardship Looks Like

The Bible does not teach that money is bad and poverty is holy. It teaches that money is a trust. It belongs to God. You are managing it

on His behalf. And one day, you will give an account of how you managed it.

In the last chapter, we looked at Jesus' words in Luke 16:10 about faithfulness in little things. The very next verses apply that principle directly to money:

"Therefore if you have not been faithful in the use of unrighteous wealth, who will entrust the true riches to you? And if you have not been faithful in the use of that which is another's, who will give you that which is your own?"

— Luke 16:11–12 (NASB)

Jesus calls money *unrighteous wealth* — not because earning money is sinful, but because money belongs to the passing world. It is temporary. It is lesser. And how you handle this lesser thing reveals whether you can be trusted with the greater things — the true riches, the eternal things, the things that actually matter.

Faithful stewardship is not complicated, but it does require discipline. It means living within your means. It means spending less than you earn. It means giving first, saving second, and spending last — not the other way around.

Give First

The first and most important financial decision you will ever make is this: give before you do anything else. This is not a suggestion from a self-help book. It is a principle established by God from the earliest pages of Scripture:

"Honor the Lord from your wealth and from the first of all your produce; so your barns will be filled with plenty and your vats will overflow with new wine."

— Proverbs 3:9–10 (NASB)

From the *first* of all your produce. Not the leftovers. Not what remains after you have taken care of yourself. The first portion. God asks for the first because the first is where your trust is revealed. The man who gives from the top is declaring, with his wallet, that God comes before his own comfort. The man who gives from what is left over — if there is anything left over — is declaring that God gets the scraps.

Generosity is not something you grow into when you can afford it. If you cannot be generous with a little, you will not be generous with a lot. That is not a guess. That is a promise baked into human nature. The habit of generosity must be established now, while the first paychecks are arriving, while the amounts feel small, while you are forming the patterns that will govern the rest of your financial life.

Avoid the Trap of Debt

The culture you are walking into will hand you credit before you have the wisdom to use it. Credit cards will arrive. Financing offers will appear. The ability to buy things you cannot afford will be presented to you as normal, expected, even smart. It is none of those things.

"The rich rules over the poor, and the borrower becomes the lender's slave."

— Proverbs 22:7 (NASB)

The borrower becomes the lender's *slave*. Solomon chose that word deliberately. Debt does not feel like slavery when you sign the papers. It feels like freedom — the freedom to have now what you cannot yet afford. But the payments come every month. And every month, a portion of the money you worked for — the money we talked about in the last chapter, the money earned heartily as for the Lord — goes to pay for something you already consumed. You are working for yesterday instead of building for tomorrow.

There will be times in your life when borrowing is necessary or wise — a home, an education in some cases, a genuine investment. But the casual, thoughtless accumulation of debt for things you want but do not need is one of the most common traps that robs young men of their freedom, their options, and their peace of mind.

A man who owes nothing to anyone can make decisions that a man in debt cannot. He can take the job that pays less but matters more. He can give generously when a need appears. He can walk away from a situation that compromises his integrity, because he is not chained to a payment schedule that demands he stay. Debt removes options. Freedom preserves them.

Learn Contentment

There is a word in the New Testament that the modern world has almost completely abandoned, and it may be the single most important financial skill a young man can develop:

"But godliness actually is a means of great gain when accompanied by contentment. For we have brought nothing into the world, so we cannot take anything out of it either. If we have food and covering, with these we shall be content."

— 1 Timothy 6:6–8 (NASB)

Contentment. Not complacency. Not laziness. Not the absence of ambition. Contentment is the settled confidence that what God has provided is sufficient. It is the ability to look at what you have and say "this is enough" — not because you have stopped working, but because you have stopped letting the culture define what enough means.

The world around you is spending billions of dollars every year to make sure you are never content. Every advertisement, every social media post from someone who appears to have more, every algorithm designed to show you what you do not yet own — all of it exists to create a sense of lack. To make you feel that what you have is not enough, that who you are is not enough, that you need more in order to be more.

Paul, who wrote those words about contentment, was not a man of comfort. He had been beaten, shipwrecked, imprisoned, hungry, and cold. He wrote some of his most powerful letters from a jail cell. And from that cell he wrote:

"I have learned to be content in whatever circumstances I am. I know how to get along with humble means, and I also know how to live in prosperity; in any and every circumstance I have learned the secret of being filled and going hungry, both of having abundance and suffering need."

— Philippians 4:11–12 (NASB)

Notice the word *learned*. Contentment was not natural for Paul. It is not natural for any man. It is learned. It is a discipline, built over time, strengthened by practice, and anchored in the conviction that God is more than enough even when the bank account says otherwise.

* * *

What Money Reveals About You

Here is the deepest truth this chapter can offer you: money does not change a man. It reveals him.

Give a generous man more money and he will be more generous. Give a selfish man more money and he will be more selfish. Give a man of integrity more resources and he will use them with integrity. Give a man without self-control more resources and he will destroy himself faster.

This is why it matters so much that you settle these questions now, before the amounts get large. Who are you with a hundred dollars? Because that is exactly who you will be with a hundred thousand. The scale changes. The man does not.

We talked in Chapter 2 about the heart — the inner man, the seat of motive and will, the place God looks when He evaluates a man. Your financial life is one of the clearest windows into that heart. How you earn reveals your integrity. How you spend reveals your priorities. How you give reveals your faith. And how you hold it all — with an open hand or a clenched fist — reveals who is actually sitting on the throne.

"For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also."

— Matthew 6:21 (NASB)

Where your treasure is. Not where your mouth is. Not where your Sunday morning is. Where your treasure is. Jesus knew that a man's money follows his heart, and his heart follows his money. They travel together. And if you want to know what you truly value — not what you say you value, but what you actually value — look at your bank statement. It will tell you the truth your words may not.

* * *

The Man Who Holds It All With Open Hands

The young man who gets this right — who earns honestly, gives first, avoids the trap of debt, learns contentment, and holds his money with open hands — will be a man of extraordinary freedom. Not because he has more than others, but because what he has does not have him.

Joseph managed the wealth of an entire empire and remained faithful. Daniel served in the richest courts on earth and was never corrupted by them. Abraham was blessed abundantly and gave generously, including offering his own son on the altar because he trusted God more than he trusted his blessings.

These were not men who avoided money. They were men who refused to let money avoid God. Every dollar, every resource, every opportunity was held under the authority of the One who provided it. And because they held it that way, God could trust them with more.

You are at the beginning. The paychecks are just starting. The financial habits are just forming. The decisions you make right now — this month, this year, in the first chapter of your working life — will establish patterns that will either serve you for decades or enslave you for decades.

Work heartily, as we talked about in the last chapter. And then take what that work produces and hold it the way a steward holds his master's property: carefully, faithfully, generously, and always with the understanding that none of it is really yours.

It all belongs to Him. And a man who knows that is the richest man in any room.

* * *

For Further Study

These passages will shape how you handle money for the rest of your life. Read them slowly:

- 1 Timothy 6:6–12 — Contentment, the love of money, and the grief it causes
- Matthew 6:19–24 — Treasure, the heart, and the two masters
- Mark 10:17–27 — The rich young man who walked away from Jesus
- Proverbs 3:9–10 — Honor the Lord with the first of your wealth
- Proverbs 22:7 — The borrower becomes the lender's slave

- Ecclesiastes 5:10–15 — The vanity of loving money
- Philippians 4:11–13 — Paul's secret of contentment in every circumstance
- Luke 16:10–13 — Faithful in little, faithful in much

* * *

"For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also."

— Matthew 6:21 (NASB)

The Church Is Not Optional

Part Four: How You Build a Life

*"And let us consider how to stimulate
one another to love and good deeds,
not forsaking our own assembling
together"*

— Hebrews 10:24-25 (NASB)

At some point in the last few years — maybe gradually, maybe all at once — you started hearing a version of this idea: "I don't need church. I can have a relationship with God on my own. I can read my Bible at home, pray on my own time, listen to a podcast, and be just fine spiritually without sitting in a building every week."

It sounds reasonable. It sounds mature, even. Like a man who has moved past the rituals and gotten to the real thing.

It is also exactly wrong.

Not because the building matters. Not because the ritual matters. Not because some denomination has a monopoly on God. It is wrong because God Himself designed something specific, something intentional, something that cannot be replaced by private devotion alone — and He called it the church. Not a building. Not

an institution. Not a brand or a tradition or a style of music. A body. His body. And He did not make membership in that body optional.

This chapter is not going to tell you which church to attend. It is not going to argue for one denomination over another. What it is going to do is show you what the Scriptures actually say about the church — what God designed it to be, why He designed it that way, and why the young man who walks away from it is walking away from something he cannot afford to lose.

* * *

What the Church Actually Is

The English word "church" translates the Greek word *ekklesia*, which means "the called-out ones" — an assembly of people who have been called out of the world and gathered together for a purpose. In the New Testament, the church is never a building. It is never a program. It is always people. Specifically, it is the people who belong to Christ, gathered together under His authority, functioning as one body.

Paul gave the most complete picture of what this looks like:

"For even as the body is one and yet has many members, and all the members of the body, though they are many, are one body, so also is Christ. For by one Spirit we were all baptized into one body."

— 1 Corinthians 12:12–13 (NASB)

One body. Many members. That is not a metaphor for convenience. That is God's design for how His people function. Just as your physical body cannot function with isolated parts — an eye detached from the body does not see, a hand disconnected from the arm does not work — a Christian disconnected from the body of Christ cannot function the way God designed him to.

Paul pressed this further, and what he wrote should put an end to the idea that any man can go it alone:

"The eye cannot say to the hand, 'I have no need of you'; or again the head to the feet, 'I have no need of you.' . . . But God has so composed the body . . . so that there may be no division in the body, but that the members may have the same care for one another."

— 1 Corinthians 12:21, 24–25 (NASB)

I have no need of you. That is exactly what the man who leaves the church is saying — whether he uses those words or not. He is saying to the body of Christ: I do not need you. I can function alone. And Paul, writing under the inspiration of the Holy Spirit, says God Himself composed the body so that no member could rightly say that. God designed it so that you need other believers and they need you.

You were not designed to follow Christ alone. No one was.

* * *

What the First Church Looked Like

If you want to see what God intended when He established the church, the clearest picture is in the book of Acts. Weeks after Jesus rose from the dead and ascended to heaven, the Holy Spirit came upon the apostles at Pentecost, the gospel was preached, thousands responded, and the first church was born.

The text tells us exactly what they did:

"They were continually devoting themselves to the apostles' teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer."

— Acts 2:42 (NASB)

Four things. The apostles' teaching. Fellowship. The breaking of bread. Prayer. That is the pattern. It is not complicated. It is not a production. It is not a light show or an entertainment experience or a brand. It is people who belong to Christ gathering together to learn His Word, to share life with one another, to worship Him at His table, and to pray.

As the rest of the New Testament unfolds, other passages fill out this picture further. The gathered church also sang together and gave of their resources to support the work. The full pattern of New Testament worship is simple but specific — and every part of it was established by apostolic teaching and example, not by human tradition.

The passage continues with what that pattern produced:

"Day by day continuing with one mind in the temple, and breaking bread from house to house, they were taking their meals together with gladness and sincerity of heart, praising God and having favor with all the people. And the Lord was adding to their number day by day those who were being saved."

— Acts 2:46–47 (NASB)

The Lord was adding. Not a marketing campaign. Not a clever strategy. The Lord was adding to their number, because what these people had together was so clearly real, so clearly different from everything the world was offering, that people were drawn to it.

That is what the church is supposed to be. And when it is what it is supposed to be, it is the most powerful thing on earth — because the Head of it is Jesus Christ.

* * *

Why Young Men Leave

It would not be honest to write a chapter about the church without acknowledging something that you probably already know or have already felt: a lot of young men your age are walking away from it. And they have reasons.

Some leave because the church they grew up in felt more like a social club than a serious pursuit of truth. They sat through years of programs and events and activities that never once opened a Bible and expected them to wrestle with what it says.

Some leave because they saw hypocrisy. They watched adults say one thing on Sunday and live another way the rest of the week, and they decided the whole thing was a performance.

Some leave because they were never given real answers to real questions. They asked hard things and were told not to ask. They brought doubts and were met with clichés. They needed substance and were given sentiment.

And some leave simply because it is easier. Sunday morning is the one morning you can sleep in. The screen offers a hundred alternatives that ask nothing of you and entertain you instantly. Leaving church is the path of least resistance in a culture that has already told you church is outdated, irrelevant, and unnecessary.

Every one of those reasons deserves a response. And the response is not to dismiss them.

The failures of the church are real. But the design of the church is God's.

Here is the distinction that matters: men have failed the church. The church as God designed it has not failed men. Every flaw you can point to in a local congregation is a flaw in the people, not in the blueprint. And walking away from God's design because people failed to live up to it is like refusing to eat because someone once served you a bad meal. The problem was not the food. The problem was the cook.

The answer to a church that has not been what it should be is not to abandon the church. It is to find one that takes the Word of God seriously and be part of making it what God designed it to be. That might be the hardest thing this chapter asks of you. It is also the most important.

* * *

What the Church Gives You That Nothing Else Can

There are things the church provides that cannot be replicated anywhere else. Not in a podcast. Not in a small group that never connects to a larger body. Not in private devotion, as important as private devotion is. The church offers things that are irreplaceable by design.

The Teaching of God's Word

We talked in Chapter 6 about the Bible and how to read it. But God's design for how His Word is delivered to His people has always included preaching and teaching within the gathered assembly. Paul told Timothy:

"Preach the word; be ready in season and out of season; reprove, rebuke, exhort, with great patience and instruction."

— 2 Timothy 4:2 (NASB)

Preaching is not a nice option for people who prefer it. It is God's appointed means of delivering truth to His people. The man who sits under faithful teaching week after week is being shaped by that teaching in ways he often does not recognize until years later. It builds a framework of biblical understanding that informs every decision he makes. Remove it, and the framework weakens. Ignore it long enough, and it collapses.

Accountability

In Chapter 9, we talked about the friends who sharpen you. The church is where those friendships are most naturally formed

and most effectively maintained — because the church puts men around you who share your convictions and who have the right and the responsibility to hold you accountable.

"And let us consider how to stimulate one another to love and good deeds, not forsaking our own assembling together, as is the habit of some, but encouraging one another; and all the more as you see the day drawing near."

— Hebrews 10:24–25 (NASB)

Not forsaking our own assembling together. The Holy Spirit, through the writer of Hebrews, anticipated that some believers would drift away. He called it a habit — because it starts small. You miss one week. Then two. Then a month. Then missing feels more normal than going. And the man who drifted away from the assembly has also drifted away from the accountability, the encouragement, and the stimulation to love and good deeds that the assembly was designed to provide.

A man without accountability is a man without walls. We have used that image from Proverbs 25:28 throughout this book, and it applies here with full force. The church is one of the primary walls God put around you. Remove it, and you are exposed — to the culture, to temptation, to the slow drift that this book has warned you about in chapter after chapter.

The Lord's Supper

Jesus, on the night He was betrayed, did something that He commanded His followers to continue doing until He returns. He took bread and a cup, and He gave them to His disciples:

"This is My body, which is for you; do this in remembrance of Me . . . This cup is the new covenant in My blood; do this, as often as you drink it, in remembrance of Me."

— 1 Corinthians 11:24–25 (NASB)

The Lord's Supper is not a private act. Paul's instructions in 1 Corinthians 11 are addressed to the gathered church. It is an act of communal worship, of shared remembrance, of proclaiming the Lord's death together until He comes. A man who walks away from the assembly walks away from the table. And the table is not optional — Jesus said "do this."

Singing

When the early church gathered, they sang. Not as a warm-up act for the sermon. Not as entertainment. As worship — and as something they did for one another. Paul described it in two letters:

"Speaking to one another in psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing and making melody with your heart to the Lord."

— Ephesians 5:19 (NASB)

"Let the word of Christ richly dwell within you, with all wisdom teaching and admonishing one another with psalms and hymns and spiritual songs, singing with thankfulness in your hearts to God."

— Colossians 3:16 (NASB)

Notice what those passages say. Singing in the church is not just vertical — directed at God — though it is certainly that. It is also horizontal. You are speaking to one another. You are teaching and

admonishing one another. When the church lifts its voice together, something happens that a playlist in your earbuds cannot replicate: the Word of Christ dwells richly among a gathered body, and each voice strengthens the others.

Paul also wrote in 1 Corinthians 14:15, "I will sing with the spirit and I will sing with the mind also." Singing in the assembly is intentional. It engages the mind and the heart. And it is something every believer participates in — not a performance by a few, but the united voice of the whole body.

Giving

God's design for the church includes its members giving of their financial resources to support the work. This is not a gimmick or a fundraising strategy. It is a pattern established by apostolic instruction:

"On the first day of every week each one of you is to put aside and save, as he may prosper, so that no collections be made when I come."

— 1 Corinthians 16:1–2 (NASB)

Notice the specifics. On the first day of every week — when the church gathered. Each one of you — not just the wealthy, not just the established, but every member. As he may prosper — proportional, personal, and purposeful. This was not an afterthought bolted onto the worship. It was woven into it.

Paul wrote extensively to the Corinthian church about the heart behind giving:

"Each one must do just as he has purposed in his heart, not grudgingly or under compulsion, for God loves a cheerful giver."

— 2 Corinthians 9:7 (NASB)

Giving is an act of trust. It is a young man looking at what God has provided and deciding, before he spends a dollar on himself, to set something aside for the work of the church. It is not about the amount. It is about the heart. And a man who gives cheerfully, purposefully, and consistently is a man who has learned something that most of the world never figures out: everything he has came from God in the first place, and using it for God's purposes is not a loss. It is an investment in something eternal.

A Place to Serve

The body of Christ is not an audience. It is an organism. Every member has a function. Every member has a gift. And those gifts were given not for personal enrichment, but for the building up of the body:

"As each one has received a special gift, employ it in serving one another as good stewards of the manifold grace of God."

— 1 Peter 4:10 (NASB)

You have something the body needs. Not someday, when you are older or more experienced or more mature. Now. The church needs what God has given you, and you need the exercise of serving others to grow into the man God is making you. A muscle that is never used does not grow. It atrophies. The gifts God gave you will do the

same if they are never put to work in the body they were designed to serve.

* * *

Finding a Church That Takes the Word Seriously

This chapter is not an endorsement of every church on every corner. Not every congregation that puts a sign out front is doing what God designed the church to do. And part of becoming a man of faith is learning to evaluate a church the same way this book has taught you to evaluate everything else: by what the Scriptures actually say.

When you look for a church, look for these things:

- Is the Bible being taught faithfully — not just referenced, but opened, read, and explained in context? The apostles' teaching was the first thing the early church devoted itself to. If a church does not take the Word seriously, nothing else it does will matter.
- Is the church following the pattern of the New Testament? Does it practice the Lord's Supper as Jesus commanded? Does it practice baptism as the apostles taught? Does it gather to sing, to pray, to give, to encourage one another? A church that has replaced the New Testament pattern with something of its own invention has replaced God's design with man's preference.
- Are the people there serious about living what they teach? Not perfect — no church is perfect because no person is perfect. But serious. Are the men in that congregation the kind of men who would sharpen you? Are they the kind of friends we talked about in Chapter 9?

- Does the leadership submit to the authority of Scripture, even when the culture pressures them to do otherwise? A church that changes its message to match the culture is a church that has traded its foundation for applause. Daniel did not bow. Neither should the church.

You may not find a church that does everything perfectly. You will not, in fact, because churches are made of people and people are flawed. But you can find a church that takes the Word of God seriously and is genuinely striving to follow the pattern God established. That church is worth your time, your commitment, and your presence — even when it is imperfect.

They Did Not Stand Alone

One final time, consider Daniel and his three friends. They stood in Babylon. They stood against the most powerful empire on earth. They stood when bowing would have been easy and standing could have killed them.

But they stood together.

When Daniel purposed not to defile himself with the king's food, Hananiah, Mishael, and Azariah stood with him. When the golden statue demanded worship and the furnace was lit, Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego walked in together. Even Daniel's famous moment in the lions' den came after decades of living within a

community of men who shared his convictions and reinforced his faithfulness.

God did not design one man to carry the weight of faithfulness alone. He designed a body. He designed a family. He designed a church — a community of believers who sharpen one another, hold one another accountable, teach one another, serve one another, sing together, give together, break bread together, pray together, and stand together when the world says to bow.

You need that community. And that community needs you.

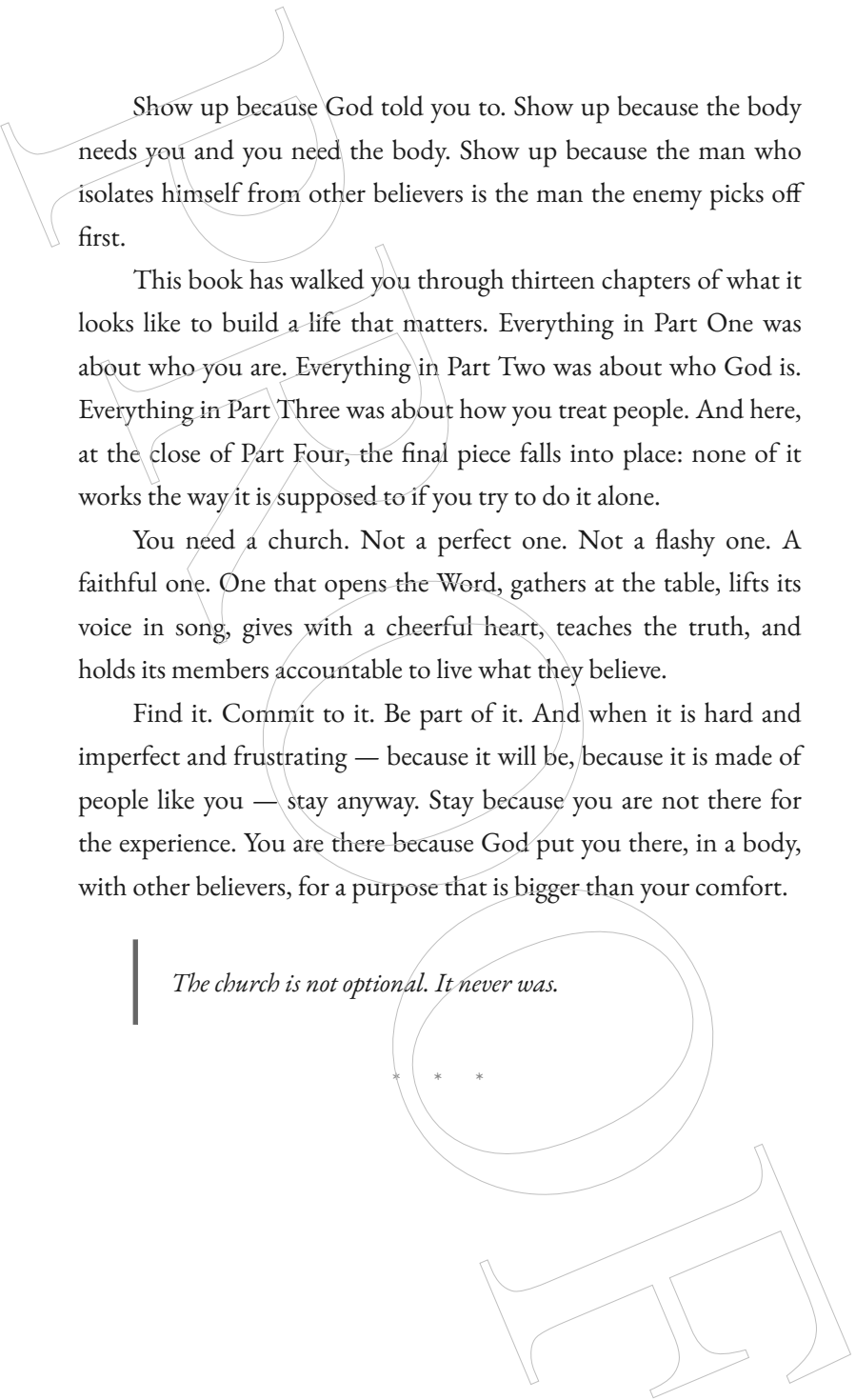
The man who tries to follow Christ without the church is a soldier who has left his unit. He may have courage. He may have conviction. But he has removed himself from the structure God designed to protect him, strengthen him, and deploy him. And the enemy knows it.

* * *

Show Up

This is the simplest instruction in this chapter, and it may be the hardest: show up.

Show up on Sunday when you are tired. Show up when you would rather sleep in. Show up when the game is on and the weather is nice and a dozen things are competing for your morning. Show up when you do not feel like it, because the man who only shows up when he feels like it will eventually stop showing up at all.



Show up because God told you to. Show up because the body needs you and you need the body. Show up because the man who isolates himself from other believers is the man the enemy picks off first.

This book has walked you through thirteen chapters of what it looks like to build a life that matters. Everything in Part One was about who you are. Everything in Part Two was about who God is. Everything in Part Three was about how you treat people. And here, at the close of Part Four, the final piece falls into place: none of it works the way it is supposed to if you try to do it alone.

You need a church. Not a perfect one. Not a flashy one. A faithful one. One that opens the Word, gathers at the table, lifts its voice in song, gives with a cheerful heart, teaches the truth, and holds its members accountable to live what they believe.

Find it. Commit to it. Be part of it. And when it is hard and imperfect and frustrating — because it will be, because it is made of people like you — stay anyway. Stay because you are not there for the experience. You are there because God put you there, in a body, with other believers, for a purpose that is bigger than your comfort.

The church is not optional. It never was.

* * *

For Further Study

Read these passages and see the church as God designed it — not as the world has sometimes distorted it:

- 1 Corinthians 12:12–27 — The body of Christ and why every member matters
- Acts 2:42–47 — The first church and what they devoted themselves to
- Hebrews 10:24–25 — The command not to forsake the assembly
- 2 Timothy 4:1–5 — Preach the word in season and out of season
- Ephesians 5:19 — Singing to God and to one another in the assembly
- Colossians 3:16 — Let the word of Christ dwell richly among you
- 1 Corinthians 11:23–26 — The Lord's Supper and its meaning
- 1 Corinthians 16:1–2 — Giving purposefully and cheerfully
- 2 Corinthians 9:6–8 — God loves a cheerful giver
- 1 Peter 4:10–11 — Using your gifts to serve the body

* * *

"They were continually devoting themselves to the apostles' teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer."

— Acts 2:42 (NASB)

CONCLUSION

Your Move

*"Choose for yourselves today whom you
will serve... but as for me and my house,
we will serve the LORD."*

— Joshua 24:15 (NASB)

Choose for yourselves *today*.

Not tomorrow. Not when life settles down. Not when you feel ready. Not after you have had your fun. Today. Joshua understood something that every generation needs to hear: the decision to serve God is not a decision that waits for a convenient moment. It is a decision that demands an answer now, because every day you do not choose is a day the world chooses for you.

Joshua did not beg them. He did not manipulate them. He stated his own position clearly — as for me and my house, we will serve the Lord — and then he put the decision in their hands.

This book is doing the same thing. The decision is yours.

* * *

The Story That Changes Everything

Before you can make that decision well, you need to understand clearly what God has done. Not religion. Not tradition. Not what

some church told you or what you vaguely picked up from culture. What God Himself has done — according to His own Word.

Here it is, as plainly as it can be said.

God made you. He made you on purpose, for a purpose, in His image. We talked about that in the first four chapters of this book. You are not an accident. You are not a product of blind chance. You were designed, intentionally, by a God who knew your name before you were born.

"For You formed my inward parts; You wove me in my mother's womb. I will give thanks to You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made."

— Psalm 139:13–14 (NASB)

But something went wrong. Not with God. With us. From the very beginning of human history, man chose his own way over God's way. Adam and Eve were given everything and told to trust God on one point — and they chose not to. And that choice — the Bible calls it sin — broke the relationship between God and man. It entered the human race like a disease, and every person since has been infected by it.

"For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God."

— Romans 3:23 (NASB)

All. Not most. Not the especially bad ones. All. That includes you. It includes every person who has ever lived. And the consequence of that sin is not a slap on the wrist. It is death — separation from the God who made you:

"For the wages of sin is death."

— Romans 6:23a (NASB)

That is the problem. And it is a problem no human being can solve. You cannot be good enough to erase it. You cannot work hard enough to overcome it. You cannot donate enough, volunteer enough, or behave well enough to bridge the gap that sin has created between you and God. Every religion that tells you otherwise is asking you to build a ladder to heaven with broken materials. It cannot be done.

So God did it Himself.

"But God demonstrates His own love toward us, in that while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us."

— Romans 5:8 (NASB)

While we were yet sinners. Not after we cleaned ourselves up. Not after we proved we deserved it. While we were still guilty, still broken, still separated from Him — God sent His Son, Jesus Christ, into the world. Jesus lived the perfect life that no human being has ever lived. He fulfilled every commandment. He never sinned — not once, not in thought, not in deed, not in a single moment of His entire life. And then He went to a cross and died, voluntarily, taking on Himself the punishment that belonged to you and to me.

That is not a metaphor. That is not religious poetry. That is what happened. The Son of God was nailed to a cross, bled, suffocated, and died — and the reason He did it was to pay the debt that your sin created. A debt you could not pay. A debt no human effort could cover. He paid it in full.

"He made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, so that we might become the righteousness of God in Him."

— 2 Corinthians 5:21 (NASB)

And then, three days later, He rose from the dead. Not symbolically. Not in the hearts of His followers. Physically, bodily, actually — He walked out of that tomb. He was seen by the apostles. He was seen by more than five hundred people at one time. He ate with them. He spoke with them. He showed them His hands and His side. And then He ascended to the right hand of God the Father, where He sits right now, as Lord of everything.

"...that Christ died for our sins according to the Scriptures, and that He was buried, and that He was raised on the third day according to the Scriptures, and that He appeared to Cephas, then to the twelve. After that He appeared to more than five hundred brethren at one time."

— 1 Corinthians 15:3–6 (NASB)

That is the Gospel. That is the good news. God solved the problem you could not solve. He bridged the gap you could not bridge. He paid the price you could not pay. And He offers the result — forgiveness, a restored relationship with God, and eternal life — as a free gift to anyone who will receive it.

* * *

What He Asks of You

The Gospel is free, but it is not passive. It requires a response. And the New Testament is clear about what that response looks like.

Believe

First, you must believe. Not a vague, general belief that God probably exists. A specific, personal trust that Jesus Christ is the Son of God, that He died for your sins, and that God raised Him from the dead.

"...if you confess with your mouth Jesus as Lord, and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved."

— Romans 10:9 (NASB)

Believe in your heart. That is not intellectual agreement. That is trust. The same kind of trust that Shadrach, Meshach, and Abednego had when they said "Our God is able to deliver us . . . but even if He does not." It is a trust that stakes everything on the truth of who Jesus is and what He has done.

Repent

Second, you must repent. Repentance means to change your mind — to turn around. It means you stop walking in the direction you have been walking and you turn toward God. It means you acknowledge that your way has not worked, that your sin is real, and that you need what only He can give.

"Repent, and each of you be baptized in the name of Jesus Christ for the forgiveness of your sins; and you will receive the gift of the Holy Spirit."

— Acts 2:38 (NASB)

This is what Peter preached on the day the church was born. Thousands of people heard the Gospel that day, and when they asked "What shall we do?" Peter did not say "Just believe in your heart and you're fine." He said repent and be baptized. Both.

Confess

Third, you must confess. Not confess your sins to a priest. Confess Jesus as Lord. Say it out loud. Declare it publicly. The same verse from Romans 10:9 says to confess with your mouth Jesus as Lord. Faith is not a private, silent, internal thing that never shows itself. It is declared. It is spoken. It is a public identification with the One who died for you.

Be Baptized

Fourth, you must be baptized. Baptism is not a church ritual that some denominations practice and others skip. It is a command from Jesus Himself:

"Go therefore and make disciples of all the nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father and the Son and the Holy Spirit."

— Matthew 28:19 (NASB)

In the New Testament, every single person who came to faith in Christ was baptized. There is not one example of an unbaptized believer in the book of Acts. When the Ethiopian eunuch heard the Gospel from Philip, his immediate response was "Look! Water! What prevents me from being baptized?" He did not wait. He did not schedule it for a convenient Sunday. He saw water and he acted.

Baptism is where you are buried with Christ and raised to walk in a new life. Paul described it this way:

"Or do you not know that all of us who have been baptized into Christ Jesus have been baptized into His death? Therefore we have been buried with Him through baptism into death, so that as Christ was raised from the dead through the glory of the Father, so we too might walk in newness of life."

— Romans 6:3–4 (NASB)

Buried with Him. Raised with Him. That is not symbolic language for something optional. That is the moment where the old man dies and the new man is born. That is where your new life begins.

Live It

And then, fifth — you live it. Every single chapter of this book has been about what that life looks like. Guard your name. Guard your heart. Stand when the world says bow. Seek God first. Read His Word. Put down the screen. Treat women with honor. Choose your friends with intention. Honor your parents. Work heartily as for the Lord. Hold your money with open hands. Commit to the church.

That is the life. Not a perfect life. Not a life without failure. But a life of direction, purpose, repentance, and growth — lived under the authority of the One who bought you with His blood and calls you His own.

* * *

The Decision

You are standing right now where Joshua's generation stood. The words have been spoken. The truth has been laid out. The evidence has been presented — not from human tradition, not from a denomination, not from popular opinion, but from the Word of God itself.

And now you choose.

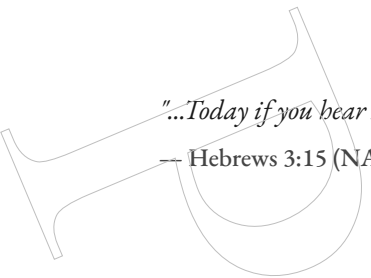
Nobody can make this decision for you. Your parents cannot make it for you. Your grandparents cannot make it for you, though they love you more than you know and want this for you more than you can imagine. Your friends cannot make it for you. Your church cannot make it for you. This is between you and God, and it is the most important decision you will ever face.

Choose for yourselves today whom you will serve.

If you choose to walk away — to close this book and go back to the life you were living before you opened it — that is your right. God will not force you. He never has. He will let you go, and the world will be happy to have you back.

But if something in these pages has spoken to you — if the Word of God has done what Hebrews 4:12 says it does, piercing as far as the division of soul and spirit, judging the thoughts and intentions of the heart — then do not ignore that. Do not set it aside and tell yourself you will deal with it later. Later is the lie the enemy has been selling since the garden of Eden. There is no guarantee of later.

Today is the day.



"...Today if you bear His voice, do not harden your hearts."

— Hebrews 3:15 (NASB)

* * *

Your Name Is Not Finished Yet

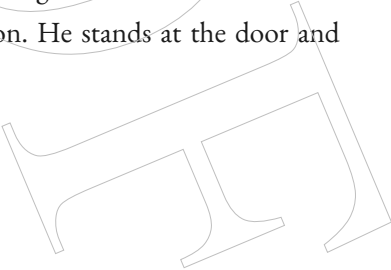
This book began with your name. It is going to end there too.

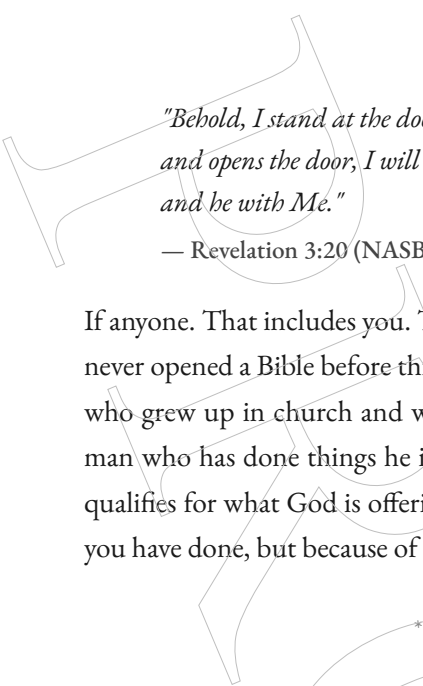
In the first chapter, you read about men whose names were changed by God — Abram to Abraham, Jacob to Israel, Simon to Peter. In every case, the new name was not a description of who they were. It was a declaration of who they would become. God looked at a childless old man and called him the father of nations. He looked at a schemer and called him one who strives with God. He looked at an impulsive fisherman and called him the rock.

Your name is not finished yet.

Whatever you have done up to this point — whatever is written in the story so far — does not have to be the final chapter. Peter denied Christ three times and went on to preach the sermon that launched the church. David committed adultery and murder and was still called a man after God's own heart — not because the sin did not matter, but because the repentance was real. Paul persecuted Christians and became the greatest missionary the world has ever known.

God is in the business of rewriting names. But He will not rewrite yours without your permission. He stands at the door and knocks. He does not break it down.

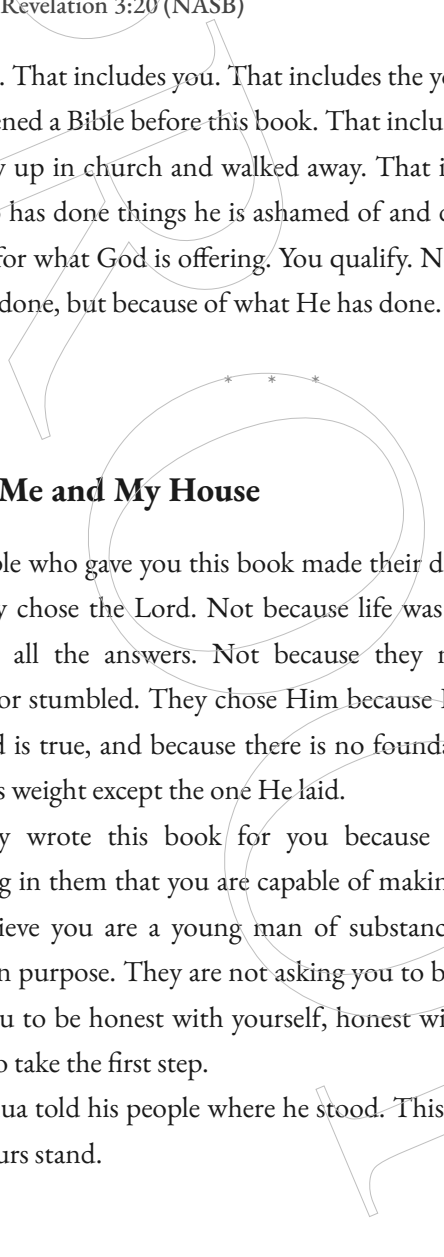




"Behold, I stand at the door and knock; if anyone hears My voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and will dine with him, and he with Me."

— Revelation 3:20 (NASB)

If anyone. That includes you. That includes the young man who has never opened a Bible before this book. That includes the young man who grew up in church and walked away. That includes the young man who has done things he is ashamed of and does not believe he qualifies for what God is offering. You qualify. Not because of what you have done, but because of what He has done.

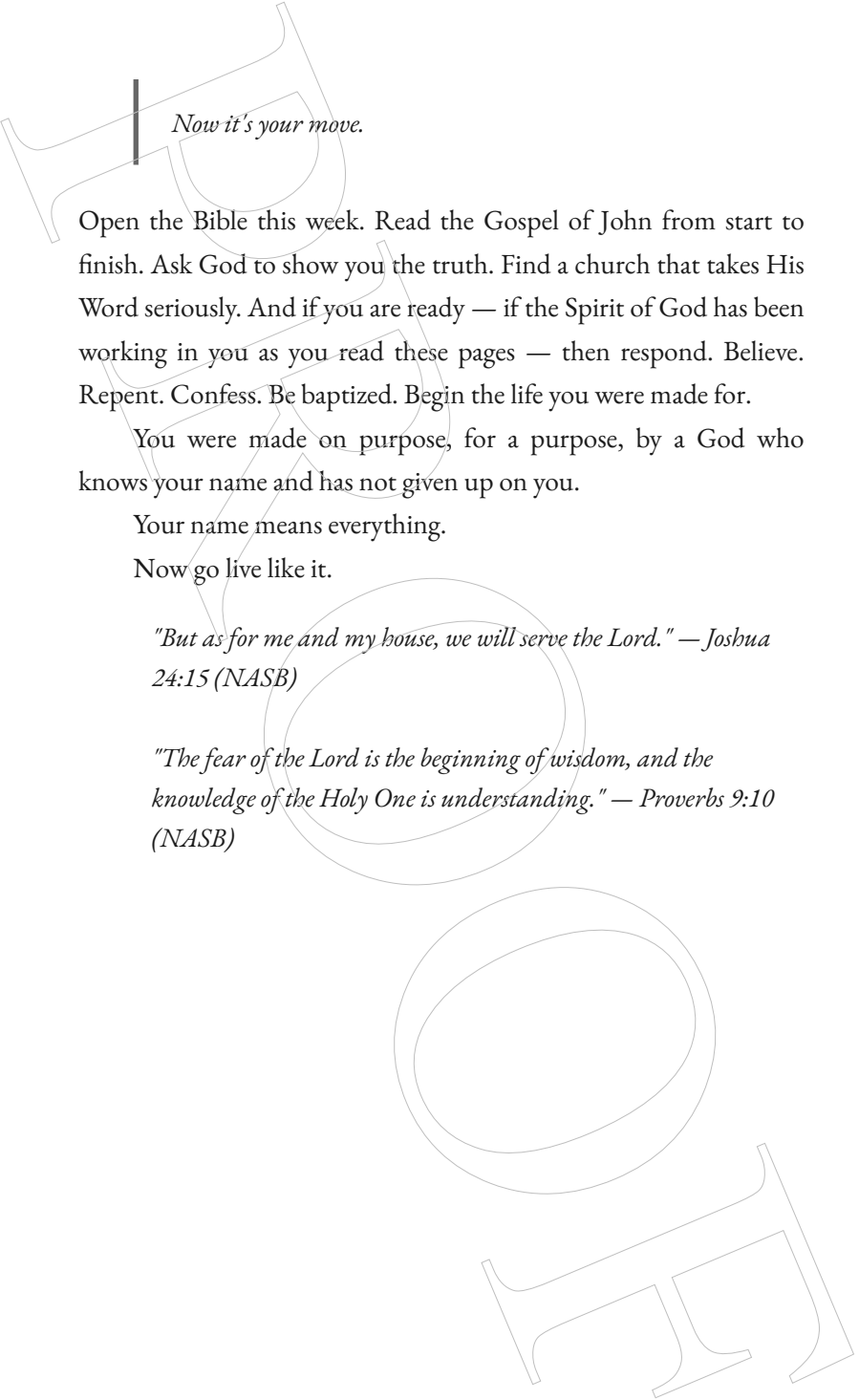


As For Me and My House

The people who gave you this book made their decision a long time ago. They chose the Lord. Not because life was easy. Not because they had all the answers. Not because they never struggled or doubted or stumbled. They chose Him because He is true, because His Word is true, and because there is no foundation in this world that holds weight except the one He laid.

They wrote this book for you because they believe with everything in them that you are capable of making the same choice. They believe you are a young man of substance, of potential, of God-given purpose. They are not asking you to be perfect. They are asking you to be honest with yourself, honest with God, and brave enough to take the first step.

Joshua told his people where he stood. This book has told you where yours stand.



Now it's your move.

Open the Bible this week. Read the Gospel of John from start to finish. Ask God to show you the truth. Find a church that takes His Word seriously. And if you are ready — if the Spirit of God has been working in you as you read these pages — then respond. Believe. Repent. Confess. Be baptized. Begin the life you were made for.

You were made on purpose, for a purpose, by a God who knows your name and has not given up on you.

Your name means everything.

Now go live like it.

"But as for me and my house, we will serve the Lord." — Joshua 24:15 (NASB)

"The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom, and the knowledge of the Holy One is understanding." — Proverbs 9:10 (NASB)

BOOKS



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Nobody told you this was coming.

You are standing at the beginning of your adult life in a world that offers everything except the truth you actually need.

This book is built on the Bible — not on opinions, not on trends, not on what sounds good at graduation.

It is a straight-talk guide through the questions that will define your life: who you are, who God is, how you treat people, and how you build something that lasts.

Thirteen chapters. One Foundation.

*“Choose for yourselves today
whom you will serve . . .
but as for me and my house,
we will serve the Lord.”*

JOSHUA 24:15

PAUL & PAM HAINLINE

